WITCH & WARD

A roleplaying game of witches, everyday life and the threat of the week

Richard Moore



TEST EDITION

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VERSION 0.9 (TEST EDITION)

GAME DESIGN & WRITING

Richard Moore

TYPEFACES

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PLAY IT ONLINE

Foundry VTT: the Witch & Ward game system

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PART ONE

Playing

How to make a witch or the guardian, roll the dice, cast spells and brew potions, follow a threat across Larkhaven and face it in the showdown. Everyone at the table should read this part.





CHAPTER 1

Welcome to Larkhaven

At the Friday night market in Old Town, a singer opens her mouth and nothing comes out. Across the city, a nurse finishes her shift, a student skips a lecture, and a bus driver takes the last run of the night. By morning all three will be on the trail of the thing that stole that voice. They are witches, and this is their city.

What this game is

Witch & Ward is a tabletop roleplaying game for 3–5 players and a **Storyteller**. Each player is a witch in **the coven**, or one player may play the coven's **guardian**. Together you protect innocent people from demons and other **threats** in Larkhaven, an invented harbour city.

It plays like an episode of a TV drama. Each session has a threat of the week, and an **innocent**: the person the threat wants. Around that runs witch life: jobs, family, friends, dates and rent. A witch can spend the night fighting a fire spirit and still have to explain to her boss why she's late. The game is often funny and sometimes frightening.

One session is one **episode**. Each episode works on its own. You can also string episodes into a **season**, where a little carries over from one to the next (Chapter 8).

What you need

FOR ONE EPISODE

- 3–5 players and one Storyteller.
- Six-sided dice. A shared pile of 13 covers every roll, even the biggest one: the Unmaking with five witches. In a season, once a witch has raised Craft to 4, that roll can need 14. A few dice each speeds things up.
- A witch sheet for each witch, the guardian sheet if someone plays the guardian, and an episode tracker for the Storyteller. They are at the back of this book.
- Pencils. Hurt, Magic and the tracks change all the time.
- 2–3 hours.

For your first game, use the six ready-made witches and the ready-made guardian, Rook (Chapter 13). Chapter 12 walks the Storyteller through the first night.

Tone

This is a supernatural drama with humour. Witch life, family and romance run alongside the threat of the week. Play the funny moments for laughs and the scary ones straight.

The game is for ages 13 and up. Threats can be frightening, but there is no gore. Deaths happen off the page: the story can say that someone died, but it doesn't show it. Nobody dies from the dice. A witch who is badly hurt goes **Down**, out of the fight, never dead. Romance is an optional story thread with no rules attached (Chapter 8).

Real faiths

Witchcraft and Wicca are living religions. Real people practise them today. The witches in this book are invented: their Powers, spells, potions and Book belong to this game, not to anyone's real practice.

- Don't mock real practice.
- Don't use real symbols, such as the pentacle, as shorthand for evil. A threat is evil because of what it does, not because of a sign it wears.
- The demons here are this game's own creatures. No faith is the villain, and none is the joke.

Keeping the table safe

Before your first episode, take a few minutes to ask what anyone would rather not see in the game. Leave those things out. Nobody needs to say why.

SKIP OR FADE

- Anyone can say "skip" at any time. The story jumps past that moment.
- Anyone can say "fade". It still happens, but off the page, like a film cutting away.
- No one has to explain. The Storyteller just moves on, and nobody argues.
- At the end of the session, check in: was anything too much?

The coven

The coven is 2–5 witches, plus the guardian if a player plays it. Its members are family by blood or by choice: sisters, cousins, old friends, a lodger who stayed. They share a home, the Lantern House, and the coven's spellbook, **the Book**.

Each witch has one **Power** (Force, Flame, Sight, Voice, Veil or Wild), a **Life** (a job or role outside magic) and four ratings. Chapter 3 shows you how to make one.

The coven is strongest together. The only spell that destroys a threat for good is **the Unmaking**, and every witch who joins it makes it stronger (Chapter 7).

The guardian

The guardian is a protective spirit, bound to the coven's home by an old promise. It takes a human or an animal shape, and it answers to no master. It heals, shields, carries people to safety, senses what others miss and draws the threat's attacks onto itself. It never casts spells and never destroys a threat. One player may play it instead of a witch (Chapter 4). If nobody does, the coven can still call on it once an episode.

The ready-made guardian is Rook. In human shape Rook is a very tall, very still person in a long grey coat. In animal shape, a large black rook.

The Storyteller

The Storyteller runs everything else: the city, its people, the threat and the innocent. They describe each scene, set how hard each roll is and roll for the threat. They aren't playing against you. Their job is to make the threat frightening, give every witch a moment in the story, and follow the rules so the dice decide. Part Two of this book is for them.

Larkhaven

Larkhaven is a harbour city, set today. Fog in the mornings, ferries, steep streets, old money in the Heights and new flats on the old docks.

AREA	WHAT'S THERE
Old Town	Narrow streets, the Lantern House, St Bride's market hall, the night market on Fridays
The Harbour	Ferries, the fish market, the long pier, the lighthouse
Saltmarsh	Reed beds, the drowned village at low tide, birdwatchers
The Heights	Big houses, the old radio tower, the observatory
University Hill	Students, cheap cafés, the library with the locked basement
The Docks	New flats, a burned-out theatre, the container yard

The Lantern House

The coven lives in a narrow, three-storey house in Old Town. A lamp over the door has never gone out. On the ground floor are the front room, the kitchen where potions get brewed, and a back door to a walled garden. The first floor has three bedrooms and a bathroom. The Book sits on a lectern in the attic, among old trunks, under a round window over the street. The guardian is bound to the house.

Threats can't come inside uninvited. That is story, not a rule: no showdown ever happens here. Home is also where the coven can research the Book and brew potions without anyone seeing.

How an episode runs

The episode opens when the threat strikes. The coven then investigates in **scenes**. In each scene every character takes one action: following leads around the city, researching the Book, brewing, resting, covering up magic or answering the call of their everyday life. After every scene the threat's **Doom** rises. With half the **Clues** the coven knows what the threat is and where it hides, and can go to it. With all of them it knows the threat's **Weakness**. Wait too long, and the threat comes to the coven instead, in a public place, with the innocent in its grip. The **showdown** is fought in rounds until the threat is **Broken** and the coven joins together to unmake it, or it gets away, or the coven falls. A closing scene ties up lives and loose ends.

How to read this book

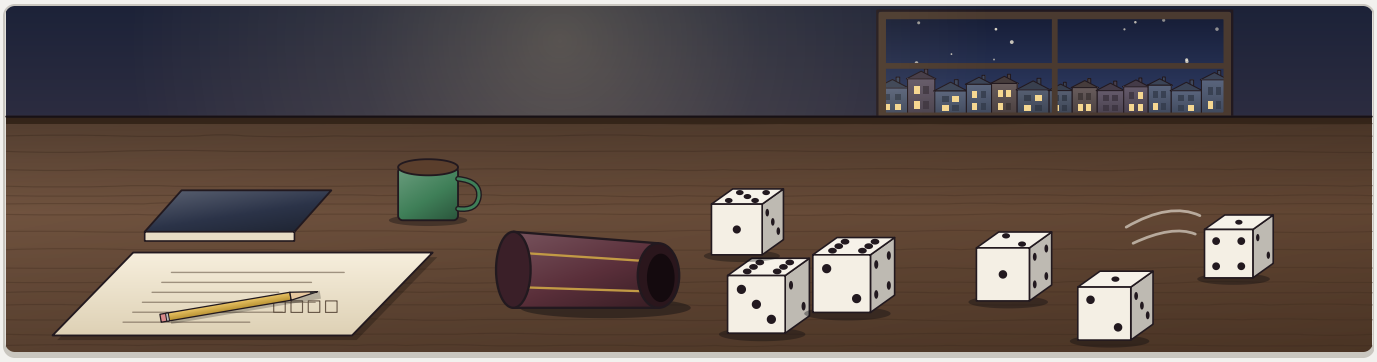
- **Part One** (Chapters 1–8) is for everyone: the roll, witches, the guardian, magic, the episode, the showdown and seasons.
- **Part Two** (Chapters 9–12) is for the Storyteller: running an episode, threats, making episodes and the first night.
- **Part Three** (Chapters 13–16) is ready to play: the coven, the Lantern House and three episodes. Players shouldn't read an episode before they play it.
- The sheets are at the back.

Each rule is stated fully in one place. When a chapter needs a rule from another chapter, it says where to look. Game terms are in **bold** the first time a section uses them.

THE BOXES

- **Rule boxes** hold the key rules.
- **Example boxes** show play, with every number checked against the rules.
- **Storyteller boxes** give advice for whoever runs the game.
- **List boxes** hold checklists and tips, like this one.





CHAPTER 2

The Roll

Talking a witness round, searching a burned house, throwing a demon across a room, keeping your feet when it hits back: almost everything in the game uses the same roll. Learn it once and you know how to play.

Rolling

Pick the rating that fits what you're doing: Heart, Wits, Nerve or Craft (Chapter 3). Roll that many six-sided dice. Each 4, 5 or 6 is a **success**. Count them.

The Storyteller sets the **Difficulty**: the number of successes you need. It is usually 1–4. The Unmaking can be higher. No Difficulty is ever below 1: if something would lower it to 0, it stays at 1. Most Difficulties come straight from the episode's numbers (Chapter 6): leads and brewing use the Lead Difficulty, attacks use the threat's Defence, and defending uses its Danger. Shelter and Hide are Difficulty 2.

READING THE ROLL

Success: your successes are at least the Difficulty. It works.

Critical: a Success that shows two or more 6s. It works, and does one thing extra.

Partial: at least half the Difficulty (round up), but less than all of it. It works, with a cost. At Difficulty 1 there is no Partial.

Failure: fewer successes than that. It doesn't work, and there is a cost.

DIFFICULTY	SUCCESS NEEDS	PARTIAL NEEDS
1	1	—
2	2	1
3	3	2
4	4	2

Criticals

A **Critical** does one thing extra: +1 damage, +1 Clue, +1 potion or –1 more Exposure, whichever fits. If none fits, you get +1 die on your next roll this episode, inside the +2 limit (below).

Some rules already give a number for a Critical: a lead's 2 Clues, an attack's 3 damage, a brew's three potions. That number already includes the extra.

Costs

A Partial or a Failure comes with a **cost**. What it is depends on where you are and what you're doing.

THE COST

In a showdown: 1 Hurt.

Anywhere else: Exposure +1 if you were casting out in the city; otherwise 1 Hurt.

So at home in the Lantern House, a cost is always 1 Hurt. Out in the city, an ordinary roll risks Hurt and a casting roll risks Exposure. Hurt is in Chapter 3; Exposure is in Chapter 6.

Casting

Casting means using a Power, a spell, a potion or a guardian gift. It matters in two places. Out in the city, a casting roll's cost is Exposure. In a public showdown, every round in which anyone was casting raises Exposure (Chapter 7).

- A helper's die doesn't make your roll casting. Neither does the guardian's Sense.
- The guardian's Hold isn't casting: it costs no Ward and uses no magic.
- Casting Hide never raises Exposure, so its cost is always 1 Hurt.

Extra dice

Your **Power** adds 2 dice when it fits what you're doing. Chapter 3 says what each Power fits. You may leave your Power off a roll. Then your Power doesn't make the roll casting (a spell or potion still does).

On top of your Power, you can add at most **+2 dice from everything else together**:

SOURCE	DICE	INSIDE THE +2 LIMIT?
Your Power, when it fits	+2	No, it's separate
A helper (1 Magic or Ward each)	+1 each	Yes
Your Life, when the Storyteller agrees it fits	+1	Yes
The Book (research at home)	+1	Yes
Your own Magic (Ward for the guardian), 1 each	+1 each	Yes
A Critical's extra die, on your next roll	+1	Yes
The guardian's Sense, on someone else's lead (once a scene)	+1	No
Each witch who joins the Unmaking	+2 each	No

HELPERS

To help, spend 1 Magic (the guardian spends 1 Ward) and add 1 die to someone else's roll. Say how you help in the story. You must be able to help: be there with them, or reach them, such as a phone call during a talking lead or a page read out from the Book during research. The Storyteller says whether you can. **Helping takes no action**, so anyone can help, even after they have acted, and even while Down. (A Down guardian is the one exception: it has faded back to the home, Chapter 4.)

YOUR LIFE, THE BOOK AND SENSE

Your **Life** adds 1 die when your job or role fits the roll and the Storyteller agrees: Dana the nurse asking about patients at Larkhaven General, or Tess the bus driver checking the depot's cameras. **The Book** adds 1 die when you research it at home (Chapter 5). **Sense** is a guardian gift that adds 1 die to someone else's lead, once a scene, outside the +2 limit (Chapter 4).

LEAVING YOUR POWER OFF

More dice is usually better, but casting has a price. Out in the city, a casting roll's cost is Exposure; with your Power left off, an ordinary roll costs 1 Hurt instead. In a public showdown, a round with no casting at all doesn't raise Exposure. When Exposure is close to full, leaving your Power off can be the smart move.

Group checks

When everyone must do the same thing, such as wading out before the tide covers the drowned village, the Storyteller calls a **group check**. Everyone rolls. It isn't an action, so nobody uses their action on it. There is only one cost, and whoever rolled worst takes it.

The odds

Each die has an even chance of a success. This table shows your chance, in per cent, of a Success or better / a Partial / a Failure. Each number is rounded on its own, so a row may not add up to exactly 100.

DICE	DIFFICULTY 1	DIFFICULTY 2	DIFFICULTY 3	DIFFICULTY 4
2	75 / — / 25	25 / 50 / 25	0 / 25 / 75	0 / 25 / 75
3	88 / — / 13	50 / 38 / 13	13 / 38 / 50	0 / 50 / 50
4	94 / — / 6	69 / 25 / 6	31 / 38 / 31	6 / 63 / 31
5	97 / — / 3	81 / 16 / 3	50 / 31 / 19	19 / 63 / 19
6	98 / — / 2	89 / 9 / 2	66 / 23 / 11	34 / 55 / 11
7	99 / — / 1	94 / 5 / 1	77 / 16 / 6	50 / 44 / 6

Two things stand out. Each extra die helps a lot. And at Difficulty 3 or 4, a Partial is common: plan for the cost.

EXAMPLE: A CRITICAL

In a Standard episode, June Takeda searches the newspaper archive in the University Hill library for old fires. That's a searching lead: Wits 3. Her Power, Sight, fits leads, so she adds 2 dice. Dana helps by spending 1 Magic, so June rolls 6 dice against the Lead Difficulty of 2. Using Sight makes this a casting roll out in the city, so a short roll would cost Exposure.

She rolls 6, 6, 5, 2, 1, 1. That's three successes, so it's a Success, and it shows two 6s, so it's a Critical. A lead's Critical gives 2 Clues. No cost.

EXAMPLE: LEAVING THE POWER OFF

In a Hard episode, the coven's Exposure is at 3 of its 4 boxes. Tess Lindqvist wants to check the bus depot's cameras for the people who walked into the sea: a searching lead, Wits 2, against Difficulty 2. Her Power, Veil, fits searching leads. But with Veil on, any Partial or Failure would cost Exposure, and the coven would be Seen.

So Tess leaves Veil off. She is a bus driver, and the Storyteller agrees her Life fits: +1 die. She spends 1 Magic for another: +2 in all, the limit. She rolls 4 dice: 5, 3, 2, 1. One success is a Partial. She gets 1 Clue, and because she wasn't casting, the cost is 1 Hurt instead of Exposure. Tess marks 1 Hurt, and the coven stays unseen.

EXAMPLE: A GROUP CHECK

The tide is coming in over the drowned village. Dana, June and Tess must all wade out: a group check, Nerve against Difficulty 2. Nobody is casting. Dana rolls 4, 4, 2: a Success. Tess rolls 6, 3, 1: a Partial. June, with Nerve 1, rolls a 2: a Failure. There is one cost, and June rolled worst, so she marks 1 Hurt.





CHAPTER 3

Witches

Every witch in the coven has one Power, a life outside magic and people who count on them. Some were born to it. Some woke up one morning and set the curtains on fire. Making a witch takes five steps and about ten minutes.

The four ratings

A witch has four ratings. Each one is the number of dice you roll for that kind of action.

RATING	WHAT IT COVERS	ROLLS THAT USE IT
Heart	People: talking, comforting, lying, reading people	Talking leads
Wits	Noticing, searching, research	Searching leads, researching the Book, studying the threat
Nerve	Moving, fighting, standing firm	Attacks, freeing the innocent, defending
Craft	Spells and potions	Every spell, including the Unmaking; brewing

The guardian has only Heart, Wits and Nerve (Chapter 4).

Making a witch

1. YOUR POWER

Roll a d6 on this table, or pick. **No two witches share a Power.** If you roll one that another witch already has, roll again.

D6	POWER	IN SHORT
1	Force	Move things with your mind
2	Flame	Call fire
3	Sight	Glimpses of what's coming or what happened
4	Voice	Words that sway minds
5	Veil	Go unseen, hide magic
6	Wild	Talk to animals, grow and bind with plants

2. YOUR RATINGS

Put 3, 2, 2 and 1 into Heart, Wits, Nerve and Craft, in any order. A good habit is to put the 3 where your Power is used most: Nerve for Force or Flame, Wits for Sight, Heart for Voice, Craft for Wild. Veil works with Nerve, Wits and Craft, so any of those suits it.

3. YOUR LIFE

Your **Life** is your job or role outside magic. Roll a d6, or pick. If you roll one another witch already has, roll again.

D6	LIFE
1	Student
2	Nurse
3	Shop worker
4	Teacher
5	Mechanic
6	Bus driver

4. YOUR TIE TO THE COVEN

Decide how your witch is family to the others, by blood or by choice. A sister, a cousin, an old friend from school, the neighbour's kid who never went home, someone who inherited a room in the house, a lodger who stayed. Ties have no rules. They tell everyone why you would run into a burning theatre for each other.

5. YOUR NAME AND LOOK

Choose a name and pronouns. Any witch can be any gender. Then pick one or two things people notice: a yellow raincoat, oil on your hands, a silver ring on your thumb.

THEN FILL IN YOUR SHEET

Every witch has 4 **Hurt** boxes, all empty, and starts each episode with 5 **Magic**.

The six Powers

Each Power adds 2 dice to a roll it fits (Chapter 2). Using your Power is **casting**. Each Power also has a **Surge**: a bigger effect.

> **SURGES**
>
> Once per scene, you may Surge. It costs 2 Magic, paid before you roll, and it's spent even if you get a Failure. Add it to an action that uses your Power. A defence roll isn't an action, so it takes no Surge; Sight's miss is the one Surge that needs no action. Nobody can Surge while Down, not even Sight's miss. It works on a Partial or better. The whole showdown counts as one scene, so you get one Surge per showdown.

A **talking lead** uses Heart. A **searching lead** uses Wits.

FORCE

You move things with your mind: throw, push, pull, slam a door from across the room.

Fits: attacks, freeing the innocent. **Surge:** the threat loses its next attack.

FLAME

You call fire: a spark, a lash of flame, a candle that won't go out.

Fits: attacks. **Surge:** 2 more damage.

SIGHT

You catch glimpses of what's coming or what happened: a flash of the past when you touch a doorframe, a warning a second before the blow lands.

Fits: leads, defending, studying the threat. **Surge:** 1 more Clue. Or, with no action, before the defence roll, one attack aimed at anyone misses. That miss isn't a lost attack.

VOICE

Your words sway minds: a witness who opens up, a crowd that decides it saw nothing.

Fits: talking leads, Hide. **Surge:** 1 more Clue, or Exposure −1.

VEIL

You go unseen, and you hide magic: people look straight past you, and a spell becomes a trick of the light.

Fits: defending, searching leads, Hide. **Surge:** no Exposure from casting for the rest of the scene, or in a showdown for this round and the next. It covers the whole coven's casting, this roll included. While it lasts, a casting roll's cost becomes 1 Hurt. In a showdown, Veil's Surge goes with Hide.

WILD

You talk to animals, and you grow and bind with plants: the gulls tell you what they saw, ivy wraps a demon's legs.

Fits: talking and searching leads, Bind, brewing. **Surge:** 1 more Clue or potion. Or, in a showdown (where it goes with Bind), the threat's Defence is 1 lower for everyone this round, starting after the Bind roll. It never goes below 1 (Chapter 2).

Magic

You start every episode with 5 **Magic**. There is no top limit: answering your Life gives you 1 more (below). Spend Magic like this:

SPEND	MAGIC
Cast a spell	1
Surge your Power	2
Help someone else's roll (+1 die)	1
Add a die to your own roll	1
Lead or join the Unmaking	1

Unspent Magic is lost at the end of the episode, so spend it. But keep 2 for the showdown: 1 to join the Unmaking, and 1 for a die or a second try (Chapter 7).

Hurt and Down

You mark **Hurt** when a roll's cost says so and when the threat's attacks land. A witch has 4 Hurt boxes. Hurt can't go past full.

> **DOWN**
>
> When all your Hurt boxes are full, you are **Down**. You can take no actions, except resting during the investigation. You can't use potions or Surge (not even Sight's miss), though someone else can use a potion on you. You can still help other people's rolls and join the Unmaking. You are back up as soon as your Hurt drops below full.

Three things clear Hurt: resting in a scene clears all of it, a Healing potion clears 2 (Chapter 5) and the guardian's Mend clears 2 (Chapter 4). Hurt also clears between episodes, except a Scar.

Nobody dies from the dice. But Down has a real cost. If every witch is Down at the end of a showdown round, the coven loses (Chapter 7). And a witch who is Down when the coven loses, except by retreating, gets a **Scar**: 1 Hurt at the start of the next episode (Chapter 8).

Your Life

Your **Life** pulls at you. It helps in two ways and costs in one.

- **It adds a die.** When your Life fits a roll and the Storyteller agrees, add 1 die (inside the +2 limit).
- **It calls.** Once per episode, your Life calls: a double shift, a parents' evening, a bus that won't start, a friend in trouble.

THE LIFE CALL

You can answer your Life in any scene of the investigation. Answering takes your action for that scene, needs no roll, and gives you 1 Magic. If you haven't answered by the showdown, you lose 1 Magic, or take 1 Hurt if you have no Magic.

Answering costs a lead. Ignoring it costs Magic you'll want in the fight. Either way, play the scene: a missed date or a covered shift is good story.

EXAMPLE: MAKING A WITCH

Dana (Force) and June (Sight) are already in the coven. Kemi is making the third witch.

Power. She rolls a 1: Force, which Dana has. She rolls again: 6, Wild.

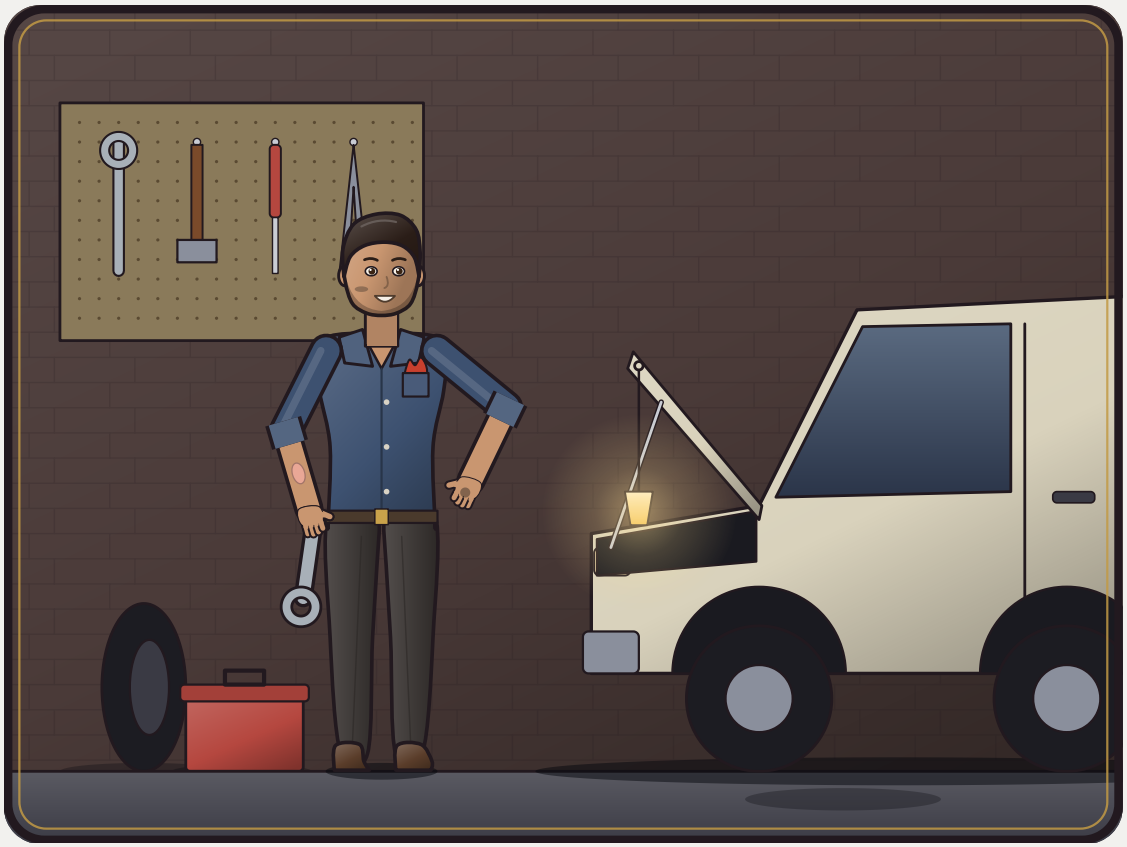
Ratings. Wild fits talking and searching leads, Bind and brewing. Kemi puts 3 in Craft for Bind and brewing, 2 in Heart, 2 in Wits and 1 in Nerve. With Nerve 1 her witch will defend badly in a fight, so she plans to keep a Healing potion close.

Life. She rolls a 2: nurse, which Dana has. She rolls again: 4, teacher.

Tie. Her witch taught June at school and now rents the box room at the Lantern House.

Name and look. Ruth Penhale (she), freckled, with a bike helmet clipped to her bag and a sprig of rosemary behind one ear.

Kemi marks 4 empty Hurt boxes and 5 Magic. Ruth is ready.





CHAPTER 4

The Guardian

The lamp over the door of the Lantern House has never gone out. Something keeps it lit. Something keeps the household safe, too, and has done for longer than anyone living can remember.

What the guardian is

The **guardian** is a protective spirit, bound to the coven's home by an old promise. It takes a human or an animal shape. It answers to no master: nobody gives it orders, not even the coven. It stays because of the promise, and because it cares about the people under its roof.

The guardian isn't a witch. It has no Power, no Craft, no Life and no Magic. It has **Ward** instead, and five **gifts**.

Each coven has one guardian. With 3–5 players, one player may play it instead of a witch. If two players want it, each rolls a die: the highest plays the guardian (roll again on a tie), and the other plays a witch.

A guardian player counts as one of the coven's characters for the Clues needed, for the potion limit and for how many attacks the threat makes. It doesn't count as a witch: it adds nothing to the threat's Toughness and doesn't change the Unmaking's Difficulty.

Why play the guardian

- **You decide who stays standing.** You heal, you take hits meant for others, and you can make the threat come for you instead.
- **You save the innocent.** You can carry a freed innocent right out of the fight.
- **You make the whole coven better.** Your Sense makes a lead land, and your Ward adds dice to anyone's roll.
- **You are the strangest one at the table.** You are old, you remember things, and you see the coven as your household.

The numbers allow for you. A coven with a guardian player does about as well as a coven with one more witch.

Ratings, Hurt and Ward

Put 3, 2 and 2 into **Heart**, **Wits** and **Nerve**, in any order. The guardian rolls like everyone else (Chapter 2).

The guardian has 5 **Hurt** boxes and starts each episode with 5 **Ward**. Spend Ward on gifts (1 each, except Hold), on helping someone else's roll (1 die each) or on your own rolls (1 die each, inside the +2 limit). Unspent Ward is lost at the end of the episode.

The gifts

Using a gift counts as **casting**, except Hold: it costs no Ward and uses no magic. So in a public showdown, a round in which the guardian uses Mend, Shield or Carry raises Exposure, but a Hold doesn't (Chapter 7).

GIFT	WARD	TAKES	WHAT IT DOES
Mend	1	An action	Clear 2 Hurt from someone it touches, itself included.
Shield	1	No action; once a round	Take an attack meant for someone near it. In a showdown, everyone is near.

GIFT	WARD	TAKES	WHAT IT DOES
Carry	1	An action	Take one person to a place it knows, such as the freed innocent out of a fight. It can't carry the coven out of a showdown or past a threat.
Sense	1	No action; once a scene	+1 die on someone else's lead this scene, outside the +2 limit.
Hold	0	An action	Roll Nerve against the threat's Defence. If it works, the threat's next attack must target the guardian. Not casting.

A few details:

- **Shield:** the attack becomes the guardian's, so the guardian rolls to defend against it (Chapter 7).
- **Carry:** an innocent still in the threat's grip can't be carried.
- **Sense:** only on a lead in the investigation, never on studying the threat.
- **Hold:** "works" means a Partial or better, and a Partial still costs 1 Hurt. The Storyteller still rolls the d6 for the attack Hold has aimed, because a 6 still brings the signature move or takes the innocent (Chapter 7).
- **Shelter:** a guardian under Shelter can't Shield or Hold.

What the guardian can and can't do

In the investigation, the guardian takes one action per scene like everyone else: it can follow leads with Heart or Wits, research the Book (a lead using Wits), rest, or use Mend or Carry. Sense takes no action. In the showdown it can free and guard the innocent and study the threat like anyone, use its gifts, and help with Ward.

THE GUARDIAN CAN'T

Cast spells or brew (it has no Craft), use potions, join the Unmaking or damage a threat. It never attacks. It can help the Unmaking's roll with Ward, like any other roll.

When the guardian goes Down

When all 5 Hurt boxes are full, the guardian is **Down**. A Down guardian fades back to the home for the rest of the scene. In a showdown, that means the rest of the fight. From there it can't help, and nobody can heal or help it: no potion or helper reaches it until the scene, or the fight, ends. In a later scene of the investigation it can rest, like anyone who is Down, and it is back up when its Hurt drops below full.

That is the guardian's true cost: if it goes Down in a showdown, the coven loses its Shield, its Hold and its Ward for the rest of the fight.

PLAYING THE GUARDIAN WELL

- **Spend your Ward.** It's gone at the end of the episode.
- **Come to the showdown rested, with Ward left.** That is when you are strongest. Go Down to the first attack and you sit out the fight, so rest if you are hurt, and don't spend all your Ward on Sense.
- **Shield the witch who would go Down.** Your 5 boxes can take a hit that would drop them.
- **Hold before the threat's turn.** In round 1 the threat acts first, so a Hold in round 1 aims its first attack in round 2.
- **Carry the freed innocent out.** Once they are gone, the threat can't take them.
- **Sense the lead that matters most.** Once a scene, on someone else's lead. Its die is outside the +2 limit.
- **Help the Unmaking.** You can't join it, but a Ward die on the leader's roll counts.
- **Don't play a servant.** You have no master. Play it old, odd and loyal.

Rook

The ready-made guardian is Rook (Heart 3, Wits 2, Nerve 2). In human shape, Rook is a very tall, very still person in a long grey coat, grey-eyed, who speaks little. In animal shape, a large black rook. Rook calls the witches "the household". When Rook carries someone, the air folds like a page and they are somewhere else.

EXAMPLE: ROOK IN A FIGHT

A Standard showdown in a hidden place. The threat's Defence is 2 (the coven knows its Weakness) and its Danger is 3, with Hit 2. The coven is Dana, Marco, June and Rook, four characters, so the threat makes 2 attacks a round. Rook has 3 Ward. Dana has 3 of her 4 Hurt boxes marked.

Rook holds. On the characters' turn, Rook uses Hold: Nerve 2, plus 1 Ward for a die (2 Ward left), against Defence 2. Rook rolls 5, 4, 1: two successes, a Success. The threat's next attack must target Rook.

The first attack. The Storyteller rolls the d6 anyway: a 3, not a 6, so it goes to Rook. Rook defends: Nerve 2 against Danger 3, rolling 4, 2. One success, when a Partial needs two: a Failure. Rook marks 2 Hurt (Hit 2).

The second attack. The d6 shows 5: whoever has the most Hurt marked. That is Dana, with 3. Even a Partial would put her Down. Rook uses Shield (1 Ward left) and takes the attack. Rook rolls 6, 4: two successes, a Partial. Rook marks 1 more Hurt, 3 of 5 in all. Dana stays standing.

If nobody plays the guardian

The guardian stays at home, guarding the house. It doesn't take actions, roll or spend Ward, and it doesn't count as one of the coven's characters.

CALLING THE GUARDIAN

Once per episode, on any character's turn, the coven may call the guardian for one Mend or one Carry. Calling takes no action and no roll, and it counts as casting.

Save the call for when it matters: Mend a Down witch back up in the showdown, or Carry a freed innocent out of the fight. A coven of 3 witches with no guardian player faces a threat with 3 more Toughness (Chapter 7).





CHAPTER 5

Magic

Magic in Larkhaven is real, and it is hard to hide. Every witch can cast the spells in the Book, brew potions in the kitchen and use their own Power. All of it costs something, and some of it can be seen.

Casting

Casting means using a Power, a spell, a potion or a guardian gift. Helping someone, adding your own Magic die, your Life die or the Book die doesn't count as casting. A helper's die or the guardian's Sense doesn't make your roll casting either, and the guardian's Hold isn't casting.

Where you cast decides what it risks:

WHERE	COST OF A CASTING ROLL	EXPOSURE
At home (the Lantern House)	1 Hurt	Never rises
Out in the city (investigation)	Exposure +1	Rises only from that cost
Showdown, hidden place	1 Hurt	Never rises
Showdown, public place	1 Hurt	+1 for each round in which anyone was casting

Casting Hide never raises **Exposure**, so its cost is always 1 Hurt. You can leave your Power off a roll so that your Power doesn't make it casting, though a spell or a potion still does (Chapter 2). Exposure and being Seen are in Chapter 6.

Spells

Any witch can cast any spell. A spell is a Craft roll and costs 1 **Magic**. A Partial works, with a cost. A Failure doesn't work, and there is a cost.

SPELL	ROLL	WHAT IT DOES	POWERS THAT FIT
Reveal	Craft against the Lead Difficulty	A lead out in the city. A success gives 1 more Clue.	Sight
Bind	Craft against Defence	The threat loses its next attack.	Wild
Blast	Craft against Defence	An attack. 1 more damage if it works.	Force, Flame
Shelter	Craft, Difficulty 2	Until the end of the threat's next turn, one person can't be hurt by its attacks and doesn't roll to defend. It ends if you go Down.	—
Hide	Craft, Difficulty 2	Exposure –1.	Voice, Veil
The Unmaking	Craft, see Chapter 7	Destroys a Broken threat.	—

REVEAL

Reveal is a lead, so it follows the lead results (Chapter 6), plus 1 Clue on a success. That makes a Success worth 2 Clues, a Critical 3, and a Partial 1 Clue with a cost. Out in the city, Reveal is always casting, so its cost is Exposure.

BIND

The threat loses its next attack. A threat loses at most one attack a round, whatever the cause. If a second Bind, a Force Surge or a Binding potion lands on the same round of attacks, it is wasted. In round 1 the threat attacks before anyone acts, so a Bind cast in round 1 takes away one of its attacks in round 2. Wild's Surge goes with Bind: the threat's Defence is 1 lower for the rest of the round, starting after the Bind roll (Chapter 3).

BLAST

Blast is an attack that uses Craft instead of Nerve (Chapter 7). A Success does 3 damage, a Critical 4 and a Partial 2 with a cost. Once the coven knows the Weakness, add 1 more.

SHELTER

Shelter stops the threat's attacks from hurting one person. It doesn't stop the cost of that person's own rolls. A guardian under Shelter can't Shield or Hold (Chapter 4).

HIDE

Hide calms witnesses and covers up what they saw. A Critical lowers Exposure 1 more. In a showdown, Hide is the spell to take Veil's Surge: a defence roll isn't an action, so it can't carry a Surge. Veil's Surge hides all the coven's casting, Hide's own roll included (Chapter 3). Exposure never goes below 0, and once the coven is Seen, Hide can't lower it.

Any other spell

You can describe any spell you like. The Storyteller uses the closest spell on the list. If your idea stretches it, the Difficulty is 1 higher. Making the harbour fog roll in so nobody sees you leave is Hide. Making the reeds wrap round the creature's legs is Bind. A ring of salt round the innocent is Shelter. Asking an old photograph what it saw is Reveal, at +1 Difficulty, because it's a stretch.

Rhymes are welcome. Say one aloud if you enjoy it, and make it your own. A rhyme gives no bonus.

Potions

BREWING

You brew at home, in the Lantern House kitchen. Brewing takes your action for the scene, or it can be the extra roll the Book researcher makes (below). Roll Craft against the Lead Difficulty.

RESULT	POTIONS MADE
Critical	3
Success	2
Partial	1, and 1 Hurt
Failure	None, and 1 Hurt

Wild fits brewing, and Wild's Surge makes 1 more potion. Choose the kind of each potion as you make it.

THE THREE KINDS

POTION	WHAT IT DOES
Healing	Clear 2 Hurt.
Blasting	Use it with your attack. If the attack works, 2 more damage.
Binding	Use it with your attack. If the attack works, the threat loses its next attack.

USING POTIONS

Using a potion takes no action. Use it while the characters act, before or after your own action, on yourself or someone near you (the guardian included: it can't use potions, but you can use one on it). In a showdown, that is never on the threat's turn. Each character uses at most one potion a round (or a scene). Using a potion is casting.

A Blasting or Binding potion goes with the attacker's own attack. An attack takes at most one potion.

A Down character can't use potions at all, but someone else can use one on them. A Healing potion brings them back up.

Say you are using a potion before you roll. It is used up either way.

The coven shares its potions and can have at most one per character. The guardian counts if a player plays it. Extra potions from a brew are lost.

Potions spoil at the end of the episode.

The Weakness adds 1 damage to an attack that works, but not to a potion. A working attack with a Blasting potion, once the coven knows the Weakness, does its normal damage +1 for the Weakness +2 for the potion.

The Book

The Book is the coven's spellbook. It lives on a lectern in the attic of the Lantern House, full of other witches' notes, drawings and warnings.

RESEARCHING THE BOOK

Researching the Book is an action at home. It is a lead using Wits, with +1 die (inside the +2 limit), and it never raises Exposure. Only one character can research the Book each scene. That character may also make one brewing roll in the same scene. Each roll has its own result and its own cost.

Pages. When the coven destroys a threat, the threat gets a page in the Book. The next time the coven faces that kind of threat, it starts the episode with half the Clues, rounded up. Pages last for the whole season (Chapter 8).

What magic can't do

NO SPELL CAN

- **Heal.** Hurt clears only by resting, a Healing potion or the guardian's Mend.
- **Bring back the dead.**
- **Change the past.**
- **Force love.**

No stretch makes these possible. If a player describes one, the Storyteller says no and helps them find a spell that can work.

EXAMPLE: COVERING UP

In a Standard episode, the coven's Exposure is at 3 of its 4 boxes after Marco set a skip on fire in front of a bus queue. Quinn Abernathy goes back to cover it up: Hide, out in the city. Quinn rolls Craft 2, plus 2 for Voice, which fits Hide: 4 dice against Difficulty 2. Quinn pays 1 Magic for the spell and 2 for a Surge before rolling: 3 Magic.

Quinn rolls 6, 4, 2, 1: two successes, a Success. Hide lowers Exposure by 1 and the Surge by 1 more, from 3 to 1. By the time Quinn leaves, the bus queue remembers a dropped cigarette.

EXAMPLE: BREWING

The coven is Dana, June, Noor and Rook, played by the fourth player, so it can hold at most 4 potions. It already has 2. In a Standard episode, Noor Haddad brews as her action: Craft 3, plus 2 for Wild, which fits brewing. She rolls 5 dice against the Lead Difficulty of 2: 6, 6, 4, 2, 1. Three successes and two 6s: a Critical, three potions.

Only 2 more fit, so Noor picks a Blasting potion and a Healing potion. The third potion is lost. She was casting at home, so even a short roll would have cost only Hurt, never Exposure.





CHAPTER 6

The Episode

An episode is one evening's story. The threat strikes. The coven pieces together what it is and where it hides, while the threat's plan creeps forward. In the end, someone faces it.

The shape of an episode

1. **Opening.** The threat strikes.
2. **Investigation,** in scenes. The coven looks for Clues.
3. **Showdown,** in rounds. The coven fights the threat (Chapter 7).
4. **Closing.** Life scenes, consequences, carry-over.

The episode's numbers

Each episode has a **label**: Easy, Standard or Hard. At the start, the Storyteller sets every number from this table. The numbers don't change if someone joins or leaves during the episode. In the table, **w** is the number of witches and **n** is the number of witches plus the guardian, if a player plays it.

	EASY	STANDARD	HARD
Lead Difficulty	1	2	2
Threat Defence / Danger	1 / 1	2 / 3	2 / 3
Hit (Hurt on a failed defence)	2	2	3
Toughness	3 × w	3 × w	4 × w
Clues needed	3 × n	4 × n – 1	4 × n
Exposure boxes	5	4	4

Doom always has 12 boxes, with the Showdown mark at 5. A coven of 3 witches with no guardian player faces 3 more Toughness, and a season adds more (Chapters 7 and 8).

Opening

The episode starts when the threat strikes: a singer loses her voice, a row of houses burns, three people walk into the sea. **Doom**, **Exposure** and **Clues** all start at 0. If the Book has a page on this kind of threat, the coven starts with half the Clues (rounded up) instead (Chapter 5).

Scenes

The investigation is played in **scenes**. In each scene, every character takes one action, in any order. At the end of the scene, Doom rises by 1.

ACTION	WHERE	ROLL	WHAT IT GETS YOU
Follow a lead	Out in the city	Heart (talking), Wits (searching) or Reveal (Craft, 1 Magic), against the Lead Difficulty	Clues

ACTION	WHERE	ROLL	WHAT IT GETS YOU
Research the Book	At home	Wits +1 die, against the Lead Difficulty; one character per scene	Clues, never Exposure; may also brew
Brew a potion	At home	Craft against the Lead Difficulty	Potions (Chapter 5)
Rest	—	None	Clear all your Hurt
Cover up	Out in the city	Hide (Craft, 1 Magic, Difficulty 2)	Exposure –1
Answer your Life	—	None	1 Magic (Chapter 3)

The guardian can also use Mend or Carry as its action, and Sense without one. It can research the Book, but it can't brew (Chapter 4). A character who is Down can only rest.

Leads

A **lead** is any action that can find Clues. A **talking lead** uses Heart: questioning a witness, comforting someone who's scared, lying your way past a security desk. A **searching lead** uses Wits: going over a scene, reading old records, following tracks. Researching the Book is a lead using Wits at home. Reveal is a lead using Craft.

LEAD RESULTS

Critical: 2 Clues. **Success:** 1 Clue. **Partial:** 1 Clue, with a cost. **Failure:** no Clue, and a cost.

Reveal gives 1 more Clue on a success. Sight, Voice and Wild can Surge for 1 more Clue on a lead they fit.

Out in the city, a casting roll's cost is Exposure +1; any other cost is 1 Hurt (Chapter 2). The Storyteller tells you what each Clue shows: a name, a smell of smoke, a pattern on a map.

Clues

- **Half the Clues** (rounded up): the coven knows what the threat is and where it is, and may go to it.
- **All the Clues:** the coven knows the threat's **Weakness**. Until it does, the threat's Defence is 1 higher and the Unmaking is 2 harder (Chapter 7).
- Clues past the total are lost.

Clues found in the showdown, by studying the threat, count too.

Doom

Doom is the threat's plan. It has 12 boxes, and it rises by 1 at the end of every scene and every round. Nothing lowers it.

- **The Showdown mark (5):** if Doom has reached it at the end of a scene, the threat comes to the coven. The mark is checked only then, even if Doom rose during the scene.
- **Full (12):** the plan is complete. The innocent is lost (unless already carried to safety, Chapter 7), the threat escapes, and the episode ends as a Loss.
- Doom doesn't rise once the threat is Broken.

THE END OF A SCENE

1. Doom +1.

2. If Doom has reached the Showdown mark (5), it's too late. The threat **comes to the coven**. The showdown starts in a public place, with the innocent **in its grip**, whatever the coven did for them before.

3. Otherwise, if the coven has half the Clues, it may **go to the threat** now. Going takes no scene. The showdown is in a hidden place, and the innocent isn't there. Or the coven plays another scene.

Go now, or one more scene?

If nothing else raises Doom, it reaches 4 at the end of the fourth scene. That is the last moment to go to the threat. Play a fifth scene and Doom reaches 5: the threat comes to you. So if you have half the Clues but not all of them, you face a real choice.

	GO NOW	STAY ONE MORE SCENE
Where	A hidden place	A public place
The innocent	Not there	In its grip: free them in round 1, or they're lost
Exposure	Casting doesn't raise it	Every round with casting raises it
The Weakness	Maybe not: Defence 1 higher, Unmaking 2 harder	One more scene of leads to find it

Neither is always right. Count how many Clues you are short. Studying the threat can find the last few in the fight. Ask whether your coven can free the innocent in round 1, and how close Exposure is to full. You can also go earlier, at the end of any scene, once you have half the Clues.

Exposure and Seen

Exposure is how close ordinary people are to seeing magic. Its number of boxes depends on the label.

- **It rises** by 1 when a casting roll out in the city has a cost (except Hide, whose cost is always 1 Hurt), and by 1 for each round of a public showdown in which anyone was casting (Chapter 7).
- **It falls** when someone casts Hide (Chapter 5), never below 0.

SEEN

When Exposure is full, the coven is **Seen**. Exposure stays full, and Hide can't lower it. Any further rise becomes Doom +1 instead (once per round or scene), but not once the threat is Broken. At the end, Seen drops the episode's result one step.

Being Seen is costly. A Win becomes a Partial and a Partial becomes a Loss. Every careless spell after that pushes the threat's plan closer. In the story, there are phone videos, a reporter asking questions, neighbours who stop waving.

Your Life call

Each witch's Life calls once per episode. Answering it is an action in any scene: no roll, and you gain 1 Magic. If you haven't answered by the showdown, you lose 1 Magic, or take 1 Hurt if you have none (Chapter 3). The Storyteller frames the call; the player decides when to answer.

The closing

After the showdown comes the closing: the result (Chapter 7), Life scenes and consequences. This is where the everyday side of the game gets its moment: the date that got cut short, the shift a friend covered, the innocent saying thank you, or not. In a season, note what carries over (Chapter 8).

EXAMPLE: A SCENE IN CINDERS

A Standard episode: the Ash Widow is burning houses, and Hannah Price, a firefighter about to be married, is the innocent. The coven is Dana (Force), Marco (Flame) and June (Sight), and the fourth player plays Rook. That is 4 characters, so the coven needs 4 × 4 − 1 = 15 Clues, and half is 8. The Lead Difficulty is 2.

At the start of scene 3, Doom is 2, Exposure is 1 of 4 and the coven has 6 Clues. June answered her Life in scene 1 and spent 1 Magic in scene 2. Dana, Marco and June have 5 Magic each, and Rook has 5 Ward.

June searches the burned row of houses: a searching lead, Wits 3 plus 2 for Sight. Rook uses Sense (4 Ward left) for 1 more die, outside the limit. June rolls 6 dice: 6, 5, 4, 3, 2, 1. Three successes, but only one 6: a Success, 1 Clue. Clues: 7.

Dana talks to a nurse at Larkhaven General who treated the people from the fire. Dana is a nurse, so the Storyteller agrees her Life fits: Heart 2 plus 1. She rolls 4, 2, 1: one success, a Partial. 1 Clue (Clues: 8), and since she wasn't casting, the cost is 1 Hurt.

Marco answers his Life: a customer's van has to be ready tonight. No roll; he gains 1 Magic, to 6.

Rook talks to an old woman who saw the first fire: Heart 3. Rook rolls 5, 4, 1: a Success, 1 Clue. Clues: 9.

End of scene 3. Doom rises to 3: not the mark. The coven has 9 Clues, more than half, so it knows what the threat is (a fire spirit in a burned wedding dress) and where (the burned-out theatre on the Docks). It could go now, but it is 6 Clues short of the Weakness. It plays another scene.

Scene 4. Dana answers her Life, a double shift, and gains 1 Magic, to 6. June casts Reveal from across the street from the theatre: Craft 2 plus 2 for Sight, 1 Magic (4 left). She rolls 6, 4, 4, 1: a Success, 1 Clue plus 1 for Reveal. Marco talks to the fire investigator whose truck he fixes; his Life fits, so he rolls Heart 2 plus 1: 5, 5, 2, a Success. Rook searches the fire scene with Wits 2: 6, 4, a Success. Clues: 9 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 13. Doom rises to 4.

The choice. Thirteen of 15. One more scene would probably find the Weakness, but Doom would reach 5, and the Ash Widow would come to them at the harbour fireworks with Hannah in her grip. The coven goes now. In the fight, June (Wits 3 plus Sight) and Rook can study the threat for the last 2 Clues. Chapter 7 picks up the fight.



CHAPTER 7

The Showdown

Sooner or later the coven and the threat meet. It might be in the threat's lair, on the coven's terms. It might be in the middle of a crowd, with the innocent in its grip. Either way, only the coven together can finish it.

Where it happens

If the coven went to the threat, the **showdown** is in a hidden place. The innocent isn't there, and casting doesn't raise Exposure. If the threat came to the coven, the showdown is in a public place. The innocent is there, in its grip, and every round with casting raises Exposure (Chapter 6).

Everyone keeps their Hurt, Magic, Ward and potions from the investigation.

Rounds

The showdown is played in **rounds**. The whole showdown counts as one scene for anything that works once per scene, such as a Surge.

ORDER OF A ROUND

Round 1: the threat's attacks; the characters' actions; the innocent (still in its grip? they're lost); Exposure; Doom +1.

Later rounds: the characters' actions; the threat's attacks; Exposure; Doom +1.

At the start of any round, the coven may retreat (below).

Actions

In each round, every character takes one action, in any order they like, or does nothing:

- **Attack** the threat (below).
- **Cast a spell:** Bind, Blast, Shelter, Hide or the Unmaking (Chapter 5).
- **Free** the innocent, or **guard** them (below).
- **Study** the threat: Wits against its Defence. It gives 1 Clue, so the coven can find the Weakness mid-fight.
- **Use a gift** (the guardian, Chapter 4).

Some things take no action: helping a roll, using a potion, the guardian's Shield, Sight's miss Surge, and a Down witch joining the Unmaking. Potions are used while the characters act, before or after your own action, never on the threat's turn: one per character a round, and an attack takes at most one, the attacker's own (Chapter 5).

A Down character takes no actions, uses no potions and can't Surge, not even Sight's miss. Someone else can use a Healing potion on them to bring them back up (Chapter 3).

Attacks and damage

To **attack**, roll Nerve, or Craft if you cast Blast. A Power that fits adds 2 dice: Force and Flame fit attacks. The Difficulty is the threat's **Defence**.

RESULT	DAMAGE	COST
Critical	3	—
Success	2	—
Partial	1	1 Hurt
Failure	0	1 Hurt

If the attack works (a Partial or better), add: **+1** for Blast, **+1** once the coven knows the Weakness, **+2** for Flame's Surge and **+2** for a Blasting potion. Mark the damage against the threat's **Toughness**. Damage past its Toughness is lost. The guardian never attacks.

The Weakness

Until the coven knows the threat's **Weakness**, its Defence is 1 higher for every roll against it. Once the coven knows it, attack rolls that work, Blast included, do 1 more damage. Potions don't. The Unmaking is also 2 harder without it (below). Wild's Surge can lower Defence, but no Difficulty is ever below 1 (Chapter 2).

Knowing the Weakness is enough. The coven has what it needs, such as the salt or the bell, as part of the story. Using it takes no action and no roll.

If the coven came in short, studying is how it catches up. Each study that works gives 1 Clue, a Critical gives 2, and Sight's Surge adds 1 more.

The threat

A threat has four numbers: **Defence** (the Difficulty to hurt it), **Danger** (the Difficulty to defend against it), **Hit** (the Hurt it does on a failed defence) and **Toughness** (the damage that Breaks it).

THE THREAT'S ATTACKS

It makes 1 attack a round against 3 characters, and 2 against 4 or 5. A guardian counts only if a player plays it.

It loses at most one attack a round, whatever the cause (Bind, Force's Surge, a Binding potion). Any more are wasted. Sight's miss isn't a lost attack.

Against a coven of 3 witches with no guardian player, it has 3 more Toughness.

The threat's turn

For each attack, the Storyteller rolls a d6 to see what the threat does.

D6	THE THREAT…
1–3	attacks whoever hurt it last. If nobody has, or they're Down, use 4–5.
4–5	attacks whoever has the most Hurt marked and is still standing. Ties: roll a die among them.
6	uses its signature move (one with none attacks two different characters). But if the innocent is there and free, it goes for them instead: it attacks their guard, or takes them if nobody is guarding them.

Taking the innocent isn't an attack, so Hold can't stop it. That is why the Storyteller rolls the d6 even for an attack Hold has aimed. If it shows 6, the signature move still happens (or the innocent is taken). Hold only aims attacks: if the move attacks, the guardian is its first target, and Hold is used up. If it attacks the innocent's guard, Hold sends that attack to the guardian instead, and Hold is used up. Taking an unguarded innocent isn't an attack, so Hold stays for the next attack. Any part of a move that isn't an attack still happens: under Hold, Lure's attack goes to the guardian, and its Heart roll still happens. A move with no attack in it leaves Hold for the next attack. Each threat has its own signature move, and Chapter 10 says whom it targets. Every signature move picks only standing characters.

Defending

The target rolls Nerve against the threat's Danger. A Power that fits adds 2 dice: Sight and Veil fit defending. That is casting, so in a public place it counts toward Exposure. A defence roll isn't an action, so it takes no Surge.

RESULT	HURT
Success	None
Partial	1
Failure	Hit

That is all the Hurt the roll does. You can add dice with Magic or helpers as usual. Four things keep an attack off someone: Shelter (no roll, no Hurt), the guardian's Shield (it takes the attack and defends itself), Sight's Surge (the attack misses) and guarding the freed innocent (you take the attack instead of them). If Shield and Sight's Surge could both be used on the same attack, Shield is chosen first.

The innocent

The innocent is only in public showdowns. In a hidden place they aren't there.

IN ITS GRIP

The threat starts the showdown with the innocent **in its grip**. While they are, nobody can guard or carry them.

Free them: roll Nerve against Defence (Force fits). Only a Success frees them. A Partial doesn't, and still costs 1 Hurt.

If they are still in its grip at the end of round 1, they're lost.

Once they're free, if the threat takes them, they're lost. A Broken threat lets go.

To **guard** a freed innocent, use your action. Until the end of the threat's next turn, if it goes for them, it attacks you instead. It ends if you go Down. The guardian can also **carry**

them out of the fight (Chapter 4). Once they're gone, the threat can't go for them.

In round 1, keep trying until someone frees them. A Partial isn't enough.

Public showdowns and Exposure

In a public place, every round in which anyone was casting raises **Exposure** by 1, once per round, at the Exposure step. Powers, spells, potions and gifts all count, except the guardian's Hold, which isn't casting. Casting Hide doesn't raise it either.

- One caster or four, it's the same 1 Exposure. Bunch your casting into the same rounds.
- In a quiet round, leave your Power off.
- Veil's Surge, cast with Hide, hides all the coven's casting for this round and the next.
- Once the coven is Seen, each further rise becomes Doom +1 instead, until the threat is Broken (Chapter 6).

Broken

When the threat's Toughness is full, it is **Broken**. It makes no more rolls or moves, so it doesn't attack. Doom stops rising. It lets go of the innocent. At the end of the next round it flees, unless the coven unmakes it first.

The Unmaking

THE UNMAKING

Only against a Broken threat. One standing witch leads, with Craft, as their action, and pays 1 Magic.

Every other witch may join for 1 Magic. Each one adds **2 dice**, outside the +2 limit. A standing witch joins as their action, so they must not have acted this round. A Down witch joins without one, and so does a witch who lost their action to Lure.

The Difficulty is **the number of witches in the coven**, +2 without the Weakness.

Only a Success destroys the threat. On a Partial or a Failure it isn't destroyed and nobody takes Hurt. Try again next round if it's still there.

The Unmaking is a spell, so it is casting. In a public place, every try counts toward the round's Exposure, even a failed one.

The leader can still add up to +2 dice of their own: their Magic, or helpers, including the guardian's Ward. The guardian can't join.

Timing. You have the rest of the round the threat Breaks in, and all of the next round. If most of the coven has already acted, try now with whoever is left: a failed try costs no Hurt, only Magic (and in a public place it counts as casting). Or wait for the next round, when every standing witch can join. Either way, the next round is your last chance.

The Weakness matters here most. In a coven of three witches, a leader with Craft 2, two joiners and +2 dice make 8 dice. Against Difficulty 3 that works about 86% of the time. Without the Weakness it's Difficulty 5: about 36%.

Retreat

At the start of any round, the coven may **retreat**. Everyone leaves together. The episode ends at once, and it is a Loss. The threat wasn't destroyed, so it comes back later with 2 more Toughness (Chapter 8). An innocent still in the fight is lost. Nobody gets a Scar for a retreat: that is what retreating saves when a fight is going badly. It never turns a bad fight into anything better than a Loss.

How it ends

The episode ends at once, and the rest of the round doesn't happen, when:

- the threat is destroyed;
- the threat flees;
- Doom fills;
- every witch is Down at the end of a showdown round (a standing guardian doesn't count);
- the coven retreats.

At the end of a round, "every witch is Down" is checked before a Broken threat flees. If both happen, it's a Loss.

On a retreat, or when every witch is Down, an innocent still in the fight is lost. When Doom fills, the plan is complete and the innocent is lost. In each case, an innocent already carried to safety isn't lost, but the result is still a Loss.

RESULT	WHAT HAPPENED
Win	The threat was destroyed, and the innocent is safe.
Partial	The threat fled, or it was destroyed but the innocent was lost.
Loss	Doom filled, every witch was Down, or the coven retreated.

If the coven is **Seen**, the result drops one step: a Win becomes a Partial and a Partial becomes a Loss. A Loss stays a Loss.

Scars

Nobody dies from the dice. But a witch who is Down when the coven loses, except by retreating, gets a **Scar**: 1 Hurt at the start of the next episode (Chapter 8).

FIGHTING WELL

- **Keep 2 Magic for the Unmaking:** 1 to join, and 1 for a die or a second try. Spend the rest. Unspent Magic is lost.
- **Short of the Weakness? Study first.** Every later attack and the Unmaking get easier.
- **Break it early in the round.** Let one witch land the last blow first, so the others still have their actions to lead or join the Unmaking.
- **Watch the 4–5 result.** The most-hurt character draws the attacks. Shelter, Shield or heal them before they drop.
- **Use your potions.** They take no action, and they spoil at the end of the episode anyway.

A worked showdown

This follows on from the example in Chapter 6. Every number is checked against the rules.

THE ASH WIDOW: SETTING UP

A Standard episode, in a hidden place: the burned-out theatre on the Docks. The coven is Dana (Force), Marco (Flame), June (Sight) and Rook, played by the fourth player. Four characters, so the Ash Widow makes 2 attacks a round. Three witches, so her Toughness is 3 × 3 = 9 (no extra 3, because a player plays the guardian). Danger 3, Hit 2. Defence 2, but 3 until the coven knows the Weakness. The Unmaking will be Difficulty 3, or 5 without the Weakness.

Clues 13 of 15. Doom 4. Exposure 1 of 4. No potions.

Dana: Nerve 3, Hurt 1, Magic 6. Marco: Nerve 3, Craft 2, Hurt 0, Magic 6. June: Wits 3, Craft 2, Hurt 0, Magic 4. Rook: Nerve 2, Wits 2, Hurt 0 of 5, Ward 4. Every Life call has been answered.

ROUND 1

The threat goes first. Attack one: the d6 shows 2. Nobody has hurt her yet, so use 4–5: the most Hurt marked is Dana, with 1. Dana defends: Nerve 3 against Danger 3. She rolls 5, 4, 2: two successes, a Partial. She marks 1 Hurt (2 of 4).

Attack two: the d6 shows 5, Dana again. A Failure would do 2 Hurt and put her Down. Rook uses Shield (3 Ward left) and takes the attack. Rook rolls 6, 3: one success, a Failure. Rook marks 2 Hurt (2 of 5).

June studies: Wits 3, plus 2 for Sight, against Defence 3. She rolls 6, 5, 4, 1, 1: three successes, a Success. 1 Clue (14).

Rook studies: Wits 2, plus 1 Ward for a die (2 Ward left), against Defence 3. Rook rolls 5, 4, 3: two successes, a Partial. It works with a cost: 1 Clue (15) and 1 Hurt (3 of 5). The coven has all the Clues and knows the Weakness: harbour water, blessed by a coven. From now on Defence is 2, and attacks that work do 1 more damage.

Marco attacks with fire and Surges: 2 Magic first (4 left). Nerve 3 plus 2 for Flame, against Defence 2. He rolls 6, 5, 2, 2, 1: two successes and one 6, a Success. Damage: 2, +1 for the Weakness, +2 for the Surge = 5. Toughness 5 of 9.

Dana attacks with Force and Surges: 2 Magic (4 left). Five dice against Defence 2: 4, 4, 3, 1, 1. Two successes, a Success. Damage 2 + 1 = 3, Toughness 8 of 9, and the Surge means the threat loses its next attack.

The innocent: not here. **Exposure:** a hidden place, so no rise. **Doom** rises to 5. The Showdown mark only matters in the investigation.

ROUND 2

The characters act first now. The coven wants the Ash Widow Broken before the others act, so Marco goes first.

Marco attacks, with no Surge left (one per showdown). Five dice: 5, 3, 3, 2, 1. One success, a Partial. Damage 1 + 1 for the Weakness = 2, and Marco marks 1 Hurt. Toughness is 9 of 9; the extra point is lost. **She is Broken.** She stops attacking, Doom stops rising, and she will flee at the end of round 3.

June leads the Unmaking: Craft 2, 1 Magic (3 left). Dana hasn't acted, so she joins as her action: 1 Magic (3 left), +2 dice. Marco has acted, so he can't join this round. June adds 1 of her own Magic (2 left) and Rook helps with 1 Ward (1 left): +2, the limit. Six dice against Difficulty 3: 5, 4, 3, 2, 1, 1. Two successes, a Partial. She isn't destroyed, but nobody takes Hurt.

The threat's attacks: none; she is Broken. **Exposure:** no rise. **Doom:** stays at 5.

ROUND 3

The last chance. **June leads again:** 1 Magic (1 left). Dana joins (2 left) and Marco joins (3 left): +4 dice. June spends her last Magic on a die, and Rook its last Ward: +2. Eight dice against Difficulty 3: 6, 5, 4, 4, 3, 2, 1, 1. Four successes, a Success. The Ash Widow is destroyed, and the episode ends at once.

The result. The threat was destroyed, and Hannah was never in danger: a Win. Exposure is 1 of 4, so the coven isn't Seen and the Win stands. The Ash Widow gets a page in the Book.

Look at what made it work. Studying first found the Weakness, which made every later roll easier and cut the Unmaking from Difficulty 5 to 3. Rook's Shield kept Dana standing. And everyone kept enough Magic to try the Unmaking twice.

EXAMPLE: FREEING THE INNOCENT

An Easy episode, Night Market. Quinn (Voice), Tess (Veil) and Noor (Wild) stayed one more scene to find all 9 Clues, so the Quiet Man came to them at the Friday night market with Grace Ellery in his grip. Three characters, so 1 attack a round. Defence 1, Danger 1. Toughness 3 × 3 = 9, plus 3 against 3 witches with no guardian player: 12. Exposure is 2 of 5.

The threat goes first. The d6 shows 4: the most Hurt marked is Tess, with 1. Veil fits defending, but using it would be casting, so Tess leaves it off. Nerve 3 against Danger 1: 4, 2, 1, a Success. No Hurt.

Tess frees Grace: Nerve 3 against Defence 1. She rolls 5, 2, 1: a Success. Grace is free.

Quinn guards Grace. No roll. Until the end of the Quiet Man's next turn, if he goes for her, he attacks Quinn instead.

Noor casts Blast: 1 Magic, Craft 3 against Defence 1. Wild doesn't fit attacks, but 3 dice beat her Nerve 1. She rolls 5, 4, 1: a Success. Damage 2, +1 for Blast, +1 for the Weakness = 4. Toughness 4 of 12.

The innocent: free, so not lost. **Exposure:** Noor cast, so it rises to 3. **Doom** rises by 1.

Because Noor cast anyway, Tess could have used Veil on her defence for no extra Exposure. But the threat acted first, before anyone knew. Plan your casting rounds together.



CHAPTER 8

Seasons

One episode is a good night. A run of them is a season: the same coven, the same house, the same city, getting older, stronger and more tangled up in each other's lives. The threats remember the coven, too.

Stringing episodes together

A **season** is a run of episodes with the same coven. Each episode still works on its own. A season just adds a little carry-over between them.

Each episode starts fresh: 5 Magic for each witch, 5 Ward for the guardian, no potions (they spoil), and Doom, Exposure and Clues at 0. Hurt doesn't carry over, except as a Scar. The Storyteller sets the episode's numbers at its start (Chapter 6). They don't change if someone joins or leaves during the episode.

WHAT CARRIES OVER	WHEN	EFFECT
Scars	A witch is Down when the coven loses (not by retreating)	1 Hurt at the start of the next episode
Growth	After every second episode	Each witch raises one rating by 1 (most 4)
Book pages	The coven destroys a threat	Next time, start with half the Clues (rounded up)
Returning threats	A threat isn't destroyed	It comes back when the Storyteller chooses, with 2 more Toughness each time it escapes
Stronger threats	After the 2nd and the 4th episodes	Threats get 2 more Toughness per witch

Scars

Nobody dies from the dice. But a witch who is Down when the coven loses gets a **Scar**, unless the coven lost by retreating: they start the next episode with 1 Hurt marked. Once it is marked, it is ordinary Hurt, and rest, a Healing potion or the guardian's Mend can clear it.

Play the Scar in the story: a burn that needs a dressing, a cough that won't shift, a nightmare that comes back.

Growth

After every second episode of a season (the 2nd, the 4th, the 6th and so on), each witch raises one rating by 1. No rating can go above 4. Pick the rating your witch has been leaning on, or the one that let them down. The guardian doesn't grow.

Book pages

When the coven destroys a threat, it gets a page in **the Book**. The next time the coven faces that kind of threat, it starts the episode with half the Clues, rounded up, so it can go to the threat as soon as the first scene ends. Pages last the whole season, and a new witch shares them (Chapter 5).

Returning threats

A threat that wasn't destroyed comes back when the Storyteller chooses, with 2 more Toughness each time it escapes. That includes a threat that fled, one that escaped when Doom filled, and one the coven retreated from or fell to. A threat that has escaped twice comes back with 4 more.

Stronger threats

As the witches grow, so do the threats. After the 2nd and the 4th episodes, threats get 2 more Toughness per witch. So from the 3rd episode they have 2 more per witch, and from the 5th episode on they have 4 more per witch. After that they stop growing.

EPISODE	RAISES EACH WITCH HAS HAD	THREATS' EXTRA TOUGHNESS
1–2	0	None
3–4	1	+2 per witch
5–6	2	+4 per witch
7–8	3	+4 per witch

The same pattern goes on: one more raise every second episode, while the threats stay at +4 per witch. This is on top of the 3 more Toughness against a coven of 3 witches with no guardian player, and the 2 more each time a returning threat has escaped.

New and replacement witches

Players come and go during a season. A witch can leave the coven for good, and a new one can join. Make a new witch as in Chapter 3: no two witches share a Power, and a Life someone already has is rolled again.

A NEW WITCH

A new or replacement witch joins at the same growth as the coven's lowest witch: they get as many raises as that witch has had. They share the coven's Book, pages and all. They bring no Scars.

Give a new witch a tie to the coven that makes sense: a cousin who turned up with a suitcase, someone the coven saved last month, a friend who finally saw too much.

Romance and everyday life

The threat of the week is only half the show. The other half is the witches' lives: jobs, families, money, friends who almost find out, and sometimes romance.

- **Romance is an optional story thread.** There are no rules for it: no dice, no Magic, no track. Play it if the table enjoys it and skip it if not.
- **Mostly with people from everyday life:** a colleague, a neighbour, a regular at the garage, the innocent from three episodes ago. A romance between a witch and the guardian isn't part of the game's usual setup.
- **Keep it to the table's comfort.** The game is for ages 13 and up. Fade to black is always there, and anyone can say "skip" or "fade" (Chapter 1).
- **Everyday life uses the rules you already have.** Your Life adds a die when it fits, and it calls once each episode (Chapter 3). Everything else about everyday life is story.

The best seasons let the two halves crash into each other. The Storyteller can pick a Life call that lands on the worst possible night, or an innocent who turns out to be a witch's new boss.

RUNNING A SEASON

- The three ready-made episodes (Chapters 14–16) make a good start: Easy, then Standard, then Hard. After that, use the episode generator (Chapter 11).
- Bring a returning threat back when the coven has almost forgotten it. It knows them now.
- Keep a list of the people the coven has met. Let them come back as friends, problems, innocents or dates.
- Give every witch's Life a turn in the spotlight over the season.

EXAMPLE: FOUR EPISODES OF A SEASON

The coven is Dana, Marco and June, with Rook played by the fourth player.

Episode 1, Night Market (Easy). The Quiet Man is Broken but flees before the Unmaking works: a Partial. He wasn't destroyed, so he will come back later with 2 more Toughness. No page.

Episode 2, Cinders (Standard). A Win. The Ash Widow gets a page in the Book.

After episode 2. Growth: Dana raises Nerve to 4, Marco raises Craft to 3 and June raises Wits to 4. From now on, threats have 2 more Toughness per witch.

Episode 3, Low Tide (Hard). The Drowned Choir has Toughness 4 × 3 = 12, plus 2 × 3 = 6 for the season: 18. Doom fills before the coven can Break the Choir: a Loss, with Marco Down. Marco gets a Scar, and the Drowned Choir will come back later too.

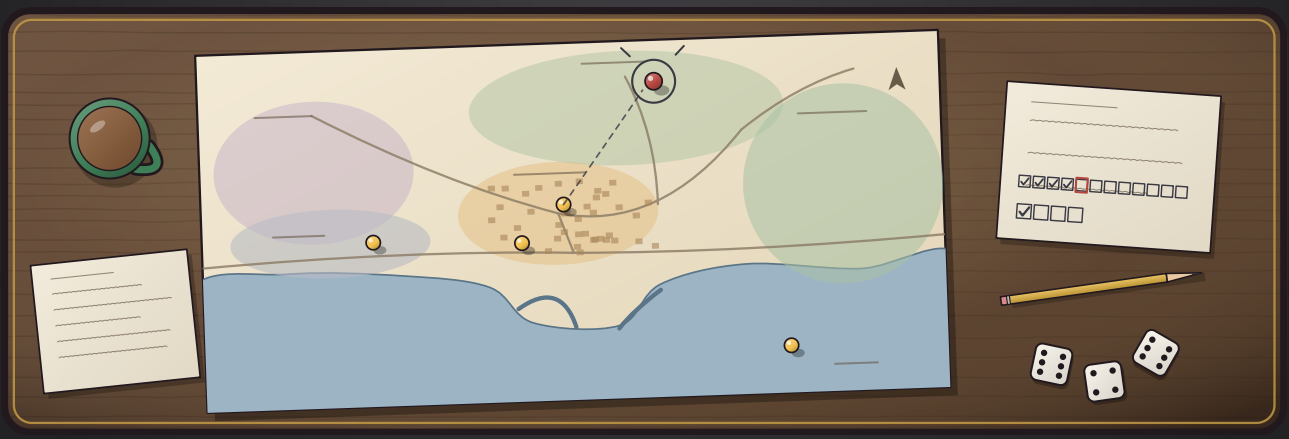
Episode 4. A fifth player joins with Ruth Penhale (Wild). The coven's lowest witches have had one raise, so Ruth gets one; she raises Nerve to 2. She shares the Book and its page on the Ash Widow, and brings no Scar. Marco starts with 1 Hurt. The Quiet Man returns in a Standard episode. With 4 witches, his Toughness is 3 × 4 = 12, plus 2 × 4 = 8 for the season, plus 2 for returning: 22. After this episode, every witch, Ruth included, raises another rating, and threats will have 4 more Toughness per witch.

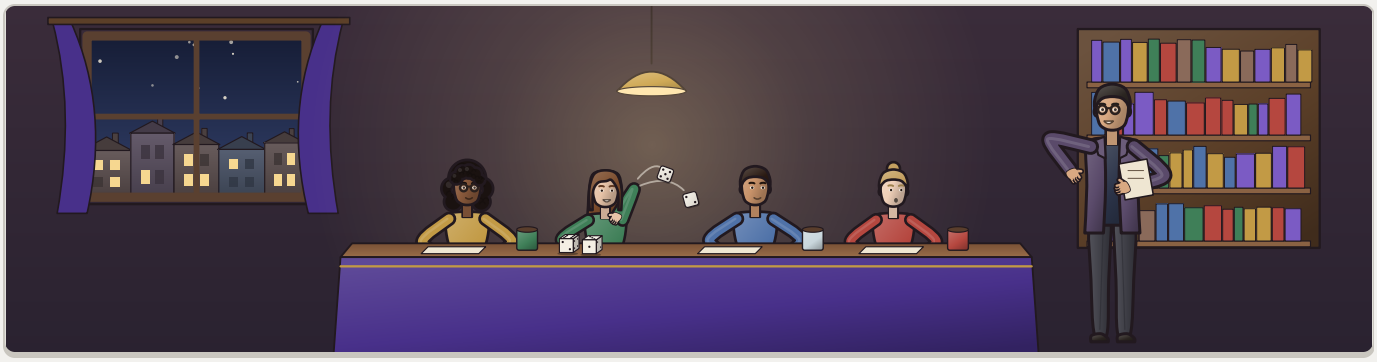


PART TWO

Running the Game

This part is for the Storyteller. It shows how to run an episode from the opening to the closing, how to play each threat by its table, how to roll up a new episode in a few minutes, and how to get a new group playing in under half an hour.





CHAPTER 9

Running an Episode

You are the Storyteller. You play Larkhaven and everyone in it, the threat included. The players have the witches and the guardian. Your job is to give them a frightening night, real choices and a fair fight.

The Storyteller's job

- **Set the scene:** where the coven is, what they see, who is there.
- **Set the Difficulty** when the label doesn't.
- **Say the cost** of a Partial or a Failure.
- **Run the threat** by its d6 table. You roll; the table decides.
- **Keep the tracks** on the episode tracker.

You are not playing against the players. The dice bring the danger; you bring the city to life. Be a fan of the witches: make their wins feel big and their losses feel real.

When the rules don't set a Difficulty, choose 1 to 4. With 3 dice, a witch succeeds about 88% of the time at Difficulty 1, 50% at 2 and 13% at 3. At 4 they need extra dice.

Choosing the label

Every episode has a **label**: Easy, Standard or Hard. It sets the episode's numbers from the table in Chapter 6: the Lead Difficulty, the threat's stats, the Clues needed and the Exposure boxes. Set every number at the start of the episode; they don't change if someone joins or leaves. Below, **w** is the number of witches and **n** is the witches plus the guardian, if a player plays it.

Here is what each label feels like, from 36,000 simulated episodes.

- **Easy** is for first nights and new players. About 85% of Easy episodes end in a Win and the rest in a Partial; almost none end in a Loss. A witch goes Down in only 2% of episodes, and the threat almost never reaches the Showdown mark.
- **Standard** is the normal game. About 73% Wins and 8% Losses. A witch goes Down in about two episodes in five (39%), and about one in five (21%) ends with the threat coming to the coven in a public place.
- **Hard** is for a coven that wants real danger. About 59% Wins and 23% Losses. A witch goes Down in most episodes (61%), and about a third (34%) end in a public showdown.

Group size moves these by a few points. At Standard, for example, Wins run from 67% (five witches) to 79% (two witches and a guardian player). Start new players on Easy.

Setting up the episode tracker

1. **Count the coven: w** and **n**.
2. **Clues needed:** mark the total, and half, rounded up.
3. **Toughness:** cross out the boxes you don't need. Against 3 witches with no guardian player, the threat has 3 more.
4. **Exposure:** 5 boxes at Easy, 4 at Standard and Hard. **Doom:** 12 boxes, the mark at 5.
5. **The threat's line:** Defence (1 higher until the coven knows the Weakness), Danger, Hit, attacks a round (1 against 3 characters, 2 against 4 or 5), and the Unmaking's Difficulty (the number of witches, +2 without the Weakness).
6. **No guardian player?** Leave the "guardian called" box empty.

Doom, Exposure and Clues start at 0. Put the tracker where everyone can see Doom.

PLAYERS	GUARDIAN PLAYER	W	N	TOUGHNESS (EASY / STANDARD / HARD)	CLUES NEEDED, HALF IN BRACKETS (EASY / STANDARD / HARD)	ATTACKS A ROUND	UNMAKING DIFFICULTY
3	no	3	3	12 / 12 / 15	9 (5) / 11 (6) / 12 (6)	1	3
3	yes	2	3	6 / 6 / 8	9 (5) / 11 (6) / 12 (6)	1	2
4	no	4	4	12 / 12 / 16	12 (6) / 15 (8) / 16 (8)	2	4
4	yes	3	4	9 / 9 / 12	12 (6) / 15 (8) / 16 (8)	2	3
5	no	5	5	15 / 15 / 20	15 (8) / 19 (10) / 20 (10)	2	5
5	yes	4	5	12 / 12 / 16	15 (8) / 19 (10) / 20 (10)	2	4

This table works out the Chapter 6 numbers for each group. The Unmaking column is with the Weakness; add 2 without it. In a season, threats grow (Chapter 8).

Framing scenes and leads

The opening. The threat strikes: something strange and frightening happens to someone in Larkhaven. Then tell each witch what their Life wants this episode. They can answer it in any scene, so they need to know from the start. The opening isn't a scene: nobody takes an action or rolls. Whatever the players want to do as it ends, such as chase the stranger or help the victim, becomes their first lead in scene 1.

A scene. The investigation runs in scenes. In each one:

1. Say what has changed and where things stand. Offer two or three leads.
2. Go round the table. Each character takes one action: follow a lead out in the city, research the Book at home, brew at home, rest, cover up with Hide, or answer their Life. The guardian can research the Book but can't brew.
3. Resolve each roll and mark its cost.
4. Doom +1. Show the threat's plan moving: a new victim, a new sign. Each ready-made episode has some, under "As Doom rises".
5. Check the Showdown mark. If Doom has reached 5, the threat comes to the coven. If not, and the coven has half the Clues, it may go to the threat.

Before the showdown the threat has no attacks. It shows itself through Doom and through costs.

The guardian. If a player plays the guardian, tell them before the coven goes to the threat, while there is still a scene to rest in: the guardian is strongest when it comes to the showdown rested and with Ward left. A guardian that goes Down to the first attack sits out the fight.

Leads. A **talking lead** uses Heart: a witness, a neighbour, a nurse on the night shift. A **searching lead** uses Wits: a burned room, an old map, a phone full of photos. **Reveal** is a lead using Craft (1 Magic). All three happen out in the city, against the Lead Difficulty. The **Book** is a lead at home: Wits, +1 die, no Exposure, one character per scene. The written leads are a starting kit, not a fence: when a player thinks of someone to ask or somewhere to look, that's a lead too. A lead can be followed again; show something new there each time.

What Clues tell. The first few show what is happening. At half, tell the coven plainly what the threat is and name its hidden place; if one lead takes them from under half to half or more, that lead tells them. With all of them, tell them its Weakness. Knowing it is enough: the coven has what it needs as part of the story (Chapter 7). Extra Clues past the total are lost.

EXAMPLE: GO NOW, OR STAY?

Standard. Dana, June and Quinn are the witches, and a fourth player plays Rook, so w = 3 and n = 4. The coven needs 15 Clues; half is 8. At the end of scene 4, Doom rises from 3 to 4. The coven has 9 Clues, so it knows the threat is the Ash Widow, hiding in the burned-out theatre on the Docks.

If they go now, the fight is in the theatre and Hannah, the innocent, isn't there. But without the Weakness the Ash Widow's Defence is 3, not 2, and the Unmaking needs 5 successes, not 3. If they stay to hunt the last 6 Clues, Doom reaches 5 at the end of the next scene, and the Ash Widow comes to them at the harbour fireworks with Hannah in her grip. They go.

When a Life fits

A witch's **Life** adds 1 die, inside the +2 limit, when you agree it fits. Say yes when the job gives a real edge: the nurse knows how a hospital works at night, the bus driver knows every street and every regular, the student can get into the library after hours. About one roll in three is a good rate.

The Life also **calls** once per episode. Answering takes the witch's action for that scene, needs no roll, and gives 1 Magic. Play it as a short scene: a shift, a lesson, a family dinner. If a witch hasn't answered by the showdown, they lose 1 Magic (or take 1 Hurt if they have none). Make the call matter.

Costs, and what to describe

A **Partial** works, with a cost. A **Failure** doesn't work, and there is a cost. The rules set the cost:

- **In a showdown:** 1 Hurt.
- **Otherwise:** Exposure +1 if the witch was casting out in the city, or else 1 Hurt.

Casting means using a Power, a spell, a potion or a guardian gift. Hide's cost is always 1 Hurt. Book research and brewing are at home, so their cost is 1 Hurt.

Mark the cost first, then describe it. A Hurt is a twisted ankle, a cut hand, a bad scare. An Exposure is a passer-by filming, a scream, a story in the morning paper. Never add a second cost. Before a risky roll, say what it could cost.

A **Critical** does one thing extra, as fits: +1 damage, +1 Clue, +1 potion or –1 more Exposure. If none fits, the witch gets +1 die on their next roll this episode (inside the +2 limit). You decide which fits.

Running the threat

In the showdown the threat acts once a round: first in round 1, then after the characters in every later round. On its turn:

1. **Count its attacks:** 1 against 3 characters, 2 against 4 or 5. Like every number, this is set at the start of the episode.
2. **Lost attacks.** If Bind, Force's Surge or a Binding potion made it lose its next attack, cross one off. It loses at most one attack a round; any more are wasted.
3. **For each attack left, roll a d6** and read the move table in Chapter 10, which also says whom each signature move targets. Roll even for an attack the guardian's Hold has aimed. On a 6 the signature move still happens (or a free, unguarded innocent is taken); if the move attacks, the guardian is its first target, and Hold is used up. A part of a move that isn't an attack, such as Lure's Heart roll, still happens.
4. **Before the target rolls,** the guardian may Shield (1 Ward, once a round: it takes the attack instead). Then a Sight witch may Surge (2 Magic, once per showdown) to make it miss. Shield is chosen first. Someone under Shelter can't be hurt by its attacks and doesn't roll to defend.
5. **The target rolls Nerve,** plus a Power that fits (Sight or Veil), against Danger. Success: no Hurt. Partial: 1 Hurt. Failure: Hurt equal to Hit.

The table decides who it attacks; you don't hold back or go easy. Ties are common, above all in round 1, when nobody is hurt yet: roll a die among the tied characters. Your only choice is how the attack looks. Roll the d6 in the open. When the threat is **Broken**, it makes no more rolls or moves.

EXAMPLE: THE THREAT'S TURN

Round 2 of a public showdown at Standard. The Ash Widow has Danger 3 and Hit 2. There are four characters, so she makes two attacks. Dana freed Hannah in round 1. This round Dana hit the Ash Widow with Force, so Dana hurt her last, and Rook is guarding Hannah.

First attack: the d6 shows 3, so she goes for whoever hurt her last: Dana. Force doesn't fit defending, so Dana rolls Nerve 3: 5, 4, 1. Two successes against Danger 3 is a Partial: 1 Hurt.

Second attack: the d6 shows 6. Hannah is there and free, so instead of her signature move the Ash Widow goes for Hannah. Rook is guarding Hannah, so the Ash Widow attacks Rook. Rook rolls Nerve 2 and spends 1 Ward for a third die: 6, 4, 2. Two successes: a Partial, 1 Hurt.

Dana used Force this round, which is casting in a public place, so Exposure +1. Then Doom +1.

The innocent

The **innocent** is the person the threat wants. Give them a name, a want and a reason to be liked. During the investigation the coven can talk to them, warn them and keep them close.

But if Doom reaches the Showdown mark, the threat comes to the coven in a public place with the innocent **in its grip**, whatever the coven did for them before. Say that plainly when the players plan.

- To **free** them, a character rolls Nerve against Defence. Only a success frees them; a Partial doesn't, and still costs 1 Hurt. Force fits.
- If they are still in its grip at the end of the first round, they are lost.
- While in its grip they can't be guarded or carried. Once free, a character can **guard** them, and the guardian (or the coven's call) can **Carry** them away.
- Once free, if the threat takes them, they are lost. A Broken threat lets go.

In a hidden showdown the innocent isn't there. If Doom fills, the plan is complete and the innocent is lost. If the coven retreats, or every witch is Down, an innocent still in the fight is lost. In all three cases, one already carried to safety isn't, though the result is still a Loss.

Other people the coven meets don't need stats. Talking to them is a lead against the Lead Difficulty.

Public showdowns and Exposure

Exposure is how close ordinary people are to seeing magic. Out in the city it rises when a casting roll (other than Hide) costs something. In a **public** showdown it rises by 1 in every round in which anyone was casting (once per round). That makes every Power die a choice: a witch may leave their Power off a roll, and then it isn't casting, unless it's a spell or uses a potion. The guardian's Hold isn't casting either. Veil's Surge, used with Hide, hides all the coven's casting for this round and the next. Hide (Difficulty 2) lowers Exposure by 1, never below 0, until the coven is Seen. A hidden showdown has no such rise. Describe the crowd: people film, shout, run and stare.

Seen

When Exposure is full, the coven is **Seen**. It stays full, and Hide can no longer lower it. Any further rise becomes Doom +1 instead (once per round or scene), except once the threat is Broken. At the end, being Seen drops the result one step (Chapter 7). Show it in the closing: a video that went round, a reporter at the door.

Keeping the round order

Round 1 runs: the threat's attacks, the characters' actions, the innocent, Exposure, Doom. Later rounds run: the characters' actions, the threat's attacks, Exposure, Doom. The characters act in any order; each takes one action or does nothing. The episode ends at once, and the round's later steps don't happen, when the threat is destroyed, flees, or Doom fills, or when the coven retreats. It also ends when every witch is Down at the end of a round. Keep the box below in front of you.

THE STORYTELLER'S ROUND

1. **Retreat?** At the start of any round, the coven may retreat. Everyone leaves together. It's a Loss, but nobody gets a Scar. An innocent still in the fight is lost.
2. **Attacks and actions.** Round 1: the threat attacks first, then the characters act. Later rounds: the characters act, then the threat attacks. For each attack, roll a d6 on the move table; the target rolls Nerve against Danger.
3. **The innocent (round 1 only).** Still in its grip? They are lost.
4. **Exposure.** In a public place, if anyone was casting this round: +1, once. If it was already full: Doom +1 instead (not once the threat is Broken).
5. **Doom +1** (not once the threat is Broken). Every witch Down? It's a Loss, and an innocent still in the fight is lost. Broke last round? It flees.

Endings

Chapter 7 has the results: Win, Partial and Loss, what Seen does to them, and Scars. Say the result plainly, then play the **closing**: Life scenes and consequences, such as a date that went well or a shift that went badly. Nobody dies from the dice. Chapter 8 has what carries over: Book pages, returning threats, Scars and growth.

Pacing a session

An episode takes 2 to 3 hours. Doom is your clock: one box per scene, one per round.

PART	TIME	NOTES
Setup	25 minutes	First night (Chapter 12); about 5 minutes after that
Opening	10 minutes	The threat strikes; give out the Life calls

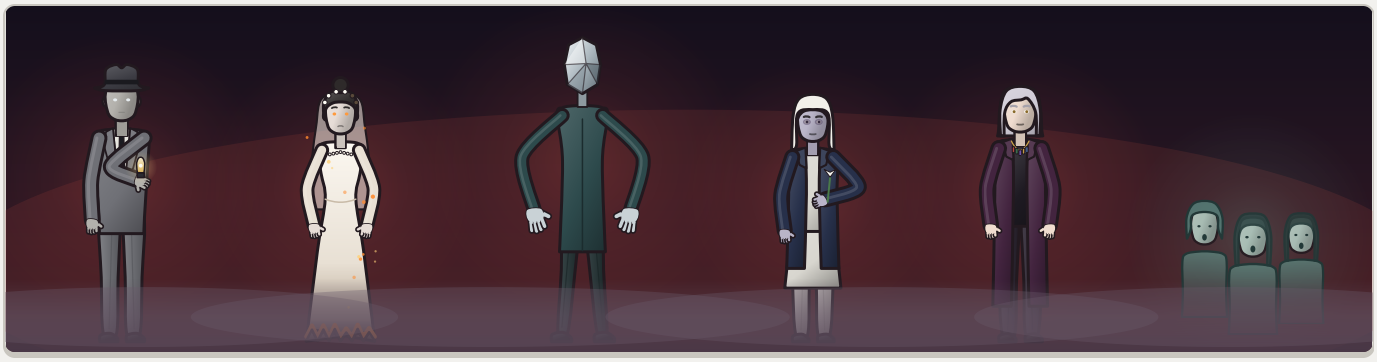
PART	TIME	NOTES
Investigation	60–80 minutes	Usually 3 scenes at Easy and 4 at Standard or Hard; about 20 minutes a scene
Showdown	30–40 minutes	Usually 2 rounds at Easy, 3 at Standard and 4 at Hard
Closing	10–15 minutes	Life scenes and consequences

Keep each action short: what they do, the roll, what happens. If a scene drags, end it.

Tone

- **13 and up.** Supernatural drama with humour. Witch life, family and romance run alongside the threat.
- **Frightening, not gory.** Show the fear: the cold, the silence, a voice that's wrong. Don't show wounds in detail.
- **Deaths happen off the page.** A lost innocent is gone: taken, never found, or a name in the paper. You never describe a death.
- **Romance** is an optional story thread with no rules, mostly with people from the witches' everyday lives.
- **Respect real faiths.** Real witchcraft and Wicca are living religions. Don't mock them, and don't use real symbols, such as the pentacle, as a sign of evil. The demons and spirits here belong to this game, not to any real religion.
- **Ask first.** Before the first night, ask the players if there's anything they don't want in the game, and leave it out.





CHAPTER 10

Threats

Every episode has one threat: a demon, a spirit, a rogue witch, a cursed thing or a creature. It wants something, and Doom shows how close it is to getting it. This chapter shows how threats work, gives the one table every threat uses in a fight, and describes the six threats that haunt Larkhaven.

How threat stats work

Every threat has four stats. **Defence** is the Difficulty to hurt it. **Danger** is the Difficulty to defend against it. **Hit** is the Hurt it does when a defence fails. **Toughness** is the damage that Breaks it.

A threat has no numbers of its own. Every threat takes its Defence, Danger, Hit and Toughness from its episode's label, in the numbers table in Chapter 6. Each stat block below repeats them. The Ash Widow is as tough as the Quiet Man at the same label. What makes them different is the story: the plan, the Weakness, the places and the signature move.

Toughness depends on **w**, the number of witches. The guardian doesn't count. Against a coven of 3 witches and no guardian player, the threat has 3 more Toughness. Damage past its Toughness is lost.

> **EXAMPLE: TOUGHNESS**
>
> The Mirror Thief at Hard, against June, Tess and Noor with no guardian player: 4 × 3 + 3 = 15 Toughness. If a fourth player joins as Rook before the episode starts, it's 4 × 3 = 12, since the extra 3 is only against 3 witches with no guardian player.

The Weakness. Until the coven knows it, the threat's Defence is 1 higher. Once it knows it, attack rolls (including Blast) that work do 1 more damage; potions don't. Without the Weakness, the Unmaking is 2 harder.

Attacks. A threat makes 1 attack a round against 3 characters, and 2 against 4 or 5. It loses at most one attack a round, whatever the cause; any more are wasted.

Broken. When its Toughness is full, it is Broken. It makes no more rolls or moves, Doom stops rising, and it flees at the end of the next round. Only the Unmaking destroys it. If it gets away, it has been **driven off**.

Seasons. Threats grow during a season. Chapter 8 has the rules; in short:

- After the 2nd and the 4th episodes, threats get 2 more Toughness per witch (so 4 more per witch from the 5th episode on).
- A threat that wasn't destroyed comes back when the Storyteller chooses, with 2 more Toughness for each time it escaped.
- A destroyed threat gets a page in the Book. Next time, the coven starts with half the Clues (rounded up).

For example, in the 3rd episode of a season, a Standard threat against 4 witches has 3 × 4 + 2 × 4 = 20 Toughness. From the 5th episode on, it has 3 × 4 + 4 × 4 = 28.

The move table

All threats share one move table: roll a d6 for each attack (Chapter 7 has it in full). On 1–3 it attacks whoever hurt it last, on 4–5 whoever has the most Hurt, and on a 6 it uses its signature move, unless the innocent is there and free. What follows is what the Storyteller needs to run it.

- **Defending.** The target rolls Nerve, plus a Power that fits (Sight or Veil), against Danger. Success: no Hurt. Partial: 1 Hurt. Failure: Hurt equal to Hit.

- **The innocent.** Taking them isn't an attack, so Hold can't stop it. A freed innocent who is taken is lost.
- **Signature move targets.** A move picks only standing characters. A move's "one attack" is aimed like a 4–5: whoever has the most Hurt marked and is still standing. "Two different characters" means the most Hurt and the next most Hurt, both standing. Ties: roll a die among them.
- **Hold.** If the guardian's Hold works, the threat's next attack must target the guardian. Still roll the d6. On a 6 the signature move still happens (or a free, unguarded innocent is taken); if it is an attacking move, the guardian is its first target, and Hold is used up. An attack on the innocent's guard goes to the guardian instead (Hold is used up); taking an unguarded innocent isn't an attack, so Hold stays. Hold aims only the attack in a move: under Hold, Lure's attack goes to the guardian, and its Heart roll still happens. Hold isn't casting.
- **Shield, Shelter and Sight.** The guardian's Shield takes an attack meant for someone near it; in a showdown, everyone is near. On the same attack, Shield is chosen before Sight's Surge. Someone under Shelter can't be hurt by the threat's attacks and doesn't roll to defend. Sight's Surge makes one attack miss; that isn't a lost attack.

EXAMPLE: A SIGNATURE MOVE

A hidden showdown at Standard: the Ash Widow (Danger 3) against Marco, Tess and Noor. The innocent isn't there, so a 6 means her signature move, Cinders: attack every character, but Hit is 1. All three are standing, so all three defend.

Marco rolls Nerve 3: 6, 4, 2. Two successes: a Partial, 1 Hurt. Tess rolls Nerve 3 plus Veil's 2 dice: 5, 5, 4, 3, 1. Three successes: no Hurt. Noor rolls Nerve 1: a 2. A Failure, so Hurt equal to Hit, which is 1. This is a hidden place, so Tess's Veil doesn't raise Exposure.

Reading a stat block

Each threat below has the same lines. The three numbers in each stat are Easy · Standard · Hard. **What it is** and **Plan** say what it wants: the plan is complete if Doom fills. **Signs** are what the coven finds on leads. **Weakness** is what all the Clues reveal. The **hidden place** is where the coven finds it with half the Clues. The **public place** is where it comes, with the innocent in its grip, if Doom reaches the Showdown mark. The **signature move** is its 6 on the move table. **Talks and acts** is how to play it. **If driven off** is what it does when it gets away.

An episode made with the generator in Chapter 11 can give a threat a different plan and different places. Then use the rolled ones.

The Quiet Man

"Thief of voices"



DEFENCE 1·2·2 **DANGER** 1·3·3 **HIT** 2·2·3 **TOUGHNESS** 3×W·3×W·4×W

Easy · Standard · Hard. Defence +1 until the coven knows the Weakness.

What it is: A demon in a grey suit who steals voices.

Plan: Seven stolen voices to sing a door open.

Signs: Singers and speakers who open their mouths and make no sound. Old radios that pick up a choir of stolen voices at night. A man in a grey suit at the edge of every crowd, whose face nobody can describe. Salt lines on a doorstep, swept away.

Weakness: His own name spoken aloud, and salt.

Hidden place: The old radio tower in the Heights.

Public place: The Friday night market.

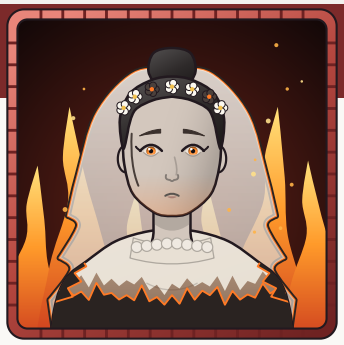
Signature move: **Hush:** attack two different characters; the first one he hurts can't cast on their next action. *Targets: the most Hurt, then the next most Hurt, both standing (ties: roll a die among them); "first" follows that order. On their next action they can't use a Power, cast a spell or use a gift, so they can't lead or join the Unmaking with it. They can't use a potion until Hush ends. It doesn't stop what takes no action: their defence dice, Sight's miss, or a Down witch joining the Unmaking. Hush ends when they next act, or at the end of the next round.*

Talks and acts: He never uses his own voice. He speaks in the voices he has stolen, often one the listener loves. Polite, patient and quietly pleased with himself. He hates his name, and changes the subject when anyone gets close to it.

If driven off: He climbs back to the tower with the voices he has, and waits to collect the rest.

The Ash Widow

"The bride who burned"



DEFENCE 1·2·2 **DANGER** 1·3·3 **HIT** 2·2·3 **TOUGHNESS** 3×W·3×W·4×W

Easy · Standard · Hard. Defence +1 until the coven knows the Weakness.

What it is: A fire spirit in a burned wedding dress.

Plan: To burn the house where she died, with a bride inside.

Signs: Small fires that burn in perfect rings and never spread. The smell of smoke and orange blossom. Wedding invitations found charred in letterboxes. A woman in a grey-white dress seen in windows that are on fire.

Weakness: Water from the harbour, blessed by a coven.

Hidden place: The burned-out theatre on the Docks.

Public place: The harbour fireworks.

Signature move: **Cinders:** attack every character, but Hit is 1. *Targets: every standing character, the guardian included.*

Talks and acts: A crackling whisper, like paper catching. She asks everyone she meets if they are to be married. She is grief more than hate, but grief that burns. She never runs; she walks through the flames.

If driven off: She sinks into the ashes of the theatre and waits for the next wedding in Larkhaven.

The Mirror Thief

"Wearer of faces"



DEFENCE 1·2·2 **DANGER** 1·3·3 **HIT** 2·2·3 **TOUGHNESS** 3×W·3×W·4×W

Easy · Standard · Hard. Defence +1 until the coven knows the Weakness.

What it is: A thin creature that wears stolen faces.

Plan: A face to keep forever.

Signs: People whose reflections have gone, and whose friends no longer know them. Mirrors turned to the wall. The same person seen in two places at once. Handprints on the inside of shop windows.

Weakness: Its true reflection: make it look in an old mirror.

Hidden place: Behind the mirrors of a closed department store.

Public place: St Bride's market hall.

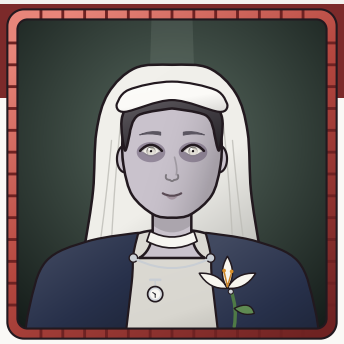
Signature move: **Borrowed Face:** attack the witch with the most Magic left; on a Failure they also lose 1 Magic. *The standing witch with the most Magic; ties: roll a die among them. Under Hold it attacks the guardian, which loses 1 Ward instead.*

Talks and acts: It wears the face of someone you trust and speaks in their voice, but it gets small things wrong: a name, a joke, which hand they write with. Vain and hungry. It turns away from old glass.

If driven off: It slips into the nearest mirror, wearing the last face it took.

The Night Nurse

"The one who sits by the bed"



DEFENCE 1·2·2 **DANGER** 1·3·3 **HIT** 2·2·3 **TOUGHNESS** 3×W·3×W·4×W

Easy · Standard · Hard. Defence +1 until the coven knows the Weakness.

What it is: A creature that feeds on the sleeping sick.

Plan: One more night of feeding before the moon turns.

Signs: Patients on the night wards who sleep and won't wake. Cold grey handprints on blankets. A nurse nobody on the rota knows, seen at the end of a corridor at three in the morning. The smell of lilies. Old iron bed frames wrapped in cloth.

Weakness: Iron, and being called by the name of someone it killed.

Hidden place: The closed wing of Larkhaven General.

Public place: The hospital car park at shift change.

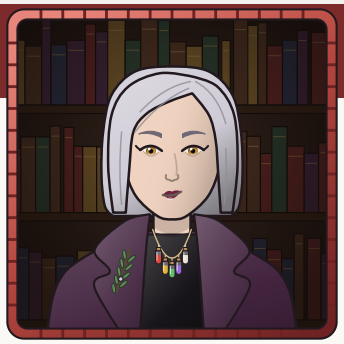
Signature move: **Drain:** one attack; if it does any Hurt, the threat clears 2 damage. *Target: whoever has the most Hurt marked and is still standing (ties: roll a die among them).*

Talks and acts: Soft, kind and endlessly patient. It calls everyone "dear". It never hurries. It looks at the hurt the way a hungry person looks at food. It keeps the names of the ones it fed on, and doesn't like to hear them.

If driven off: It lies down in an empty bed in the closed wing and sleeps until the moon turns again.

Vesper Crane

"The witch who takes"



DEFENCE 1·2·2 **DANGER** 1·3·3 **HIT** 2·2·3 **TOUGHNESS** 3×W·3×W·4×W

Easy · Standard · Hard. Defence +1 until the coven knows the Weakness.

What it is: A witch who stole other witches' power.

Plan: The coven's Book.

Signs: Other witches in the city who wake with their magic gone. Second-hand bookshops broken into, with only the old books on magic taken. A tall woman in a long coat reading in the library after it has closed. Torn-out pages that smell of burnt rosemary.

Weakness: The spell she broke to steal her power, read back to her.

Hidden place: The library's locked basement.

Public place: The university graduation.

Signature move: **Turned Spell:** one attack with Hit 1 higher. *Target: whoever has the most Hurt marked and is still standing (ties: roll a die among them).*

Talks and acts: Charming, clever and sure she is right. She offers the coven a deal before any fight. She thinks power belongs to whoever can hold it, and calls the coven "children". She studies their spells and throws them back.

If driven off: She disappears with everything she learned about the coven, and comes back better prepared.

The Drowned Choir

"The village under the sea"



DEFENCE 1·2·2 **DANGER** 1·3·3 **HIT** 2·2·3 **TOUGHNESS** 3×W·3×W·4×W

Easy · Standard · Hard. Defence +1 until the coven knows the Weakness.

What it is: Ghosts of a village the sea took.

Plan: One more voice for the choir.

Signs: Singing over the marsh at dusk, many voices as one. Wet footprints that lead into the sea, and none that come back. People humming an old song nobody taught them. At low tide, the top of a church tower showing above the mud.

Weakness: A bell from the drowned church, rung at low tide.

Hidden place: The drowned village in Saltmarsh at low tide.

Public place: The long pier at dusk.

Signature move: **Lure:** one attack; then the standing character with the lowest Heart rolls Heart against Danger (no Hurt on a Partial or a Failure); on a Failure they lose their next action. *The attack is aimed like a 4–5: whoever has the most Hurt marked and is still standing (ties: roll a die among them). It is an attack, so Hold, Shield, Shelter and Sight's Surge work on it as usual. The Heart roll isn't an attack, so they don't stop it: under Hold, the attack goes to the guardian and the Heart roll still happens. The Heart roll can fall on the guardian too (ties for the lowest Heart: roll a die among them). The lost action is this round's if they haven't acted yet, or else next round's. A witch who lost their action can still join the Unmaking without one, like a Down witch.*

Talks and acts: They never speak alone. They sing, all together, in old-fashioned words. They are lonely, not cruel, and they don't understand what they take. A bell makes them fall silent and listen.

If driven off: The tide comes in and they sink back under the marsh, still one voice short, to wait for the next low tide.

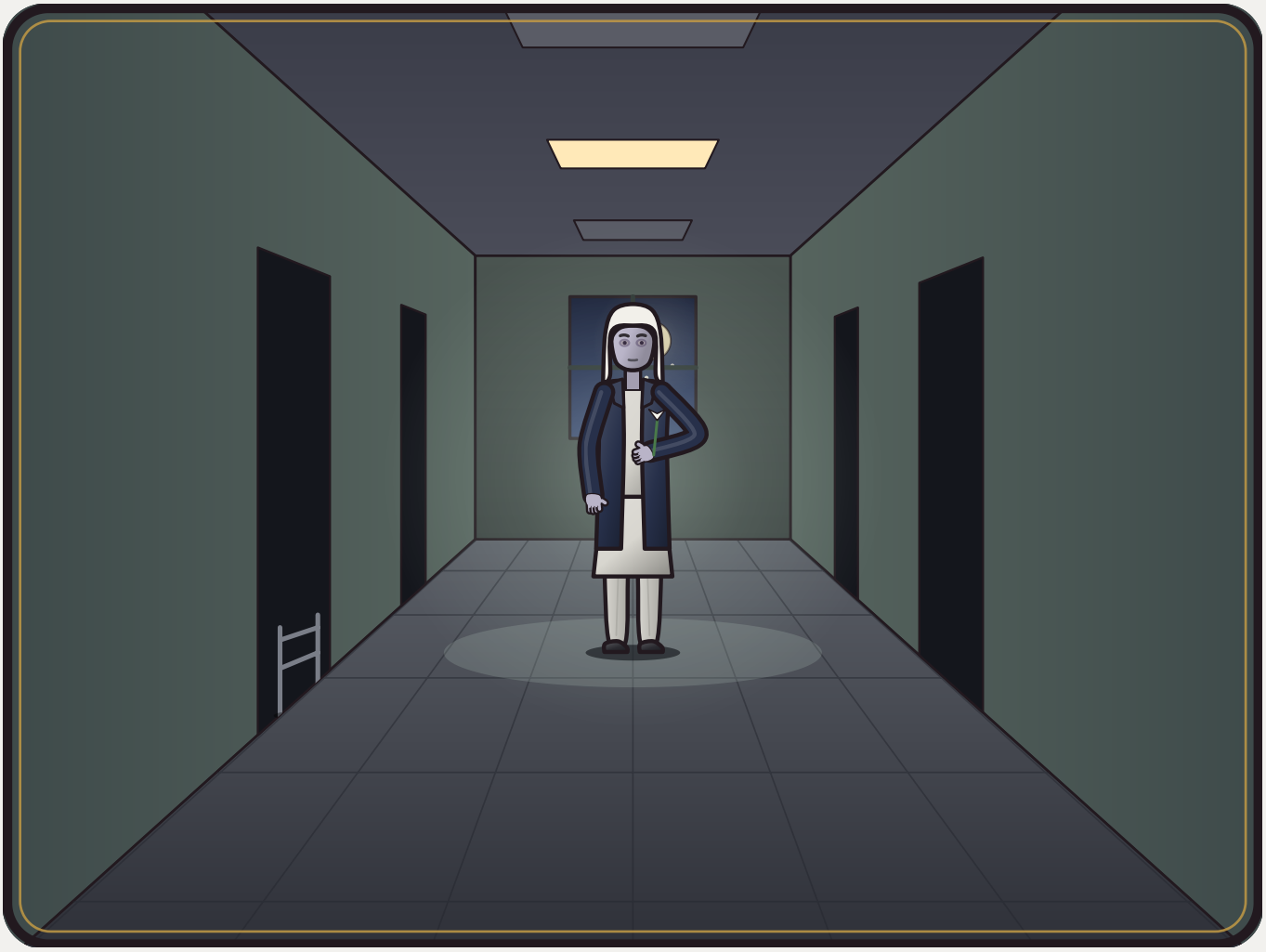
Making your own threat

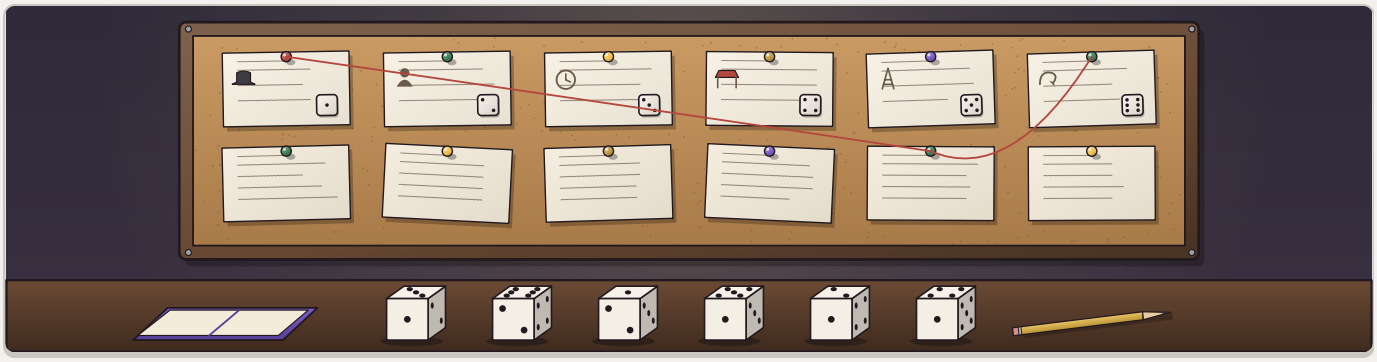
A new threat needs the same stat block and a little story.

Don't give it numbers of its own: its Defence, Danger, Hit and Toughness come from the label.

- **What it is:** a demon, a spirit, a rogue witch, a cursed thing or a creature, in one line.
- **A plan:** what it wants, and what the world looks like if Doom fills. In the rules, a full Doom always means the innocent is lost and the threat escapes.
- **A Weakness:** something the coven can find out and bring to the fight. A thing and a way to use it works well: salt and a name, a bell rung at low tide.
- **Two places:** a hidden place where it hides, and a public place where it would strike with a crowd watching. Give each two ways in and out.
- **Signs, a voice and a getaway:** three or four signs for the leads, a line on how it talks and acts, and what it does if driven off.
- **A signature move** about as strong as "attack two different characters". The six above show the range: two attacks with a small extra, every character at Hit 1, one attack with a side effect. Keep it to one move. Say exactly who it affects, so you never have to choose.

Last, check the name. It shouldn't belong to a famous book, film or show.





CHAPTER 11

Making Episodes

Part Three has three ready-made episodes. When you've played them, or want something new, roll one up. Six dice give you a threat, an innocent, a plan, two places and a twist. Half an hour of notes turns them into a night's play.

What an episode needs

Every episode, ready-made or rolled, has the same parts:

- an **opening**: the threat strikes;
- an **innocent**: the person the threat wants;
- a **threat**, with its stat block from Chapter 10;
- a **label** and the **Clues needed**;
- **six leads**: two talking, two searching, one Book research and one for Reveal, with what each kind of Clue tells;
- a d6 table of **Life calls** for the episode;
- a **hidden place** and a **public place**, each with two ways in and out;
- one **twist**;
- a **closing**.

The generator

Roll each table once. Any result works with any other.

D6	THREAT	INNOCENT	PLAN (WHAT HAPPENS AT DOOM 12)
1	The Quiet Man	A local celebrity	Takes the innocent away for good
2	The Ash Widow	A child	Opens a door for something worse
3	The Mirror Thief	A witch's relative	Takes the innocent's face, voice or name
4	The Night Nurse	A stranger with a gift	Feeds and grows stronger (next time it returns, +2 Toughness)
5	Vesper Crane	Someone who saw too much	Steals something from the coven (the Book, a memory)
6	The Drowned Choir	Someone the threat once loved	Ends a family line

D6	PUBLIC PLACE	HIDDEN PLACE	TWIST
1	The night market	An abandoned building	A witch's Life is tied to the innocent
2	A festival	Under the city (tunnels, basements)	A second, weaker threat is helping
3	A hospital	A place the sea or river covers	The innocent doesn't want to be saved
4	A school or university	A closed shop or theatre	The threat was once a witch
5	A ferry, pier or station	The old radio tower or the observatory	A reporter is following the coven (start with Exposure 1)
6	A wedding, funeral or party	Somewhere the coven knows well	None

READING THE ROLLS

- **Threat.** Use its stat block. Keep its Weakness and signature move; the rolled plan and places replace its own. If the coven has destroyed this threat before, this is another of its kind, and the Book has a page on it: the coven starts with half the Clues (rounded up). If it escaped before, it comes back with 2 more Toughness for each time it escaped.
- **Plan.** Every plan is story only: it is what a full Doom looks like. In the rules a full Doom always means the same thing: the innocent is lost and the threat escapes. Plan 4's +2 Toughness is on top of the usual +2 for a threat that wasn't destroyed, so after that escape it comes back with 4 more.
- **A witch's relative** and **a witch's Life is tied to the innocent:** pick a witch someone is playing, and ask that player who the person is.
- **Somewhere the coven knows well:** a place from a witch's Life, or a café or park they love. Never the Lantern House itself: threats can't come inside uninvited.
- **A second, weaker threat is helping:** the helper is story only. It has no stats and never fights. It leaves signs and gives the leads something to find.
- **A reporter is following the coven:** Exposure starts at 1 instead of 0.

From rolls to an episode

1. **Pick the label and work out the numbers** from the table in Chapter 6. The lookup table in Chapter 9 has them worked out for each group: Toughness, Clues needed, attacks a round and the Unmaking's Difficulty.
2. **Write the opening.** The threat strikes someone near the innocent, or someone like them. Use one of the threat's signs. Keep it short and strange: one scene, one image, one scream or one silence.
3. **Make the innocent a person.** Give them a name, a job, something they want this week, and the reason the threat wants them.
4. **Write six leads.** Two talking leads (Heart): people who saw something. Two searching leads (Wits): places with something to find. One Book lead: what the coven's spellbook says, researched at home. One Reveal lead: something hidden that only magic shows. For each, write who or where it is and a line on what it tells.
5. **Place the two locations.** The hidden place is where the coven finds the threat with half the Clues; the innocent isn't there. The public place is where the threat comes, with the innocent in its grip, if Doom reaches 5. Give each two ways in and out: a door and a roof, a ramp and a fire escape.
6. **Decide when the twist comes out.** Tie it to a lead or to a Doom number, so it lands in the middle of the investigation.
7. **Write the Life calls** (below).
8. **Write the closing:** one line each for a Win, a Partial and a Loss.

Also note what the threat does as Doom rises: a new victim at Doom 2, a move on the innocent at Doom 4. That gives every scene's end something to show.

How many Clues

Chapter 6 sets the Clues needed, from the label and **n** (the witches plus the guardian, if a player plays it). This lookup works them out for each group, with the half that tells the coven what and where.

N	EASY	STANDARD	HARD
3	9 (half 5)	11 (half 6)	12 (half 6)
4	12 (half 6)	15 (half 8)	16 (half 8)
5	15 (half 8)	19 (half 10)	20 (half 10)

Don't tie a number of Clues to each lead. The dice decide how many Clues the coven finds; the leads tell you what those Clues say. Then write three lines for the whole episode: what early Clues show (what is happening), what the coven learns at half (what the threat is and where), and what the last Clue gives (the Weakness).

Life calls

Each witch's Life calls once per episode. Write a d6 table with one call for each Life, tied to this episode if you can. A witch answers in any scene: it takes their action, needs no roll and gives 1 Magic. If they haven't answered by the showdown, they lose 1 Magic (or take 1 Hurt if they have none). Here is a table for any episode:

D6	LIFE	THE CALL
1	Student	An exam, a deadline or a group project that can't wait
2	Nurse	An extra shift on a short-staffed ward
3	Shop worker	A late delivery, a stocktake, or the boss turning up
4	Teacher	Parents' evening, a school trip or a pupil in trouble
5	Mechanic	A rush job for a customer who won't take no
6	Bus driver	A night route nobody else will cover

A worked example: The Face in the Glass

Four players: June, Tess and Noor are the witches, and the fourth player plays Rook. The Storyteller rolls the six tables: **3, 6, 2, 5, 6, 4**.

- **Threat (3):** the Mirror Thief.
- **Innocent (6):** someone the threat once loved.
- **Plan (2):** opens a door for something worse.
- **Public place (5):** a ferry, pier or station.
- **Hidden place (6):** somewhere the coven knows well.
- **Twist (4):** the threat was once a witch.

THE NUMBERS

Standard, w = 3, n = 4. Lead Difficulty 2. Defence 2 (3 until the Weakness is known), Danger 3, Hit 2. Toughness 9 (3 × 3; no extra 3, since a player plays the guardian). Clues needed 15 (4 × 4 − 1), half 8. Exposure 4 boxes. Doom 12, mark at 5. Two attacks a round (four characters). The Unmaking's Difficulty is 3, or 5 without the Weakness. Signature move: Borrowed Face. Weakness: its true reflection (make it look in an old mirror).

THE STORY

Sixty years ago a young witch called Mae Ardley lived at the Lantern House. She was afraid of growing old, and she found a spell to be seen forever. It worked too well. It pulled her into the mirrors, and over the years she became the Mirror Thief. Now it has found a door behind the glass, and it needs one face to open it: the face of the man who loved her. If the door opens, the Mirror Thief steps out for good, and it leaves the door open behind it.

THE OPENING

On the last ferry of the night, a woman glances at the dark window and sees a stranger's face looking back. Then her own reflection is gone. By morning her husband says he doesn't know who she is.

THE INNOCENT

Walter Ashdown, 81, a retired ferry captain who still rides the evening crossing every day. The girl he was going to marry vanished in 1965, and he keeps her photo in his wallet. He is kind, stubborn and doesn't believe in magic.

THE LEADS

- **Talking (Heart): Walter, on the ferry.** He tells of Mae, who stopped looking in mirrors the month before she vanished. Lately, faces from his past keep turning up: his late brother on the quay, his old first mate at the bar.
- **Talking (Heart): the drivers at the night-bus depot.** A new driver nobody hired, seen in the washroom mirrors. Two drivers have lost their reflections. Tess's Life fits here.
- **Searching (Wits): the ferry terminal.** Lost property holds a hand mirror with fingerprints on the inside of the glass. The cameras show a figure walk into a window and not come out.
- **Searching (Wits): the victims' homes.** Every mirror is turned to the wall. Every victim is in an old photo with Walter: it is practising faces from his life.
- **Book research: the attic.** Old pages in a hand nobody knows, signed "M. A.": a spell to be seen forever, written by a witch of this house.
- **Reveal: a mirror the Mirror Thief passed through.** For a moment the glass shows its true face, young and very old at once, and a door behind the glass, standing ajar.

What the Clues tell. Early Clues: people are losing their faces, something in the mirrors is copying faces from Walter's past, and it wants him. At half (8): it is the Mirror Thief, it was once a witch called Mae, and it hides behind the mirrors at the night-bus depot. All 15: make it look at its true reflection in an old mirror, such as Mae's own hand mirror, in a trunk in the attic.

As Doom rises. At Doom 2, a deckhand loses his face. At Doom 4, it visits Walter wearing his brother's face.

THE PLACES

- **Hidden place: the night-bus depot on Ferry Road,** where Tess drives from. The fight is in the old drivers' washroom, a long wall of mirrors. Ways in and out: the drivers' gate from the bus yard, and the fire door to the back lane.
- **Public place: the ferry terminal at the Harbour,** as the evening crossing boards. Ways in and out: the passenger ramp, and the car deck.

THE TWIST

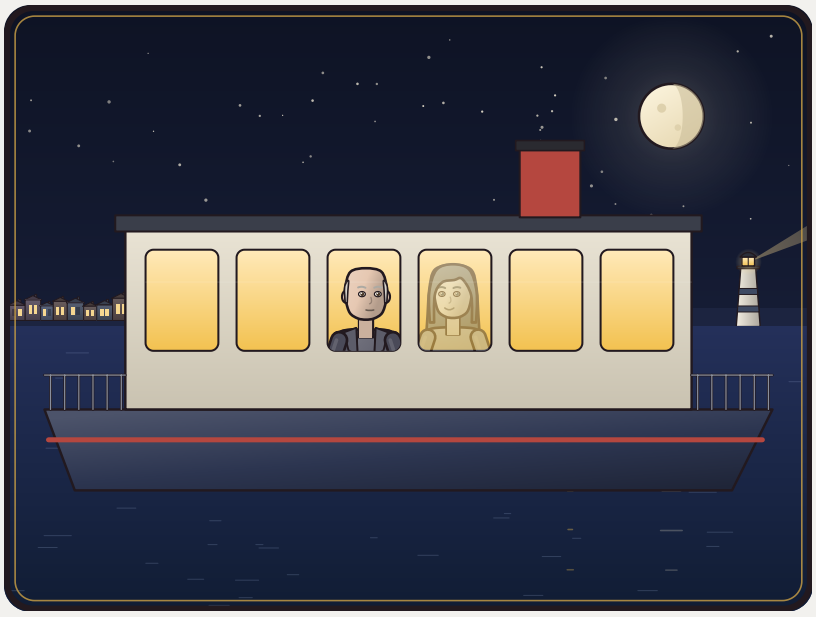
When the coven follows the Book lead, or reaches half the Clues, tell Rook's player that Rook knew her. Rook remembers Mae: how she laughed, and how she stopped. The player decides when Rook says so. It gives no Clues, but now the coven is fighting one of its own.

LIFE CALLS

D6	LIFE	THE CALL
1	Student	June's tutor wants a draft by Friday, and June hasn't started
2	Nurse	Ferry passengers with no reflections are filling a ward
3	Shop worker	Noor's garden centre has a lorry of spring bulbs to unload tonight
4	Teacher	A school trip on the evening ferry needs one more adult
5	Mechanic	The ferry company's van has broken down, and they'll pay double
6	Bus driver	The depot is short of drivers, and Tess is asked to cover the last route

THE CLOSING

- **Win:** Walter looks at the ferry window. For a moment a young woman stands beside him in the glass, smiling, and then she is gone. The coven writes the Mirror Thief's page in the Book, next to Mae's own.
- **Partial:** if it fled, the Mirror Thief slips into the dark glass, wearing the last face it took. If Walter was lost, the ferry sails without him, and his photo of Mae is found on the deck.
- **Loss:** if Doom filled, the door behind the mirrors opens. Walter is gone, and in the morning every mirror in the depot is cracked from the inside. If the coven retreated or every witch went Down, the Mirror Thief slips back into the glass to try again. If Walter was still in the fight, it takes him with it.





CHAPTER 12

The First Night

THIS CHAPTER TAKES A NEW GROUP FROM AN EMPTY table to the first scene in under 30 minutes. Nobody needs to make a character or learn the whole book. The players pick a ready-made witch, learn one roll, and play Episode 1: Night Market at Easy.

Before the night

The Storyteller reads Chapter 9 and Episode 1 (Chapter 14) before the group arrives. That takes about an hour, and it isn't part of the 30 minutes.

Print these:

- **The witch sheet,** six copies. Before the night, fill in one for each ready-made witch in Chapter 13 (Dana, Marco, June, Quinn, Tess and Noor), so the players have a real choice.
- **The guardian sheet,** filled in for Rook.
- **The episode tracker.**
- **The quick reference.** One for each player if you can, and one for you.

All four are at the back of the book. Bring pencils and erasers too.

Dice. You need only six-sided dice: at least 13 for the table to share. The biggest roll with the ready-made witches is the Unmaking with five witches: the leader's Craft 3, plus 2 dice for each of the four who join, plus up to 2 extra dice, makes 13. Once ratings can reach 4 in a season, 14 dice cover the biggest roll: a five-witch Unmaking led by Craft 4 is 4 + 8 + 2. Dice are never compared, so one colour is fine. The Storyteller needs one die for the threat's move table.

Keep the episode pages to yourself. Part Three is for the Storyteller. The players see their sheets, the tracker and the quick reference.

At the table, step by step

STEP	WHAT HAPPENS	MINUTES
1	Welcome and tone	3
2	Pick witches	5
3	Rook, or the call	2
4	Fill in the tracker	3
5	One practice roll	5
6	How an episode runs	5
7	The opening and the Life calls	2
	Total	**25**

1. WELCOME AND TONE

Tell the players what the game is: they are a coven of witches in the harbour city of Larkhaven, and tonight something is hunting an innocent person. Say the tone: for ages 13 and up, frightening but not gory, and deaths happen off the page. Ask if there is anything they don't want in the game, and leave it out.

2. PICK WITCHES

Lay out the six witch sheets. Each player picks one. If two players want the same witch, each rolls a die, and the highest picks; roll again on a tie. Give everyone a minute to read their Power and their Life. Every ready-made witch already has ratings, a Power, a Life, 4 Hurt boxes and 5 Magic.

3. ROOK, OR THE CALL

One player may play **Rook**, the coven's guardian, instead of a witch. Rook helps, heals and protects, but never casts spells, brews or damages a threat. Offer Rook to a player who likes looking after others. Only one player can play Rook: if two want to, each rolls a die, the highest plays Rook, and the other plays a witch.

If nobody plays Rook, Rook stays home guarding the house. Once per episode, on any character's turn, the coven may call it for one Mend or one Carry. Calling takes no action and no roll, and counts as casting. Show the players the "guardian called" box on the tracker.

4. FILL IN THE TRACKER

Episode 1 is Easy. Use the Easy numbers from Chapter 6: Lead Difficulty 1; the threat's Defence 1 (2 until the coven knows the Weakness), Danger 1 and Hit 2; Exposure 5 boxes; Doom 12 boxes with the mark at 5. Read Toughness, Clues needed, attacks a round and the Unmaking's Difficulty off the lookup table in Chapter 9. Doom, Exposure and Clues start at 0.

EXAMPLE: FOUR PLAYERS, ONE PLAYING ROOK

w = 3 witches and n = 4. At Easy: Toughness 3 × 3 = 9 (no extra 3, since a player plays the guardian). Clues needed 3 × 4 = 12, half 6. Exposure 5 boxes. Four characters, so the threat makes two attacks a round. The Unmaking's Difficulty is 3, or 5 without the Weakness.

5. ONE PRACTICE ROLL

Teach the roll with one roll. Pick a player and have them roll their witch's best rating against Difficulty 2. Read the result out together. The practice roll doesn't count in the episode: it has no cost, and a Critical gives no extra die later.

EXAMPLE: THE PRACTICE ROLL

Dana climbs a locked gate: Nerve 3 against Difficulty 2. She rolls three dice: 6, 4, 2. Each 4, 5 or 6 is a success, so that's two: a **Success**.

With one success it would be a **Partial**: half of 2, rounded up, is 1, so she gets over, with a cost. With none it would be a **Failure**: she doesn't, and there's a cost. Out of a fight, the cost is 1 Hurt, or Exposure +1 if she was casting out in the city. If two dice had shown 6, it would have been a **Critical**.

Her Power, Force, adds 2 dice when it fits. On top of that she can add up to 2 more: a friend's help (1 Magic or Ward each, if they can help in the story), her Life when the Storyteller agrees it fits, the Book, or her own Magic (1 each).

At Easy, leads are Difficulty 1, so a lead has no Partial: one success finds a Clue.

6. HOW AN EPISODE RUNS

Explain this in five minutes, using the tracker:

- **Scenes.** In the investigation, each character takes one action a scene: follow a lead, research the Book, brew, rest, cover up, or answer their Life. At the end of each scene, Doom +1.
- **Clues.** With half the Clues, the coven knows what the threat is and where, and may go to it. With all of them, it knows the Weakness.
- **The mark.** If Doom reaches 5, it's too late: the threat comes to the coven in a public place, with the innocent in its grip.
- **Exposure.** Casting where people can see raises it: a casting roll that costs something out in the city, and every round of casting in a public showdown. If it fills, the coven is Seen, and the result drops a step.
- **Magic.** Unspent Magic is lost at the end of the episode, so spend it. But keep 2: 1 to join the Unmaking, and 1 for a die or a second try.

Leave the showdown rules until the showdown. Teach them when the fight starts.

7. THE OPENING AND THE LIFE CALLS

Read the opening of Night Market. Then tell each witch what their Life wants from them this episode, from the episode's Life-call table. They can answer it in any scene. Then start the first scene.

FIRST-NIGHT CHECKLIST

- Storyteller has read Chapter 9 and Episode 1.
- Printed: six witch sheets filled in with the ready-made witches, Rook's sheet, the episode tracker, quick references.
- At least 13 six-sided dice, pencils and erasers.
- Tone said; lines asked about.
- Witches picked (same witch: roll, highest picks).
- Rook played, or the "guardian called" box shown.
- Tracker filled in at Easy; Doom, Exposure and Clues at 0.
- One practice roll.
- Scenes, Doom, the mark at 5, half and all the Clues, Exposure, and "keep 2 Magic" explained.
- Life calls given out.
- Episode pages kept away from the players.

After the first night

Easy is for learning. A coven almost never loses there. When the group knows the roll, move on.

- **Next, play Standard.** Episode 2: Cinders is Standard. Witches start to go Down, and the threat sometimes reaches the mark.
- **Then Hard,** when the group wants real danger. Episode 3: Low Tide is Hard.
- **Then roll your own** with the generator in Chapter 11.

Seasons. Play the episodes in a row with the same coven and they become a **season**. Chapter 8 has the rules; in short:

- A destroyed threat gets a page in the Book. Next time, the coven starts with half the Clues (rounded up).
- A threat that wasn't destroyed comes back when the Storyteller chooses, with 2 more Toughness for each time it escaped.
- Hurt clears between episodes. The exception is a Scar: a witch who was Down when the coven lost (except by retreating) starts the next episode with 1 Hurt.
- After every second episode, each witch raises one rating by 1 (most 4). Rook doesn't grow.
- After the 2nd and the 4th episodes, threats get 2 more Toughness per witch.

So if you play the three ready-made episodes as a season, Low Tide's threat is tougher than the Hard column alone. Against 4 witches it has $4 \times 4 + 2 \times 4 = 24$ Toughness. The witches are stronger too: each has raised a rating.



PART THREE

Ready to Play

A ready-made coven, the house they share and three episodes to play tonight.





CHAPTER 13

The Coven and the Lantern House

HERE IS A COVEN READY TO PLAY: SIX WITCHES, ONE for each Power, and Rook, the guardian. This chapter also shows the house they share and the city around it. Use them for your first night, or as examples when you make your own.

Using the ready-made coven

Each player picks one witch. One player may pick Rook instead. Copy the numbers onto a witch sheet or the guardian sheet at the back of the book.

- The ratings already follow the rules: 3, 2, 2 and 1, with the 3 where the Power is used most.
- Each witch starts every episode with **5 Magic** and 4 empty Hurt boxes (1 Hurt with a Scar). Rook starts with **5 Ward** and 5 empty Hurt boxes.
- No two of them share a Power or a Life.
- Any witch can be any gender. Change a name, a look or a pronoun if you like. Keep the numbers.

Each entry lists what the witch's Life might fit. These are ideas, not promises: a Life adds 1 die only when the Storyteller agrees it fits.

The witches

Dana Okafor (she)



"Sit down. Let me look at that."

Look: Tall, with short natural hair. Scrubs under a denim jacket, and a silver ring on her left thumb.

Personality: Steady and blunt. Twelve-hour shifts have taught her to stay calm and to have no time for nonsense.

POWER: FORCE

She moves things with her mind. **+2 dice** when it fits: attacks and freeing.

Surge (2 Magic, once per scene, paid before she rolls): on a Partial or better, the threat loses its next attack.

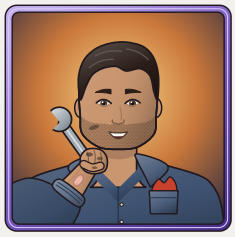
Heart 2 · **Wits** 2 · **Nerve** 3 · **Craft** 1 · **Hurt** 4 · **Magic** 5

Life: Nurse. It might fit first aid, hospitals at night and calming frightened people.

Tie to the coven: She grew up next door to the Lantern House. She saw the lamp from her bedroom window every night of her childhood.

Hook: An old man on her ward, who never has visitors, keeps asking for "the girl from next door to the lamp". He knows things about the house that nobody should.

Marco Rossi (he)



"I can fix that. Probably."

Look: Stocky, with oil on his hands and his sleeves rolled up. A burn scar on his right forearm.

Personality: Loud, kind and quick to laugh. He would rather fix a problem with his hands than talk about it.

POWER: FLAME

He calls fire. **+2 dice** when it fits: attacks.

Surge (2 Magic, once per scene, paid before he rolls): on a Partial or better, 2 more damage.

Heart 2 · **Wits** 1 · **Nerve** 3 · **Craft** 2 · **Hurt** 4 · **Magic** 5

Life: Mechanic. It might fit engines, tools, cars and vans, and the back streets of the Docks.

Tie to the coven: He is a cousin of the family that owns the house. He was round fixing the boiler the day his Flame woke, and the scar is from that day.

Hook: One of his cousins has started talking about selling the Lantern House. Marco hasn't told the others yet.

June Takeda (she)



"Hang on. I wrote that down somewhere."

Look: Small, with round glasses and a yellow raincoat. She always carries a notebook.

Personality: Curious and a little nervous. She writes everything down, and she trusts the Book more than she trusts herself.

POWER: SIGHT

Glimpses of what's coming or what happened. **+2 dice** when it fits: leads, defending and studying.

Surge (2 Magic, once per scene, paid before she rolls): on a Partial or better, 1 more Clue. Or, with no action, before the defence roll, one attack aimed at anyone misses (this isn't a lost attack).

Heart 2 · **Wits** 3 · **Nerve** 1 · **Craft** 2 · **Hurt** 4 · **Magic** 5

Life: Student. It might fit libraries, research, getting into the university after hours, and knowing what students are talking about.

Tie to the coven: She found the Book in a second-hand shop on University Hill. The next morning it was gone from her desk, and she followed the trail of it to the Lantern House attic.

Hook: The shop where she found the Book has opened again under a new owner, who keeps asking customers where it went.

Quinn Abernathy (they)



"Let's all take a breath, shall we?"

Look: Lanky, with curly red hair and a cardigan. A whistle on a cord round their neck.

Personality: Gentle, funny and stubborn. Quinn hates using Voice on anyone and would rather talk people round the slow way.

POWER: VOICE

Words that sway minds. **+2 dice** when it fits: talking leads and Hide.

Surge (2 Magic, once per scene, paid before they roll): on a Partial or better, 1 more Clue, or Exposure –1.

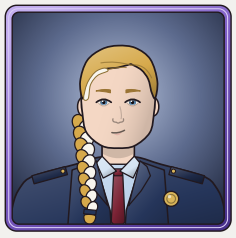
Heart 3 · **Wits** 2 · **Nerve** 1 · **Craft** 2 · **Hurt** 4 · **Magic** 5

Life: Teacher at Hillside School. It might fit children and parents, schools, getting a room to listen, and speaking in public.

Tie to the coven: An old friend of Dana's from school. Dana was the first person Quinn told about their Power.

Hook: A pupil has started repeating, word for word, something Quinn once said to them using Voice. Quinn doesn't know how long it will last.

Tess Lindqvist (she)



"Next stop. Mind the doors."

Look: Broad-shouldered, with a blonde braid and a driver's uniform. A pale streak runs through the braid.

Personality: Dry, patient and hard to rattle. She knows every street and every regular, and says little.

POWER: VEIL

She goes unseen and hides magic. **+2 dice** when it fits: defending, searching leads and Hide.

Surge (2 Magic, once per scene, paid before she rolls): on a Partial or better, no Exposure from casting for the rest of the scene, or in a showdown for this round and the next (a casting roll's cost becomes 1 Hurt).

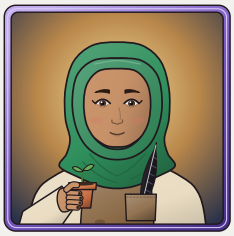
Heart 1 · **Wits** 2 · **Nerve** 3 · **Craft** 2 · **Hurt** 4 · **Magic** 5

Life: Bus driver. It might fit streets and routes, the city at night, the regulars on her bus, and keeping calm behind the wheel.

Tie to the coven: She inherited a room in the house from her gran. The pale streak appeared the first time she went unseen.

Hook: Her gran also left a locked trunk in the attic. The label, in her gran's hand, says "For Tess, when she's ready".

Noor Haddad (she)



"The crows say we're late."

Look: A green headscarf and soil under her nails. A crow feather in her pocket.

Personality: Warm, practical and hard to surprise. Animals trust her before people do.

POWER: WILD

She talks to animals, and grows and binds with plants. **+2 dice** when it fits: talking and searching leads, Bind and brewing.

Surge (2 Magic, once per scene, paid before she rolls): on a Partial or better, 1 more Clue or potion. Or, in a showdown, the threat's Defence is 1 lower for everyone this round.

Heart 2 · **Wits** 2 · **Nerve** 1 · **Craft** 3 · **Hurt** 4 · **Magic** 5

Life: Shop worker at a garden centre. It might fit plants, gardens, animals, customers, and knowing what grows where in the city.

Tie to the coven: She answered an advert for a lodger and stayed. She has kept the walled garden ever since.

Hook: A crow follows her everywhere. When a threat is near, more crows come. This morning there were eleven on the Lantern House roof.

The guardian

Rook



"The household is in danger."

Look: In human shape, a very tall, very still person in a long grey coat, with grey eyes. In animal shape, a large black rook. When Rook carries someone, the air folds like a page and they are somewhere else.

Personality: Patient, watchful and honest. Rook speaks little, never lies, and doesn't always answer. It calls the witches "the household".

GIFTS (1 WARD EACH)

- **Mend** (action): clear 2 Hurt from someone it touches.
- **Shield** (no action, once a round): take an attack meant for someone near it (in a showdown, everyone is near).
- **Carry** (action): take one person to a place it knows, such as the freed innocent out of a fight. It can't carry the coven out of a showdown or past a threat.
- **Sense** (no action, once a scene): +1 die on someone else's lead this scene, outside the +2 limit.
- **Hold** (action, no Ward, not casting): Nerve against Defence; if it works, the threat's next attack must target the guardian.

Heart 3 · **Wits** 2 · **Nerve** 2 · **Hurt** 5 · **Ward** 5

What Rook can't do: Rook can free and guard the innocent, study the threat and research the Book like anyone. It can't cast spells, brew or use potions, join the Unmaking or damage a threat. It can help with Ward. When Rook is Down, it fades back to the Lantern House for the rest of the scene (in a showdown, the rest of the fight) and can't help from there.

Tie to the coven: Rook is bound to the Lantern House by an old promise. It was there before any of the witches, and it calls whoever lives in the house its household.

Hook: Rook has never said who made the old promise, or what happens if it is broken.

If nobody plays Rook: Rook stays home, guarding the house. Once per episode, on any character's turn, the coven may call it for one Mend or one Carry. Calling takes no action and no roll, and counts as casting.

The Lantern House

The coven's home is a narrow, three-storey house on a steep street in Old Town, squeezed between two others. A lamp hangs over the front door. It has never gone out, not in a storm and not in a power cut, and nobody has ever filled it.

Rook is bound to the house. In rook shape it sits on the chimney. In human shape it stands in the hall, so still that visitors take it for a coat stand until it moves.

WHAT THE HOUSE IS FOR

Two investigation actions happen **at home**: researching the **Book** (a searching lead using Wits, +1 die, with no Exposure; one character per scene; Sight, Veil and Wild fit it) and **brewing** potions. Threats can't come inside uninvited. That is story only: the rules never put a showdown here.

GROUND FLOOR

- **The front room.** Sofas that don't match, a fireplace and a bay window onto the street. The coven meets here to plan, argue and eat takeaway.
- **The kitchen.** A long scrubbed table, an old range and shelves of jars, half of them labelled in handwriting nobody living recognises. This is where potions get brewed.
- **The back door and the walled garden.** Herbs, an apple tree and a bench under it. The walls are high and old. Noor keeps the garden; the crows keep Noor company.

FIRST FLOOR

- **Three bedrooms.** In the ready-made coven, Tess has her gran's room at the front, Noor has the lodger's room at the back, and the small room over the stairs belongs to whoever needs it tonight. June has slept there more nights than she has slept at home.
- **The bathroom.** A bath with clawed feet, pipes that knock, and a mirror that fogs over even when nobody has run the tap.

ATTIC

- **The Book on its lectern.** A heavy book, written in many hands over many years. Every witch who has lived here added pages. Research happens here.
- **Old trunks.** Clothes, letters, tools and keepsakes left by the witches who lived here before. Some are locked.
- **The round window.** It looks down on the street and the lamp. From here, you can see who comes to the door before they knock.

Larkhaven

Larkhaven is an invented harbour city, set today. Fog in the mornings, ferries, steep streets, old money in the Heights and new flats on the old docks. The table shows where the ready-made episodes and threats happen.

AREA	WHAT'S THERE	IN THIS BOOK
Old Town	Narrow streets, the Lantern House, St Bride's market hall, the night market on Fridays	Night Market (public place); the Mirror Thief
The Harbour	Ferries, the fish market, the long pier, the lighthouse	Cinders (public place); Low Tide (public place)
Saltmarsh	Reed beds, the drowned village at low tide, birdwatchers	Low Tide (hidden place)
The Heights	Big houses, the old radio tower, the observatory	Night Market (hidden place)
University Hill	Students, cheap cafés, the library with the locked basement	Vesper Crane
The Docks	New flats, a burned-out theatre, the container yard	Cinders (hidden place)

OLD TOWN

The oldest part of the city, built up the hill from the water. Cobbled streets too narrow for buses, little shops, and St Bride's market hall with its iron roof. On Fridays the night market fills the lanes around the hall with food stalls, music and fairy lights.

THE HARBOUR

Ferries come and go all day across the bay. The fish market opens before dawn. The long pier runs out into the sea, with an arcade at one end and a lifeboat ramp at the other. The lighthouse stands on the far arm of the harbour wall.

SALTMARSH

Flat, grey-green and quiet, east of the city. Reed beds, channels of black water and a birdwatchers' hide on stilts. At the lowest tides, the walls of a drowned village show above the mud.

THE HEIGHTS

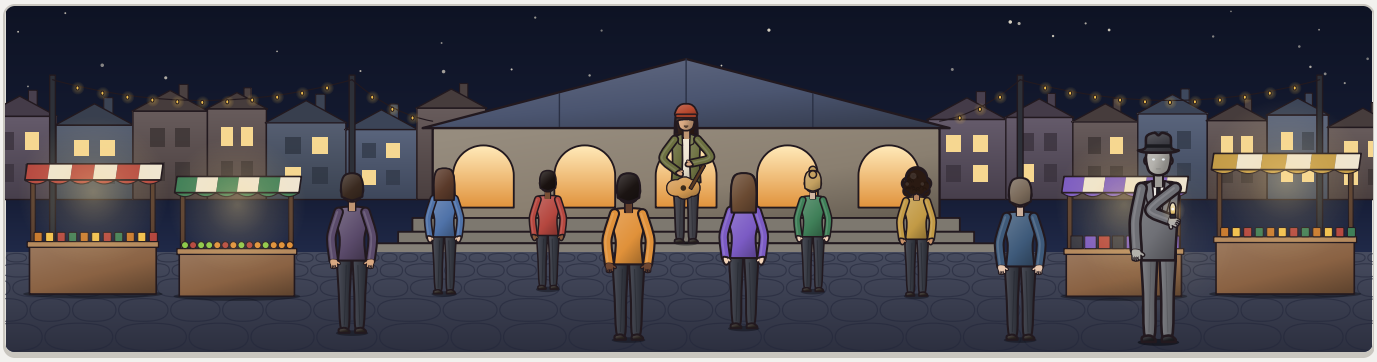
Big houses behind high hedges on the hill above the city. At the top stand the observatory and the old radio tower, a steel mast that hasn't sent anything out in fifty years.

UNIVERSITY HILL

Students, bikes, cheap cafés and second-hand shops. The university library has a basement that is always locked, and nobody on the staff will say why.

THE DOCKS

Once ships and warehouses; now new flats with glass balconies. The container yard still works through the night. In the middle of it all stands a burned-out theatre that nobody has managed to knock down.



CHAPTER 14

Episode 1: Night Market

STORYTELLER ONLY

This chapter is for the Storyteller. Players shouldn't read it before they play it: the fun is in finding out.

A demon called the Quiet Man is stealing voices across Larkhaven. He has taken six. He needs seven to sing a door open, and the seventh he wants is the most famous voice in the city. This is an Easy episode, built for a first night.

Setting up

Set every number at the start of the episode. They don't change if someone joins or leaves. Doom, Exposure and Clues start at 0.

EASY	NUMBER
Lead Difficulty	1 (so no Partials on leads)
Defence	1 (2 until the coven knows the Weakness)
Danger	1
Hit	2
Attacks a round	1 against 3 characters, 2 against 4 or 5
Exposure boxes	5
Doom	12 boxes, Showdown mark at 5

Clues depend on **n**: the witches, plus the guardian if a player plays it. At Easy you need 3 × n.

CHARACTERS (N)	CLUES NEEDED	HALF (WHAT AND WHERE)
3	9	5
4	12	6
5	15	8

Toughness depends on **w**, the witches only. At Easy it is 3 × w, plus 3 against 3 witches with no guardian player. The Unmaking's Difficulty is the number of witches, +2 without the Weakness.

WITCHES (W)	TOUGHNESS
2	6
3, with a guardian player	9
3, no guardian player	12
4	12
5	15

Played later in a season, add the season's Toughness (Chapter 8).

The opening

Read this aloud, then ask the players where their witches are standing.

Friday night in Old Town. The night market fills the lanes around St Bride's market hall: frying onions, fairy lights, a hundred voices at once. On the steps of the hall, Bea Santos tunes her guitar, as she does every week, and the crowd goes quiet for her first song. She smiles. She opens her mouth. Nothing comes out. Not a note, not a breath. Her hands fly to her throat. At the edge of the crowd, a man in a grey suit tips his hat and walks away into the fog, and the only ones who see him go are you.

Then tell each witch what their Life wants from them this episode (the Life calls table below).

The opening isn't a scene (Chapter 9). If the players chase the grey man or run to help Bea, let them: the fog closes, and he is gone. What they wanted to do becomes their first lead in scene 1.

The innocent: Grace Ellery

Grace hosts the late show on Radio Larkhaven, every weeknight from ten till two. Her voice is famous across the city: warm, low and easy to trust. Taxi drivers, night nurses and insomniacs all know it. She grew up on the Docks, lives in a flat on the Harbour, and is brash, kind and more frightened than she lets on.

Next Friday, Grace is broadcasting live from the night market. That is where the Quiet Man will take her if Doom reaches the Showdown mark.

The threat: the Quiet Man

His stat block is in Chapter 10. He is a demon in a grey suit who steals voices. He never uses his own voice: he speaks in the voices he has stolen. He catches each one in an old glass radio valve that glows faintly, and hangs it at the top of his tower.

- **Plan:** seven stolen voices to sing a door open. He has six after the opening.
- **Weakness:** his own name spoken aloud, and salt. His name is **Ambrose Lisk**.
- **Hidden place:** the old radio tower in the Heights.
- **Public place:** the Friday night market.
- **Signature move (on a 6): Hush:** attack two different characters; the first one he hurts can't cast on their next action (Chapter 10 says what that blocks and when it ends). If the innocent is there and free, he goes for her instead.

GO TO HIM, OR WAIT?

At the end of each scene, Doom +1. If Doom has reached 5, it's too late: the Quiet Man comes to the coven at the night market, with Grace in his grip. If not, and the coven has half the Clues, it knows what he is and where he hides, and may go to the radio tower (this takes no scene). Grace isn't there.

As Doom rises. He already has six voices, so show signs, not new victims. At Doom 2, every radio in Old Town plays six voices singing together at midnight, very faintly. At Doom 4, Grace finds a grey card on her desk at the studio: *One song, just for me. Friday.* From Doom 6, in the showdown, the stolen voices sing louder each round, and the outline of a door glows in the air above him.

Leads

Here are six leads to offer. Each says where it happens, the roll, and which Powers fit. Rolls are against the Lead Difficulty (1). A success gives 1 Clue, a Critical 2.

- Use the **What and where** answer while the coven has fewer than half the Clues (count them before the roll). Use the **Weakness** answer once it has half or more.
- Players can come back to a lead. Show them something new there each time.
- When the coven has all the Clues, tell them the whole Weakness plainly, whichever lead gave the last one.
- Out in the city, a cost is Exposure +1 if the witch was casting (a Power or Reveal), or else 1 Hurt. Anyone else the coven talks to is a talking lead too.

1. BEA SANTOS (TALKING)

Where: her flat over the chip shop on Cooper's Lane, Old Town. **Roll:** Heart. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Voice, Wild.

What and where: Bea can't speak, but she writes fast. A quiet man asked her for "one song, just for me" and paid her with an old silver coin stamped with a radio mast. When she sang, her voice came out of her as a little light and went into a glass valve in his hand. The coin is from Radio Larkhaven's first year, 1926.

Weakness: He wouldn't come near the chip-shop counter. He walked the long way round a spilled salt cellar, and the salt hissed where his shadow touched it.

2. GRACE ELLERY (TALKING)

Where: the Radio Larkhaven studio in Old Town, after her show. **Roll:** Heart. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Voice, Wild.

What and where: For a week, a caller has rung her phone-in every night and said nothing. Behind the silence, very faintly, five or six voices sing together. Radio Larkhaven began in 1926 in the old radio tower in the Heights. The station still owns the tower and keeps it locked.

Weakness: Grace goes pale and tells the truth: twenty years ago a man in a grey suit offered her a voice people would stop and listen to. She signed his card. She still has it, in a drawer at the studio. It says *A. Lisk*. (This is the twist; see below.)

3. THE MARKET LANES (SEARCHING)

Where: the night market after closing, around St Bride's market hall. **Roll:** Wits. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: Every radio on every stall died the moment Bea went silent. Each one is stuck on the same old wavelength, marked on the dials as "Larkhaven Tower". A

trail of grey threads from his suit leads to the bus stop for the Heights.

Weakness: At the salt-fish stall, a ring of coarse salt on the cobbles is still unbroken. Inside it, the last few notes of Bea's song still hang in the air. He couldn't step in to take them.

4. THE VOICE CLINIC (SEARCHING)

Where: the files of the voice clinic at Larkhaven General. A nurse's Life might fit here. **Roll:** Wits. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: Five patients this month lost their voices overnight, with no cause anyone can find. Put their addresses on a map and they ring the Heights. Every one of them can see the old radio tower from their bedroom window.

Weakness: One patient, a fish seller from the Harbour, can still whisper. Her notes say she threw a fistful of salt at "the grey man", and he dropped the valve before he could close it.

5. THE BOOK (RESEARCH AT HOME)

Where: the attic of the Lantern House. **Roll:** Wits with +1 die (the Book), with no Exposure; one character per scene. It is a searching lead. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: A page in an old hand: *Hush-men*, demons who gather voices, always seven, to sing a door open. They nest high up, in places where voices were once sent out into the air.

Weakness: *Salt stops its mouth. Speak its true name aloud and it comes undone. It hides its name where it first sang.* The coven will have to find the name in the city.

6. THE STEPS OF ST BRIDE'S (REVEAL)

Where: the steps of the market hall, where Bea sang. Nothing ordinary shows here, so Heart and Wits find nothing. **Roll:** Reveal (Craft, 1 Magic); a success gives 1 more Clue. It is casting, so a cost is Exposure +1. **Powers that fit:** Sight.

What and where: A fine silver thread, what is left of Bea's voice, runs from the steps up over the roofs, north to the Heights. It ends at the top of the old radio tower.

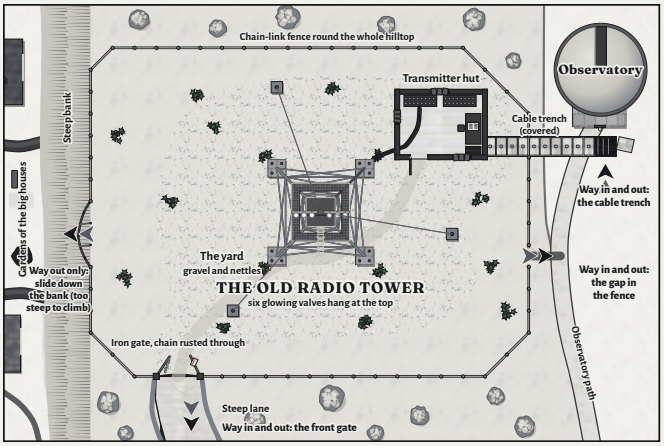
Weakness: The thread hums one word, over and over, in Bea's voice: the name he made her sing. *Lisk*. Where it passes over the salt bins at the fish stall, it frays.

Life calls

At the opening, find each witch's Life (the number is its roll on the Life table) and tell them what it wants this episode. Answering takes their action for one scene, needs no roll and gives 1 Magic. If they haven't answered by the showdown, they lose 1 Magic (or take 1 Hurt if they have none).

D6	LIFE	THIS EPISODE'S CALL
1	Student	A group project is due on Friday, and the rest of the group has gone quiet. Someone has to spend a night in the library.
2	Nurse	The ward is two nurses short. The nurse in charge asks for one more night shift, "just this once".
3	Shop worker	Stocktake. Every shelf counted before the weekend, with the manager watching.
4	Teacher	Parents' evening runs till nine, and one parent wants to talk about everything.
5	Mechanic	A market trader's van has to be running by Friday, or her stall won't get to the night market.
6	Bus driver	Covering the late route up to the Heights. A regular passenger, who always says goodnight, hasn't been on the bus all week.

The hidden place: the old radio tower



The old radio tower on the Heights

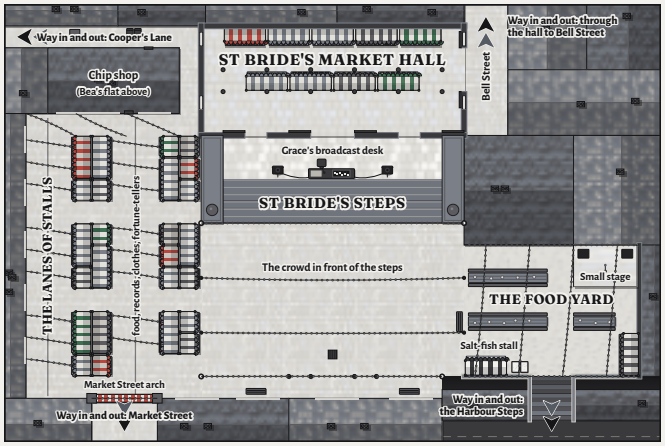
A fenced hilltop above the big houses of the Heights, next to the observatory. The coven goes to it with half the Clues; going takes no scene. Nothing here needs a roll to get past. If the coven retreats, everyone leaves together by any way out. Grace isn't here.

- **The lane and the gate.** A steep lane ends at an iron gate with a rusted chain and a sign: *Radio Larkhaven. Private.* A chain-link fence runs round the whole hilltop.
- **The transmitter hut.** A brick hut with boarded windows. Inside: racks of dead valves, a desk, a 1926 logbook, and thick cables running out and up the tower.
- **The yard.** Gravel and nettles round the tower's four concrete feet. Steel guy wires hum in the wind, though there is no wind.
- **The tower.** A steel lattice mast with a caged ladder, a platform halfway up, and a platform at the top. Six glowing valves hang from the old aerial up there, wired together. This is where he sings.
- **The cable trench.** A covered trench runs from the hut, under the fence, into the observatory grounds.

Ways in: the front gate (the chain is rusted through); a gap in the fence by the observatory path; the cable trench from the observatory grounds. **Ways out:** the same three, and the steep bank down into the gardens of the big houses (too steep to climb up, easy to slide down).

The Quiet Man waits at the top of the tower, then steps off the platform and floats down to meet the coven, hat in hand.

The public place: the Friday night market



The Friday night market around St Bride's

If Doom reaches the Showdown mark, it is Friday again, and the market is packed. In a public place, every round in which anyone was casting raises Exposure by 1 (once per round). Nothing here needs a roll to get past.

- **The Market Street arch.** A striped arch at the bottom of the hill, the busiest way in.
- **The lanes of stalls.** Food, records, second-hand clothes and fortune-tellers, under strings of fairy lights.
- **St Bride's steps.** Grace's broadcast desk is set up here, with speakers playing her show to the whole market.
- **St Bride's market hall.** The covered hall with its iron roof, full of stalls, with side doors onto Bell Street.
- **The food yard.** Long tables, a small stage and the salt-fish stall.
- **The Harbour Steps.** A stone stair from the food yard down to the harbour road.
- **Cooper's Lane.** A narrow back alley behind the chip shop.

Ways in and out: the Market Street arch; the Harbour Steps; Cooper's Lane; through the market hall to Bell Street.

In his grip: the Quiet Man stands behind Grace at her desk with one grey hand on her shoulder. When she tries to speak into the microphone, nothing comes out of her, and her voice comes out of him. To free her, roll Nerve against Defence; only a success frees her. If she is still in his grip at the end of the first round, she is lost. Once she is free, Rook (or the coven's call) can Carry her to a place it knows, such as the Lantern House.

The twist

Grace's famous voice isn't hers. Twenty years ago she was a shy girl with a thin, quiet voice who dreamed of radio. A polite man in a grey suit offered her a voice people would stop and listen to, on loan. She signed his card. The voice she has is his own: that is why he never speaks with it. He needs it back to finish his song.

The twist comes out on Grace's lead, or in the showdown, when the Quiet Man speaks for the first time in Grace's voice. Grace is ashamed and afraid. She may beg the coven to keep her secret, or try to bargain with him herself. Let the players decide what to tell her and what to tell anyone else. The twist changes no rules.

Endings

Win (he is destroyed, and Grace is safe). Lisk comes undone like a suit with the stitches pulled. The valves crack, and six stolen voices fly home over the roofs like sparks. Grace keeps the voice: with its owner gone, it is hers now. Next Friday, Bea sings again.

Partial (he fled, or he was destroyed but Grace was lost). If he fled, he climbs back to the tower with the voices he has and waits to collect the rest. The stolen voices stay stolen. If he was destroyed but Grace was lost, the six voices come home, but Grace went through the half-open door with him. Radio Larkhaven plays her old shows every night, and the city waits for her to come back.

Loss (Doom filled, every witch Down, or the coven retreated). If Doom filled, his plan is complete: Grace is lost and he escapes. On the seventh night, every radio in Larkhaven plays seven voices singing, and above the Heights a door opens in the air. If every witch went Down or the coven retreated, he walks away into the fog, polite as ever. If Grace was still in the fight, she goes with him and is lost. He will be back.

Seen (the result drops one step; a Loss stays a Loss). By morning, a video from the market is everywhere: people with fire in their hands and a man in grey who floats. Or, if the coven was Seen during the investigation, a photo of a witch casting on Cooper's Lane is on the front of the local paper. Someone at Radio Larkhaven wants to interview them.

Carry-over. If he was destroyed, the Quiet Man gets a page in the Book (next time, start with half the Clues, rounded up). If he wasn't, he comes back later, when the Storyteller chooses, with 2 more Toughness each time. A witch who is Down when the coven loses (except by retreating) gets a Scar: 1 Hurt at the start of the next episode.

Closing scene

A week later, the night market is back. Give each player a short Life scene: who noticed they were missing this week, and what it cost them. Then end at the market. If Bea has her voice back, she sings on the steps. Grace's show plays from every stall. Near midnight she says, "This one's for whoever was at the market last Friday. You know who you are." Back at the Lantern House, the lamp over the door is still burning.





CHAPTER 15

Episode 2: Cinders

STORYTELLER ONLY

This chapter is for the Storyteller. Players shouldn't read it before they play it: the fun is in finding out.

More than a hundred years ago, a bride died in a fire on her wedding night. Now the Ash Widow walks the Docks again, looking for the house where she died. She wants to burn it, with a bride inside, and a firefighter who is getting married next week has just bought it. This is a Standard episode.

Setting up

Set every number at the start of the episode. They don't change if someone joins or leaves. Doom, Exposure and Clues start at 0.

STANDARD	NUMBER
Lead Difficulty	2
Defence	2 (3 until the coven knows the Weakness)
Danger	3
Hit	2
Attacks a round	1 against 3 characters, 2 against 4 or 5
Exposure boxes	4 (cross out box 5 on the tracker)
Doom	12 boxes, Showdown mark at 5

Clues depend on **n**: the witches, plus the guardian if a player plays it. At Standard you need 4 × n – 1.

CHARACTERS (N)	CLUES NEEDED	HALF (WHAT AND WHERE)
3	11	6
4	15	8
5	19	10

Toughness depends on **w**, the witches only. At Standard it is 3 × w, plus 3 against 3 witches with no guardian player. The Unmaking's Difficulty is the number of witches, +2 without the Weakness.

WITCHES (W)	TOUGHNESS
2	6
3, with a guardian player	9
3, no guardian player	12
4	12
5	15

Played later in a season, add the season's Toughness (Chapter 8).

The opening

Read this aloud, then ask the players where their witches were when they saw the smoke.

Saturday night on the Docks. Sirens. Smoke rolls up from Tanner's Row, a terrace of old houses one street back from the water. From the hill you can see that this fire isn't spreading the way fires do. It runs in a perfect circle through the back gardens, house to house, a ring of flame with one bright knot of fire at the top, like a wedding ring dropped on the city. The fire crews get everyone out. One firefighter stops in the street and stares into the flames, at a woman in a wedding dress burned grey-white, who stares back. The air smells of smoke and orange blossom. Then the woman is gone, and the ring goes out all at once.

Then tell each witch what their Life wants from them this episode (the Life calls table below).

The opening isn't a scene (Chapter 9). If the players run into the smoke after the woman in the wedding dress or go to help the fire crews, let them: by the time they get there, she is gone. What they wanted to do becomes their first lead in scene 1.

The innocent: Hannah Price

Hannah is a firefighter at the Old Town fire station: practical, funny and fearless about everything except her own wedding. She marries Jess Moran next Saturday. They have just bought their first house, an old terrace at **7 Ropewalk Lane**, one street over from Tanner's Row. They move in after the wedding. Hannah was the firefighter in the street, and she hasn't told anyone what she saw.

This week Larkhaven holds its harbour fireworks. Hannah's crew is on standby on the quayside, and that is where the Ash Widow will take her if Doom reaches the Showdown mark.

The threat: the Ash Widow

Her stat block is in Chapter 10. She is a fire spirit in a burned wedding dress. In life she was **Clara Wren**. In 1911 she married Edwin Hale, and the wedding party was held at the Mariner Theatre on the Docks. That night their new house on Ropewalk Lane caught fire. Edwin died trying to reach her, and she died a few minutes later: a widow for those few minutes. Docks people have called her the Ash Widow ever since.

- **Plan:** to burn the house where she died, with a bride inside.
- **Weakness:** water from the harbour, blessed by a coven.
- **Hidden place:** the burned-out theatre on the Docks (the Mariner).
- **Public place:** the harbour fireworks.
- **Signature move (on a 6): Cinders:** attack every character, but Hit is 1. If the innocent is there and free, she goes for her instead.

GO TO HER, OR WAIT?

At the end of each scene, Doom +1. If Doom has reached 5, it's too late: the Ash Widow comes to the coven at the harbour fireworks, with Hannah in her grip. If not, and the coven has half the Clues, it knows what she is and where she hides, and may go to the Mariner (this takes no scene). Hannah isn't there.

As Doom rises. At Doom 2, a ring is scorched into the front step of 7 Ropewalk Lane, and the new paint inside blisters, though nothing burns. At Doom 4, Hannah finds her wedding veil in her locker at the fire station, scorched in a perfect ring and smelling of orange blossom. From Doom 6, in the showdown, the flames round the fight climb higher each round, in a perfect ring that never spreads.

Leads

Here are six leads to offer. Each says where it happens, the roll, and which Powers fit. Rolls are against the Lead Difficulty (2). A success gives 1 Clue, a Critical 2, a Partial 1 with a cost.

- Use the **What and where** answer while the coven has fewer than half the Clues (count them before the roll). Use the **Weakness** answer once it has half or more.
- Players can come back to a lead. Show them something new there each time.
- When the coven has all the Clues, tell them the whole Weakness plainly, whichever lead gave the last one.
- Out in the city, a cost is Exposure +1 if the witch was casting (a Power or Reveal), or else 1 Hurt. Anyone else the coven talks to is a talking lead too.

1. HANNAH PRICE (TALKING)

Where: the Old Town fire station, between shifts. **Roll:** Heart. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Voice, Wild.

What and where: In the flames at Tanner's Row, a woman in a burned wedding dress asked her, in a voice like paper catching, "Are you to be married?" The ring of fire started at the end of the row nearest the old Mariner Theatre. Hannah mentions, without thinking, that she has just bought a house one street over.

Weakness: Water from the hoses, off the mains, did nothing. Only the fireboat's pumps, drawing straight from the harbour, made the flames shrink back, "like it hurt".

2. WINNIE DOYLE (TALKING)

Where: the Seaview care home on the Harbour. Winnie is 91 and ran the bar at the Mariner until it burned in 1979. **Roll:** Heart. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Voice, Wild.

What and where: Winnie tells the story of Clara Wren: married in 1911, the party at the Mariner, the fire on Ropewalk Lane that night. She saw the Ash Widow herself, standing on the Mariner's stage the night it burned in 1979. "She sleeps in there. In the ashes."

Weakness: Winnie's mother told her that in 1911 the Old Town women put out the fire at the Mariner with buckets of harbour water, "and they said words over every bucket". Then, quieter: "Clara Wren was one of them. That's why they burned her house."

3. TANNER'S ROW (SEARCHING)

Where: the burned houses on the Docks, behind the fire service tape. **Roll:** Wits. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: Small bare footprints in the ash come from the direction of the Mariner Theatre and go round the row, door to door. Every door number is scorched away. She was looking for one house. In one letterbox is a charred wedding invitation: *Hannah Price and Jess Moran, next Saturday*.

Weakness: Wherever the fireboat's harbour water pooled, the ash won't settle. A scrap of burnt lace near a puddle curls away from it and crumbles.

4. THE NEWSPAPER ARCHIVE (SEARCHING)

Where: the university library on University Hill (the open floors, not the locked basement). A student's Life might fit here. **Roll:** Wits. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: *The Larkhaven Courier*, 1911: "Bride dies in Ropewalk Lane fire on wedding night", with a photograph of Clara Wren. The Mariner burned again in 1952 and 1979, both times on the night of a big wedding in the city. This year's property notices: *7 Ropewalk Lane, sold to H. Price and J. Moran*.

Weakness: A letter to the editor from 1911: the fire brigade couldn't save the Mariner, but "a line of Old Town women with buckets from the harbour" put it out, "talking over every bucket like a church full of grandmothers".

5. THE BOOK (RESEARCH AT HOME)

Where: the attic of the Lantern House. **Roll:** Wits with +1 die (the Book), with no Exposure; one character per scene. It is a searching lead. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: A page on *brides of ash*: a woman who dies by fire on her wedding night may burn on until the house she died in burns again, with a bride inside. Between fires, she rests where she was last happy. For Clara, that was the stage of the Mariner.

Weakness: In the margin of that page, notes in a small neat hand, signed *C. W.*: harbour water, blessed by a coven, puts out any fire that walks. Clara Wren wrote in this Book. (This is the twist; see below.)

6. 7 ROPEWALK LANE (REVEAL)

Where: Hannah and Jess's new house, empty and smelling of paint. Nothing ordinary shows here, so Heart and Wits find nothing. **Roll:** Reveal (Craft, 1 Magic); a success gives 1 more Clue. It is casting, so a cost is Exposure +1. **Powers that fit:** Sight.

What and where: Reveal shows the house as it was on the night in 1911: burning, with a woman in white at the upstairs window. A trail of glowing footprints leads out of the front door and down to the Mariner Theatre.

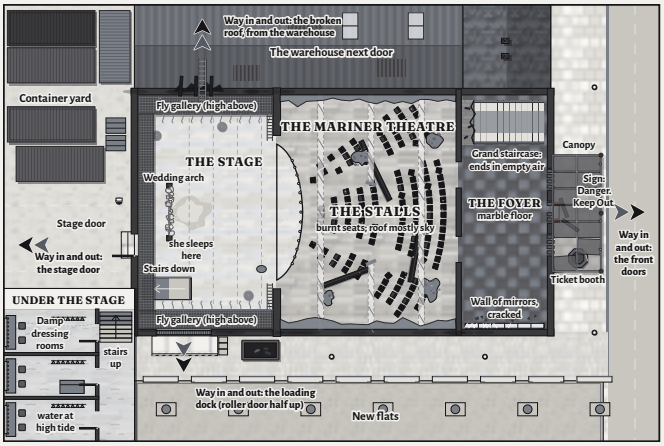
Weakness: At the end of the lane, on the old harbour steps, Reveal shows marks cut into the stone, glowing faintly. This is where Clara's coven blessed the water.

Life calls

At the opening, find each witch's Life (the number is its roll on the Life table) and tell them what it wants this episode. Answering takes their action for one scene, needs no roll and gives 1 Magic. If they haven't answered by the showdown, they lose 1 Magic (or take 1 Hurt if they have none).

D6	LIFE	THIS EPISODE'S CALL
1	Student	A revision session the lecturer says "you'll regret missing", on the same night as a best friend's birthday.
2	Nurse	The burns unit needs cover after the Tanner's Row fire.
3	Shop worker	A rush order for Saturday: two hundred white roses for a wedding, every one checked by hand.
4	Teacher	A class trip to the harbour festival needs one more adult, or it's cancelled.
5	Mechanic	A vintage car booked for a wedding on Saturday won't start. The bride's mother rings every hour.
6	Bus driver	The diversion round Tanner's Row has doubled the route, and the night bus needs a driver.

The hidden place: the Mariner Theatre



The burned-out Mariner Theatre

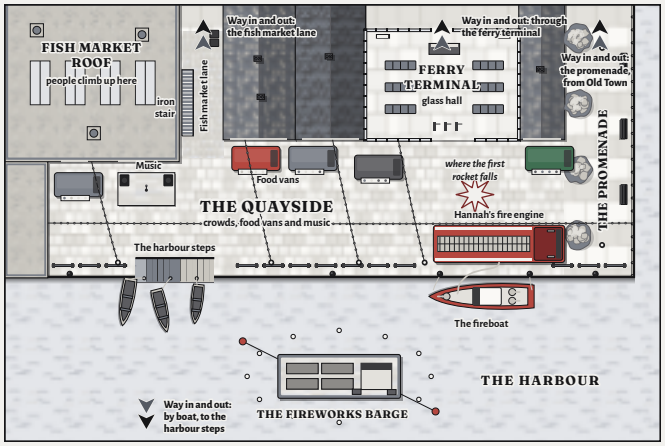
A burned-out theatre in the middle of the Docks, between new flats and the container yard. Nobody has managed to knock it down. The coven goes to it with half the Clues; going takes no scene. Nothing here needs a roll to get past. If the coven retreats, everyone leaves together by any way out. Hannah isn't here.

- **The front.** Boarded doors under a sagging canopy, an old ticket booth and a sign: *Danger. Keep Out.*
- **The foyer.** A black marble floor, a grand staircase that ends in empty air, and a wall of mirrors cracked by heat.
- **The stalls.** Rows of burnt seats under a roof that is mostly sky. Ash drifts down like snow, though nothing is burning.
- **The stage.** The boards are sound. A wedding arch of wire and wax flowers still stands at the back. This is where she sleeps.
- **The fly gallery.** Iron walkways high above the stage, hung with old ropes.
- **Under the stage.** Damp dressing rooms. At high tide, harbour water seeps in ankle-deep.

Ways in: the front doors (the boards come away); the stage door from the container yard; the loading dock at the side, with its roller door half up; the broken roof, from the warehouse next door. **Ways out:** the same four.

The Ash Widow rises out of the ash on the stage. The wax flowers on the arch melt, and every seat in the stalls catches light at once, though none of them burns away.

The public place: the harbour fireworks



The quayside on fireworks night

If Doom reaches the Showdown mark, it is fireworks night, and half of Larkhaven is on the quayside. In a public place, every round in which anyone was casting raises Exposure by 1 (once per round). Nothing here needs a roll to get past.

- **The quayside.** Thousands of people, food vans and music. Hannah's fire engine is parked here, and the fireboat is moored at the quay.
- **The fireworks barge.** Moored out in the harbour. The show is fired from here.
- **The ferry terminal.** A glass hall, open late for the festival.
- **The fish market roof.** A flat roof where people climb for a better view.
- **The promenade.** The wide walk from Old Town to the long pier.
- **The harbour steps.** Stone steps down to the water, where small boats tie up.

Ways in and out: the promenade from Old Town; through the ferry terminal; the fish market lane; by boat to the harbour steps.

In her grip: as the first rocket goes up, it bursts white and falls burning onto the quay, and the Ash Widow walks out of the sparks with her arms round Hannah. Hannah's helmet is melting. To free her, roll Nerve against Defence; only a success frees her. If she is still in her grip at the end of the first round, she is lost. Once she is free, Rook (or the coven's call) can Carry her to a place it knows, such as the Lantern House.

The twist

Clara Wren was a witch, and she lived in the Lantern House before she married. Her notes are in the margins of the Book. In 1911, someone saw her cast and talked. By her wedding night, half the Docks believed she was a witch, and somebody set her new house alight. Her coven blessed harbour water and saved the Mariner, but they were too late for her.

The twist comes out on Winnie's lead and in the Book, or in the showdown, when the Ash Widow looks at the coven and whispers, "You're from the lamp house. So was I." It is a hard reminder of why magic stays secret. The twist changes no rules.

Endings

Win (she is destroyed, and Hannah is safe). The blessed water hisses over her. The fire goes out of her dress, and for a moment she is a young woman in white, smiling. "Tell Edwin I waited," she says, and she is gone. On Saturday, Hannah marries Jess.

Partial (she fled, or she was destroyed but Hannah was lost). If she fled, she sinks into the ashes of the Mariner and waits for the next wedding in Larkhaven. Hannah marries, but every wedding in the city this year has a fire engine parked outside. If she was destroyed but Hannah was lost, the Widow took Hannah into the fire with her as she went out, and no one finds her. Jess keeps the keys to Ropewalk Lane and won't sell.

Loss (Doom filled, every witch Down, or the coven retreated). If Doom filled, her plan is complete: Hannah is lost and the Ash Widow escapes. On the night before the wedding, 7 Ropewalk Lane burns again, in a perfect ring, with Hannah inside. If every witch went Down or the coven retreated, she walks away through the flames, still asking everyone she passes if they are to be married. If Hannah was still in the fight, the Widow takes her into the fire, and she is lost.

Seen (the result drops one step; a Loss stays a Loss). The fireworks crowd filmed everything. By morning, "Larkhaven's burning bride" and the people who fought her are on every phone in the city. Or, if the coven was Seen during the investigation, someone caught a witch casting at Tanner's Row, and the fire service wants a word.

Carry-over. If she was destroyed, the Ash Widow gets a page in the Book (next time, start with half the Clues, rounded up). If she wasn't, she comes back later, when the Storyteller chooses, with 2 more Toughness each time. A witch who is Down when the coven loses (except by retreating) gets a Scar: 1 Hurt at the start of the next episode.

Closing scene

Saturday comes. Give each player a short Life scene: what they missed this week, and who forgave them. Then go to the wedding, if there is one, or to the empty house on Ropewalk Lane if there isn't. Hannah raises a glass "to absent friends" and looks straight at the coven. End in the attic of the Lantern House, where the coven opens the Book to Clara Wren's neat notes and decides what to write beside them.





CHAPTER 16

Episode 3: Low Tide

STORYTELLER ONLY

This chapter is for the Storyteller. Players shouldn't read it before they play it: the fun is in finding out.

TWO HUNDRED YEARS AGO, THE SEA SWALLOWED A VILlage in Saltmarsh, church and all. Its people still sing under the mud, and their song is missing one voice. Now the choir is calling for it, and the voice it wants belongs to a twelve-year-old boy. This is a Hard episode: expect witches to go Down.

Setting up

Set every number at the start of the episode. They don't change if someone joins or leaves. Doom, Exposure and Clues start at 0.

HARD	NUMBER
Lead Difficulty	2
Defence	2 (3 until the coven knows the Weakness)
Danger	3
Hit	3
Attacks a round	1 against 3 characters, 2 against 4 or 5
Exposure boxes	4 (cross out box 5 on the tracker)
Doom	12 boxes, Showdown mark at 5

Clues depend on **n**: the witches, plus the guardian if a player plays it. At Hard you need 4 × n.

CHARACTERS (N)	CLUES NEEDED	HALF (WHAT AND WHERE)
3	12	6
4	16	8
5	20	10

Toughness depends on **w**, the witches only. At Hard it is 4 × w, plus 3 against 3 witches with no guardian player. The Unmaking's Difficulty is the number of witches, +2 without the Weakness.

WITCHES (W)	TOUGHNESS	SEASON
2	8	12
3, with a guardian player	12	18
3, no guardian player	15	21
4	16	24
5	20	30

Season is the Toughness as the 3rd or 4th episode of a season: 2 more per witch. If you play the three ready-made episodes as a season, this one comes after the 2nd episode, so use that column. From the 5th episode on, threats have 4 more Toughness per witch instead (Chapter 8).

The opening

Read this aloud, then ask the players why their witches were on the pier at dusk.

Dusk on the long pier. The tide is coming in fast across the sands, and the sky over Saltmarsh is the colour of a bruise. Somewhere out on the marsh, voices begin to sing: an old hymn, slow and sweet, in parts, many voices as one. Three strangers walk past the arcade, down the lifeboat ramp and into the sea, singing along. Up to their knees. Their waists. Their shoulders. The lifeboat crew runs. They pull all three out, choking and shivering. None of them remembers walking in. And far out over the marsh, where nobody is standing, the singing goes on.

Then tell each witch what their Life wants from them this episode (the Life calls table below).

The opening isn't a scene (Chapter 9). If the players run to help the lifeboat crew or head out over the marsh after the singing, let them: the three are already safe in blankets, and the marsh is empty. What they wanted to do becomes their first lead in scene 1.

The innocent: Finn Marlow

Finn is twelve. He sings in the choir at Hillside School and has the solo at the winter concert. He lives with his mum and his gran in a cottage on the edge of Saltmarsh. He is shy with adults, sharp with other children, and he hums all the time. His family is descended from the only child who got out of the drowned village alive.

If Doom reaches the Showdown mark, the choir comes for him on the long pier at dusk. If Quinn Abernathy is in the coven, Finn is in Quinn's choir at Hillside School.

The threat: the Drowned Choir

Its stat block is in Chapter 10. The choir is the ghosts of **Old Saltby**, a village the sea took in the great storm of 1824. Its church, **St Agnes**, went down with it. The ghosts never speak alone. They sing, all together, in old-fashioned words. They are lonely, not cruel, and they don't understand what they take.

- **Plan:** one more voice for the choir.
- **Weakness:** a bell from the drowned church, rung at low tide. The small bell of St Agnes hangs in the lighthouse.
- **Hidden place:** the drowned village in Saltmarsh at low tide.
- **Public place:** the long pier at dusk.
- **Signature move (on a 6): Lure:** one attack; then the standing character with the lowest Heart rolls Heart against Danger (no Hurt on a Partial or a Failure); on a Failure they lose their next action. The attack is a normal attack, so Hold, Shield, Shelter and Sight's Surge work on it; the Heart roll isn't an attack, so they don't stop it. For any tie, roll a die among the tied characters. Chapter 10 has the details. If the innocent is there and free, it goes for him instead.

GO TO IT, OR WAIT?

At the end of each scene, Doom +1. If Doom has reached 5, it's too late: the choir comes to the coven on the long pier at dusk, with Finn in its grip. If not, and the coven has half the Clues, it knows what the choir is and where it hides, and may go to the drowned village (this takes no scene). Finn isn't there.

As Doom rises. At Doom 2, two more people walk into the sea at Saltmarsh at dusk, singing, and the lifeboat pulls them out. At Doom 4, wet footprints, small and bare, come up from the sea to Finn's bedroom window, and none go back. In the showdown, the water rises with Doom: round the ankles at first, knee-deep by Doom 8, waist-deep by Doom 10. The water is story only: it needs no roll.

Leads

Here are six leads to offer. Each says where it happens, the roll, and which Powers fit. Rolls are against the Lead Difficulty (2). A success gives 1 Clue, a Critical 2, a Partial 1 with a cost.

- Use the **What and where** answer while the coven has fewer than half the Clues (count them before the roll). Use the **Weakness** answer once it has half or more.
- Players can come back to a lead. Show them something new there each time.
- When the coven has all the Clues, tell them the whole Weakness plainly, whichever lead gave the last one.
- Out in the city, a cost is Exposure +1 if the witch was casting (a Power or Reveal), or else 1 Hurt. Anyone else the coven talks to is a talking lead too.

1. THE THREE WHO WALKED IN (TALKING)

Where: a ward at Larkhaven General, where the three are kept in overnight: Ray Pascoe, a ferry hand; Nell Ahern, a birdwatcher; and Dev Sood, a student. A nurse's Life might fit here. **Roll:** Heart. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Voice, Wild.

What and where: Each of them heard singing from the Saltmarsh reeds, "from under the ground", and found themselves walking along the shore towards a church tower that shows above the mud at low tide. They are still humming a hymn none of them knows. Ray says, "They tried me and spat me back. I wasn't the one they wanted."

Weakness: Nell says the singing has stopped once before, years ago, just for a breath. A bell rang out over the bay at the lowest tide, from the harbour side.

2. FINN AND HIS GRAN (TALKING)

Where: the Marlow cottage on the edge of Saltmarsh. **Roll:** Heart. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Voice, Wild.

What and where: Finn has been slipping out to the pier at dusk all week "to listen". He sings the hymn perfectly and has never learned it. His gran says the family came out of Old Saltby, the village under the marsh: one little girl, carried out of the flood in 1824, the only one the sea gave back.

Weakness: Gran remembers her own gran saying, "The lighthouse men took the little bell from the church. When it rings at low water, the old ones sleep."

3. THE LONG PIER (SEARCHING)

Where: the lifeboat ramp and the beach under the pier, the Harbour. **Roll:** Wits. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: Three sets of footprints, exactly in step, come along the shore from Saltmarsh, three miles away. There is reed seed and black marsh mud on the ramp, not sand. On a post under the pier, someone has scratched *SALTBY* over and over, at the height of a child.

Weakness: The tide board on the pier shows that this week the lowest tides fall at dusk. The old men fishing off the end say the singing always stops at slack water, "when the bell used to go".

4. THE LIGHTHOUSE (SEARCHING)

Where: the lighthouse on the harbour wall, now a little museum that keeps the old keepers' logs. **Roll:** Wits. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: The keeper's log for 1824: *Great storm. Saltby gone under the sea. Bells heard ringing under water all night.* An old chart shows the village under the Saltmarsh mud, uncovered only at the lowest tides.

Weakness: The log for 1825: *Brought up the small bell of St Agnes from the wreck and hung it for our fog bell. Rang it at low water. The singing stopped.* The bell still hangs by the lamp room.

5. THE BOOK (RESEARCH AT HOME)

Where: the attic of the Lantern House. **Roll:** Wits with +1 die (the Book), with no Exposure; one character per scene. It is a searching lead. **Powers that fit:** Sight, Veil, Wild.

What and where: A page on drowned choirs. They sing for a voice they lack, and draw others in to fill the gap, then let them go, because only a voice of their own blood will finish the song. They rise where they drowned, at the lowest water.

Weakness: *Ring a bell of their own church at the lowest water, and the song breaks.*

6. THE BIRDWATCHERS' HIDE (REVEAL)

Where: the hide on stilts in the Saltmarsh reed beds. Nothing ordinary shows here, so Heart and Wits find nothing. **Roll:** Reveal (Craft, 1 Magic); a success gives 1 more Clue. It is casting, so a cost is Exposure +1. **Powers that fit:** Sight.

What and where: Reveal shows the drowned village under the reeds, lit as if by candles: streets, cottages, the church, and the choir standing in rows in the nave, mouths open, waiting. One place in the front row is empty, at a child's height.

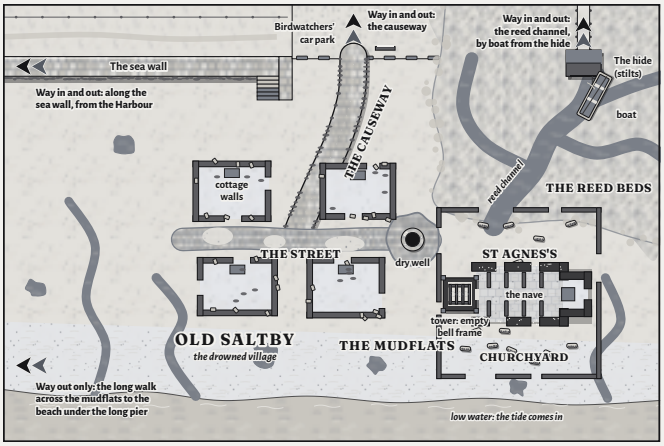
Weakness: In the church tower, Reveal shows the bell frame with one place empty, where the smallest bell should hang. A thin line of light runs from it across the bay to the lighthouse.

Life calls

At the opening, find each witch's Life (the number is its roll on the Life table) and tell them what it wants this episode. Answering takes their action for one scene, needs no roll and gives 1 Magic. If they haven't answered by the showdown, they lose 1 Magic (or take 1 Hurt if they have none).

D6	LIFE	THIS EPISODE'S CALL
1	Student	A lab session at dusk, and missing one more means failing the module.
2	Nurse	A night shift on the children's ward, where nobody can get to sleep.
3	Shop worker	Three hundred bulbs to pot before the weekend, and the delivery came a day late.
4	Teacher	Rehearsals for the winter concert run late every night this week.
5	Mechanic	The lifeboat's launch tractor needs a new clutch, and the crew won't sleep until it's fixed.
6	Bus driver	The coast road to Saltmarsh floods at high tide, and the last bus has to go the long way round.

The hidden place: the drowned village



Old Saltby, the drowned village, at low tide

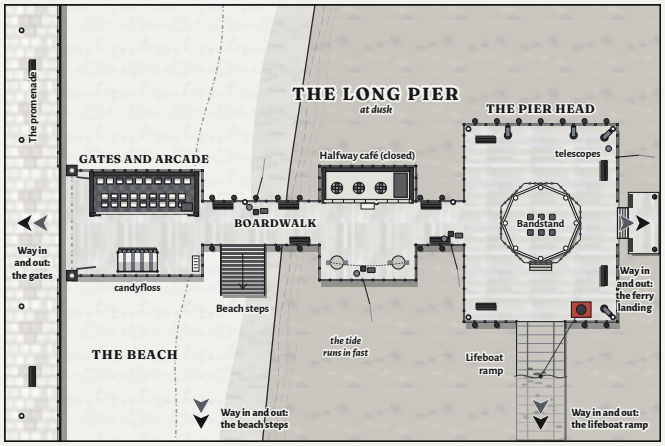
Old Saltby lies under the Saltmarsh mud and shows only at the lowest tides, which fall at dusk this week. The coven goes to it with half the Clues; going takes no scene. Nothing here needs a roll to get past. If the coven retreats, everyone leaves together by any way out. Finn isn't here.

- **The causeway.** A raised path of old stones from the birdwatchers' car park out across the mud. The sea covers it at high tide.
- **The reed beds.** Tall reeds and channels of black water. The hide stands on stilts, with a flat-bottomed boat tied below it.
- **The village street.** The stumps of cottage walls in the mud, a well with no water in it, a lane of cobbles.
- **The churchyard.** Leaning stones, half buried, crusted with shells.
- **St Agnes's church.** Roofless walls round the nave, where the choir stands in rows. The tower is still whole, with an empty bell frame at the top.
- **The mudflats.** Open, shining mud all the way to the sea and round the bay to the beach under the long pier.

Ways in: the causeway from the car park; the reed channel by boat, from the hide; along the sea wall from the Harbour side. **Ways out:** the same three, and the long walk across the mudflats to the beach under the long pier.

As the coven arrives, the singing stops. Every face in the choir turns. Then they sing again, and the song is aimed at the coven. As Doom rises, so does the water.

The public place: the long pier at dusk



The long pier at dusk

If Doom reaches the Showdown mark, the choir comes to the pier at dusk, when it is busiest. In a public place, every round in which anyone was casting raises Exposure by 1 (once per round). Nothing here needs a roll to get past.

- **The gates and the arcade.** Bright lights, slot machines and a candyfloss stall at the landward end.
- **The boardwalk.** Planks over the water, benches, and people fishing off the rail.
- **The halfway café.** Closed for the evening, with a long glass front.
- **The pier head.** The widest part, with a bandstand and coin telescopes.
- **The lifeboat ramp.** A slipway from the pier head down into the sea.
- **The beach steps.** Iron stairs from the boardwalk down to the sand under the pier.

Ways in and out: the gates from the promenade; the beach steps; the lifeboat ramp; the ferry landing at the pier head.

In its grip: Finn stands at the bottom of the lifeboat ramp, knee-deep in the sea, singing. The choir stands round him in the water, holding his hands. To free him, roll Nerve against Defence; only a success frees him. If he is still in its grip at the end of the first round, he is lost. Once he is free, Rook (or the coven's call) can Carry him to a place it knows, such as the Lantern House.

The twist

Finn doesn't want to be saved. All week, the choir has sung his name, and it sounds like family. The empty place in the front row is his, and he knows it. If the coven talks to him,

Finn asks them to leave the choir alone: "They're not hurting anyone. They're just lonely."

The twist comes out on Finn's lead, or in the showdown, when Finn doesn't struggle and asks the coven to stop. Let the players decide how to reach him: what to say, and what to promise. The twist changes no rules: freeing him still takes a success, and he can still be guarded and carried once he is free.

Endings

Win (the choir is destroyed, and Finn is safe). The small bell of St Agnes rings out over the low water. The song breaks in the middle of a note. The choir falls silent and listens, and one by one the ghosts lie down under the mud. The marsh is quiet. Finn sings the solo at the winter concert, and cries a little afterwards, and doesn't say why.

Partial (it fled, or it was destroyed but Finn was lost). If it fled, the tide comes in and the choir sinks back under the marsh, still one voice short, to wait for the next low tide. Finn's gran locks the doors every evening at dusk. If it was destroyed but Finn was lost, he walked into the water with the choir as it went. The lifeboat searches all night. Whether Finn can be found is a story for another episode.

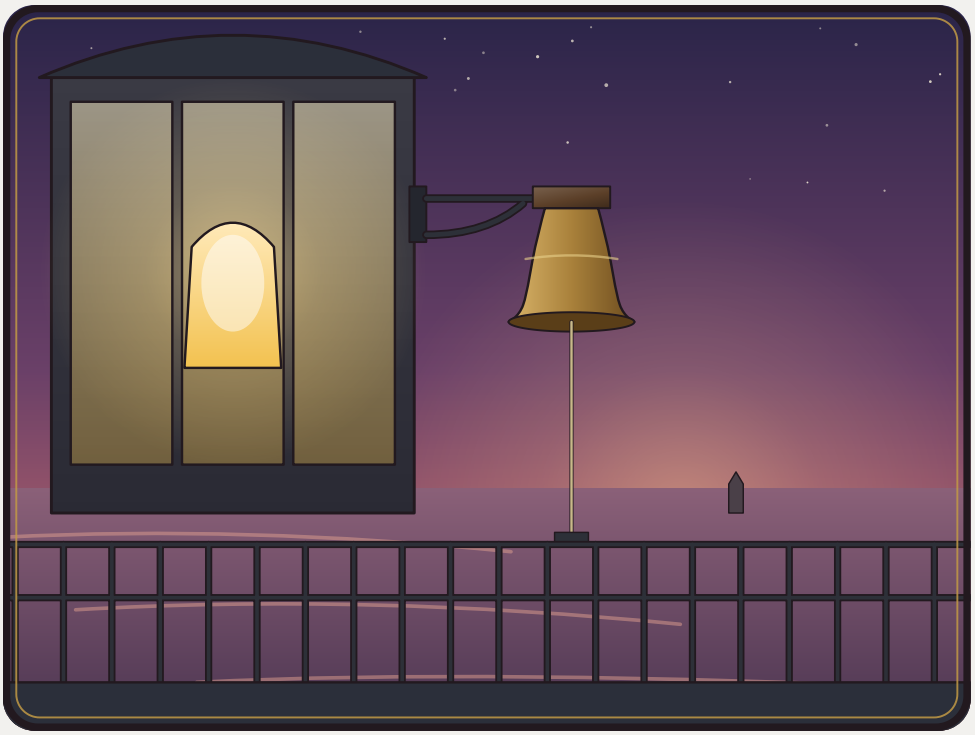
Loss (Doom filled, every witch Down, or the coven retreated). If Doom filled, its plan is complete: Finn is lost and the choir escapes. Every evening at dusk, people on the pier hear the singing, and among the voices is a boy's. If every witch went Down or the coven retreated, the tide covers Old Saltby and the singing goes on, every dusk. If Finn was still in the fight, he goes into the water with the choir, and he is lost.

Seen (the result drops one step; a Loss stays a Loss). Half the pier filmed it: the ghosts in the water, the boy on the ramp, the people doing impossible things. The lifeboat crew gave interviews. Or, if the coven was Seen during the investigation, Nell Ahern saw a witch cast at the hide and has told every birdwatcher in Larkhaven.

Carry-over. If it was destroyed, the Drowned Choir gets a page in the Book (next time, start with half the Clues, rounded up). If it wasn't, it comes back later, when the Storyteller chooses, with 2 more Toughness each time. A witch who is Down when the coven loses (except by retreating) gets a Scar: 1 Hurt at the start of the next episode.

Closing scene

The night of the winter concert at Hillside School. Give each player a short Life scene first: who they let down this week, and how they made it up. Then go to the concert. If Finn is safe, he sings the solo, and for one line the hall hears something old in his voice. If he isn't, his place in the front row stays empty. End at the lighthouse, where somebody has to decide whether the small bell goes back on its hook, or comes home to the Lantern House.



Witch Sheet

Ratings: 3, 2, 2 and 1. Each episode: 5 Magic and no Hurt (1 Hurt with a Scar).

Name _____ **Player** _____

Power _____ **Fits (+2 dice)** _____

Surge (2 Magic, once per scene, paid before you roll) on a Partial or better: _____

_____

Life _____ **Fits (+1 die)** _____

Tie to the coven _____

Look _____

HEART · PEOPLE	WITS · NOTICING, RESEARCH	NERVE · MOVING, FIGHTING	CRAFT · SPELLS, POTIONS

Hurt ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ **Magic** ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ start with 5; no top limit

Life answered ☐ **Surge used this scene** ☐ **Scar** ☐ **Potion used this round** ☐

Critical: +1 die on my next roll ☐ **Can't cast / lose my next action (Hush, Lure)** ☐

Spells (Craft, 1 Magic). **Reveal**: a lead using Craft; a success gives 1 more Clue. **Bind** (against Defence): the threat loses its next attack. **Blast**: an attack using Craft; 1 more damage if it works. **Shelter** (Difficulty 2): until the end of the threat's next turn, one person can't be hurt by its attacks and doesn't roll to defend (it ends if you go Down). **Hide** (Difficulty 2): Exposure –1. The **Unmaking**. Any other spell: the closest one, at +1 Difficulty if it's a stretch.

Spend Magic: a spell 1 · a Surge 2 · help someone 1 · a die on your own roll 1 · lead or join the Unmaking 1. Unspent Magic is lost at the end of the episode, so spend it, but keep 2 Magic: 1 to join the Unmaking and 1 for a die or a second try.

NOTES

Down (all 4 Hurt boxes full): no actions except resting during the investigation, no potions and no Surges (others can use a potion on you), but you can still help and join the Unmaking. Back up when Hurt drops below full.

Guardian Sheet

One player may play the guardian. Ratings: 3, 2 and 2. Each episode: 5 Ward and no Hurt.

Name _____ **Player** _____

Human shape _____ **Animal shape** _____

Bound to (home) _____ **By the old promise** _____

HEART · PEOPLE	WITS · NOTICING, RESEARCH	NERVE · MOVING, FIGHTING

Hurt ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ all 5 full = Down

Ward ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ Start with 5. Help someone: 1 Ward. A die on your own roll: 1 Ward.

Shield used this round ☐ **Sense used this scene** ☐ **Down: faded back to the home** ☐

Holding: the threat's next attack targets me ☐ **Critical: +1 die on my next roll** ☐

GIFT	COST	ACTION?	WHAT IT DOES
Mend	1 Ward	Action	Clear 2 Hurt from someone it touches, itself included.
Shield	1 Ward	No action, once a round	Take an attack meant for someone near it (in a showdown, everyone is near).
Carry	1 Ward	Action	Take one person to a place it knows, such as the freed innocent out of a fight. It can't carry the coven out of a showdown or past a threat.
Sense	1 Ward	No action, once a scene	+1 die on someone else's lead this scene, outside the +2 limit.
Hold	No Ward	Action, not casting	Nerve against Defence; if it works, the threat's next attack must target the guardian.

The guardian can free and guard the innocent, study the threat and research the Book like anyone, but can't cast spells, brew or use potions, join the Unmaking or damage a threat; it can help with Ward. Under Shelter it can't Shield or Hold. Down, it fades back to the home for the rest of the scene (in a showdown, the fight), where it can't help and nobody can heal or help it; it can rest in a later scene. Unspent Ward is lost at the end of the episode.

NOTES

Episode Tracker

One per episode. Set every number at the start. Doom, Exposure and Clues start at 0.

Episode _____ **Threat** _____

Label ☐ Easy ☐ Standard ☐ Hard **Witches** _____

Doom ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5◆ ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10 ☐11 ☐12

+1 after every scene and round; nothing lowers it. ◆ **Showdown mark:** if Doom has reached 5 at the end of a scene, the threat comes to a public place, the innocent in its grip. **Full:** the innocent is lost and the threat escapes.

Exposure ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ · ☐ (cross out box 5 at Standard and Hard) **Seen** ☐

Clues needed _____ **Half (what and where)** _____ **Weakness known** ☐

Clues ○○○○○5 ○○○○○10 ○○○○○15 ○○○○○20

Defence _____ **Danger** _____ **Hit** _____ **Attacks a round** _____ **Unmaking Difficulty** _____

Threat's Toughness _____ **Broken** ☐ (Doom stops; it flees at the end of the next round)

Damage ○○○○○5 ○○○○○10 ○○○○○15

Damage ○○○○○20 ○○○○○25 ○○○○○30

Damage ○○○○○35 ○○○○○40 ○○○○○45

The innocent _____ ☐ in its grip ☐ free ☐ guarded ☐ carried ☐ lost

Potions. Write each one's kind: Healing, Blasting or Binding. The coven can have at most one per character (the guardian counts if a player plays it). They spoil at the end of the episode.

_____ _____ _____ _____ _____

Showdown ☐ hidden ☐ public **Guarded by** _____ **Sheltered** _____

Round ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ **Last hurt it** _____

Its next attack lost ☐ **Held by the guardian** ☐ **Guardian called (no guardian player)** ☐

Wild: Defence –1 this round ☐ **Veil: no Exposure this round and next** ☐

Notes _____

Quick Reference

THE ROLL

Roll dice equal to the rating. Each 4, 5 or 6 is a success. The Storyteller sets the **Difficulty** (usually 1–4, never below 1; the Unmaking can be higher).

Success: successes equal to the Difficulty or more. **Critical:** a success that shows two or more 6s. It does one thing extra: +1 damage, +1 Clue, +1 potion or –1 more Exposure, as fits; otherwise +1 die on your next roll this episode (inside the +2 limit).

Partial: at least half the Difficulty (round up), but less than all of it. It works, with a cost. (At Difficulty 1 there is no Partial.) **Failure:** fewer than that. It doesn't work, and there is a cost. **Group check:** when everyone must do the same thing, everyone rolls; it isn't an action. One cost, taken by whoever rolled worst.

COSTS

In a showdown, 1 Hurt. Otherwise, Exposure +1 if you were casting out in the city, or else 1 Hurt. **Casting** means using a Power, a spell, a potion or a guardian gift. A helper's die or Sense doesn't make your roll casting. Casting Hide never raises Exposure, so its cost is always 1 Hurt. **Spells** (Craft) cost 1 Magic; a **Surge** costs 2 Magic.

EXTRA DICE

Your Power adds 2 dice when it fits (you may leave it off; then the roll isn't casting, unless it's a spell or uses a potion). On top of that, at most **+2 dice from everything else together**: helpers (1 Magic or Ward each; helping takes no action, so anyone can help, even after acting or while Down), your Life (+1 when the Storyteller agrees it fits), the Book (+1), or your own Magic (Ward for the guardian; 1 each). Sense's die doesn't count toward the limit.

INVESTIGATION (SCENES)

Each character takes one action: follow a **lead** out in the city (Heart, Wits or Reveal against the Lead Difficulty: a success gives 1 Clue, a Critical 2, a Partial 1 with a cost); research the **Book** at home (a lead using Wits, +1 die, with no Exposure; one character per scene, who may also make one brewing roll that scene; each roll has its own result and cost); brew a potion at home; rest (clear all Hurt); cover up out in the city (Hide); or answer their **Life** (no roll; gain 1 Magic). Each witch's Life calls once per episode, and they can answer it in any scene; if they haven't by the showdown, they lose 1 Magic (or take 1 Hurt if they have none).

At the end of each scene, **Doom +1**. If Doom has reached the **Showdown mark** (5), the threat comes to the coven: a public place, with the innocent in its grip. If not, with half the Clues (rounded up) the coven knows what the threat is and where, and may go to it (this takes no scene): a hidden place, without the innocent. With all the Clues it knows the **Weakness**.

SHOWDOWN ROUND ORDER

Round 1: the threat's attacks, the characters' actions, the innocent, Exposure, Doom. **Later rounds:** the characters' actions, the threat's attacks, Exposure, Doom. In a public place, every round in which anyone was casting raises Exposure by 1 (once per round). The coven may **retreat** at the start of any round (everyone leaves together).

ACTIONS (ONE EACH, ANY ORDER, OR NOTHING)

Attack: Nerve, or Craft with Blast; a Power that fits adds 2 dice; against Defence: a success does 2 damage, a Critical 3, a Partial 1 with a cost; a Failure costs 1 Hurt.

Free the innocent: Nerve against Defence; only a success frees them (a Partial doesn't, and still costs 1 Hurt). If they're still in its grip at the end of the first round, they're lost.

Guard the innocent: until the end of the threat's next turn, if it goes for them it attacks you instead; it ends if you go Down. **Study** the threat: Wits against Defence: 1 Clue. Or **cast a spell**, or **use a gift**. **Weakness:** until the coven knows it, the threat's Defence is 1 higher. Once it knows it, attack rolls (including Blast) that work do 1 more damage; potions don't.

THE THREAT ACTS

It makes 1 attack a round against 3 characters, 2 against 4 or 5. It loses at most one attack a round. Against a coven of 3 witches and no guardian player, it has 3 more Toughness. For each attack, roll a d6:

1–3: it attacks whoever hurt it last (if nobody has, or they're Down, use 4–5).
4–5: whoever has the most Hurt marked and is still standing (ties: roll a die among them).
6: its signature move (if it has none, it attacks two different characters), but if the innocent is there and free it goes for them instead: it attacks their guard, or takes them if nobody is guarding them (taking them isn't an attack, so Hold can't stop it).

The target rolls Nerve (plus a Power that fits) against Danger: Success no Hurt, Partial 1 Hurt, Failure Hit Hurt. When its Toughness is full, it is **Broken**: it makes no more rolls or moves, Doom stops rising, and it flees at the end of the next round.

THE UNMAKING (ONLY AGAINST A BROKEN THREAT)

One standing witch leads with Craft as their action and pays 1 Magic. Every other witch may join for 1 Magic, and each one adds **2 dice**; joiners don't count toward the +2 limit. A standing witch joins as their action, so must not have acted this round; a Down witch joins without one. Difficulty: **the number of witches in the coven**, +2 without the Weakness. Only a success destroys the threat. On a Partial or Failure it isn't destroyed and nobody takes Hurt: try again next round if it's still there.

THE GUARDIAN'S GIFTS (1 WARD EACH)

Mend (action): clear 2 Hurt from someone it touches. **Shield** (no action, once a round): take an attack meant for someone near it (in a showdown, everyone is near). **Carry** (action): take one person to a place it knows; it can't carry the coven out of a showdown or past a threat. **Sense** (no action, once a scene): +1 die on someone else's lead this scene, outside the +2 limit. **Hold** (action, no Ward, not casting): Nerve against Defence; if it works, the threat's next attack must target the guardian. **No guardian player:** once per episode, on any character's turn, the coven may call it for one Mend or one Carry; calling takes no action and no roll, and counts as casting.

THE END

The episode ends at once when the threat is destroyed, flees, or Doom fills, when every witch is Down at the end of a showdown round, or when the coven retreats. **Win:** destroyed, and the innocent safe. **Partial:** it fled, or it was destroyed but the innocent was lost. **Loss:** Doom filled, every witch Down, or retreat. **Seen** drops the result one step (a Loss stays a Loss). On a retreat, or when every witch is Down, an innocent still in the fight is lost. A witch who is Down when the coven loses (except by retreating) gets a **Scar**: 1 Hurt at the start of the next episode.

NUMBERS

W = WITCHES; N = WITCHES PLUS A PLAYED GUARDIAN	EASY · STANDARD · HARD
Lead Difficulty	1 · 2 · 2
Threat Defence / Danger	1 / 1 · 2 / 3 · 2 / 3
Hit (Hurt on a failed defence)	2 · 2 · 3
Toughness	3 × w · 3 × w · 4 × w
Clues needed	3 × n · 4 × n – 1 · 4 × n
Exposure boxes	5 · 4 · 4

Quick Reference: Magic

Spells, Powers and potions; the innocent, showdown details, the tracks and seasons. The roll, the episode and the showdown are on the first quick reference page.

SPELLS (CRAFT, 1 MAGIC)

Reveal: a lead using Craft; a success gives 1 more Clue. **Bind** (against Defence): the threat loses its next attack. **Blast**: an attack using Craft; 1 more damage if it works. **Shelter** (Difficulty 2): until the end of the threat's next turn, one person can't be hurt by its attacks and doesn't roll to defend (it ends if you go Down). **Hide** (Difficulty 2): Exposure –1. The **Unmaking**. Any other spell: the closest one, at +1 Difficulty if it's a stretch.

POWERS AND SURGES

Each Power adds 2 dice when it fits. Once per scene its **Surge** (2 Magic, paid before you roll and spent even on a Failure, added to an action using the Power) does more, on a Partial or better; the whole showdown counts as one scene. A defence roll isn't an action, so it takes no Surge. Nobody Surges while Down. A **talking lead** uses Heart; a **searching lead** uses Wits.

Force (attacks, freeing): the threat loses its next attack.
Flame (attacks): 2 more damage.
Sight (leads, defending, studying): 1 more Clue; or, with no action, before the defence roll, one attack aimed at anyone misses (this isn't a lost attack).
Voice (talking leads, Hide): 1 more Clue, or Exposure –1.
Veil (defending, searching leads, Hide): no Exposure from the whole coven's casting, this roll included, for the rest of the scene, or in a showdown for this round and the next (a casting roll's cost becomes 1 Hurt).
Wild (talking and searching leads, Bind, brewing): 1 more Clue or potion; or in a showdown, the threat's Defence is 1 lower for everyone this round, after the Bind roll (never below 1).

POTIONS

Brew at home: Craft against the Lead Difficulty; a success makes two, a Critical three, a Partial one with its cost. Choose each one's kind as you make it. **Healing**: clear 2 Hurt. **Blasting**: use it with your attack; if the attack works, 2 more damage. **Binding**: use it with your attack; if the attack works, the threat loses its next attack.

Say you're using a potion before you roll; it's used up either way. Using one is casting but takes no action: while the characters act (never on the threat's turn), on yourself or someone near you; each character uses at most one a round (or scene), and an attack takes at most one potion, the attacker's own. The coven shares its potions and can have at most one per character (the guardian counts if a player plays it); extra potions from a brew are lost. They spoil at the end of the episode.

THE INNOCENT (PUBLIC SHOWDOWNS ONLY)

The threat starts with them **in its grip**. To **free** them, roll Nerve against Defence; only a success frees them (a Partial doesn't, and still costs 1 Hurt). If they're still in its grip at the end of the first round, they're lost. While in its grip they can't be guarded or carried. Once free, if the threat takes them, they're lost. A Broken threat lets go.

SHOWDOWN DETAILS

Every signature move picks only standing characters. Hold only aims attacks: on a 6, an attacking move still happens, with the guardian as its first target, and Hold is used up; any part of a move that isn't an attack (such as Lure's Heart roll) still happens, and a move with no attack leaves Hold for the next attack. A guardian under Shelter can't Shield or Hold. The Unmaking is casting: in a public place every try counts toward Exposure, even a failed one. The threat loses at most one attack a round, whatever the cause; any more are wasted. If Shield and Sight's Surge could both be used on one attack, Shield is chosen first. At the end of a round, "every witch is Down" is checked before a Broken threat flees: if both happen, it's a Loss.

TRACKS

Hurt: 4 boxes for a witch, 5 for the guardian. Full boxes = **Down**: no actions except resting during the investigation, no potions or Surges (others can use a potion on you), but you can still help and join the Unmaking; back up when Hurt drops below full. Hurt can't go past full, and it clears between episodes (except a Scar).

Magic and Ward: 5 each episode (Magic has no top limit). Unspent Magic and Ward are lost at the end of the episode.

Exposure: 5 boxes at Easy, 4 at Standard and Hard. When full, the coven is **Seen**; it stays full, and any further rise becomes **Doom +1** instead (once per round or scene). Hide can lower Exposure before then, never below 0.

Doom: 12 boxes; nothing lowers it. Reaching the mark (5) during the investigation brings the threat (checked only at the end of a scene); when full, the plan is complete: the innocent is lost (unless already carried to safety) and the threat escapes. Doom doesn't rise once the threat is Broken (not even from Seen). Extra Clues or damage past the total are lost.

SEASONS

Destroyed threats get a page in the Book: next time, start with half the Clues (rounded up). A threat that wasn't destroyed comes back later, when the Storyteller chooses, with 2 more Toughness each time. After every second episode, each witch raises one rating by 1 (most 4); the guardian doesn't grow. After the 2nd and the 4th episodes, threats also get 2 more Toughness per witch (so 4 more per witch from the 5th episode on).

Magic is real. Keep it quiet.

In the harbour city of Larkhaven, a lamp burns over the door of an old house in Old Town. The coven lives there. By day they are nurses, students, mechanics and bus drivers. By night they hunt the threat of the week: demons, spirits and stranger things, each one after someone innocent.

Follow leads, read the Book and brew potions. Face the threat with spells and your own Power, then finish it together. One player can be the guardian, a spirit bound to the house. And keep magic secret, because the city is watching.



3–5 players and a Storyteller · ages 13+ · 2–3 hours

WITCH & WARD · VERSION 0.9